

This is the copy I update every five years and send out. There may be other versions called “The Story of My Life” but I’ve gotten them mixed up, so this is the official copy.

The First Fifty-Five Years of My Life

By

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1953-1963

I started this with plans of giving it to you my children on my 50th birthday, but five years later, I'm still working on it and just turned 55. Here's how it started five years ago:

Well, I find myself turning fifty this year. It seems unbelievable that I am actually that old, but I guess it is better than the alternative. Maybe I'll write about the second half of my life when I'm getting ready to spend my one-hundredth birthday in a nursing home someplace.

Let's start at the very beginning as Julie Andrews so beautifully sings. I was born at the Naval Air Base at Chincoteague, Virginia on Sept. 18, 1953. My father, Delbert Allen Dean, was on Army recruiting duty in Michigan, and there was no nearby Army hospital, so he shipped my mother, Mary Ellen Donahoe Dean, off to her parents' home until I was born. I stayed there the first six weeks of my life and moved back to Jackson City, Michigan. Twenty-one months later, my sister, Paulette Dean was born, also in Chincoteague under similar circumstances. That is how we wound up being Southerners, not Yankees.

When I was three, Daddy was transferred to Ft. Riley, Kansas, for his first of two tours of duty there. My first memory comes from this time of my life, and it's really quite an unimpressive one. I remember my beach ball I was playing with in the yard blowing

down the street and my mother running to get it. We were only there briefly.

In 1957, we were transferred to Hawaii, where I can summon up some pretty strong memories. First we lived off-base in a house we rented from the Chang family. It wasn't the most pleasant place as I remember it, and, as Mother tells it, it is because lizards got into the house a lot. One particularly big one chased her all over the house one evening. It also was the place I almost got decapitated. (Well, maybe that's being a little dramatic.)

But those were the days that women hung clothes out to dry, and Daddy had put up a lower clothes line so Paulette and I could hang up clothes too. (Thus began my long relationship with washing clothes.) One day, however, I was running across the yard and forgot about the lower clothesline. It caught me right across the neck. It didn't do any permanent damage, but I remember it sure did take the wind out of me.

The house also had what I remember to be a huge cliff behind it leading down to a road, but I'm sure if I saw it today, I would think it was just a little hill. Maybe that's where I first started to develop my fear of heights.

Another memory from that particular house is the smell of burning plastic. Paulette and I were playing house and had cooked some pretend food in our plastic dishes but put it in the real oven. Well, Mother started to cook real food in the real oven, and our plastic dishes started burning. To this day, I cannot smell plastic burning, such as when a plastic container falls onto the coil in the dishwasher, without being taken back to that memory.

After a while, we went to live on base, which I remember as being really neat. It was a two-story, townhouse-kind-of-place with hardwood floors. Military housing and furniture was really sparse. We had a television with the requisite rabbit ears up on a wrought-iron stand that we dragged all over the world. Paulette and I had a bedroom upstairs. This proved interesting because I developed the habit of sleepwalking. One night after Paulette and I had gone to bed, Mother and Daddy looked up to see me standing at the top of the stairs sound asleep and starting to walk down. Daddy flew up the stairs to rescue me. After that, they would push my table over to block the door so I couldn't get out. (Maybe this was where I developed my claustrophobia!)

This was where I heard Santa Claus land on the roof one Christmas Eve. Yes, I realize the rumors that exist about the possibility of such an occurrence happening, but I swear I really heard it. And then the next morning there were gifts under the tree, so that sort of proves it.

I started school in Hawaii and had to ride a big military school bus to school to Wheeler Air Force Base. I don't remember how far away that was. The first day of school I wore a yellow gingham dress with a white blouse and a crinoline under it. Of course, everything at that time had to be starched and ironed, and I remember Mother saying that every time I wore that dress, I got some kind of paint on it. According to local legend, Paulette watched me get on the bus the first morning, then turned to Mother and said, "Well, let's just go in the house and cry." Her playmate was gone. In my absence, she played with a little boy in the neighborhood, and they ate scrambled eggs every morning

that my mother cooked in a small aluminum frying pan.

I don't remember much about kindergarten. I do remember a little about first grade. I moved to a brand new school. I remember the first day was really scary because I was supposed to get on the first bus in the line, so when school was out, I hurried out to the buses as fast as my chubby little legs would carry me. But every time I thought I had reached the first bus in line, there was another one ahead of that. I guess I finally found the end of the line, however, since I got home and am sitting here typing this.

I remember also the smell of rice at lunchtime when I was hungry. (We ate a lot of rice since we were in Hawaii.) And I remember learning to color pictures by covering the page with layers of colors, ending with all black, and then scraping a picture away with a pair of scissors. And that's about the extent of my first-grade memories.

Other memories from Hawaii, or at least stories that my parents told me, were when Mother told me to go invite some of my friends over for a birthday party, and I went out and invited the whole neighborhood. I think there were over 20 children there. Another time I was sick and a friend of mine, a little black girl, came over to see if I could come out and play. My mischievous father told her that I was so sick that they were going to have to shoot me. He went into the kitchen, grabbed a paper bag, blew it up, and then popped it. The little girl's eyes got wide as saucers, and she went running home. I always thought that was a pretty cruel thing to do.

We spent a lot of time at the beach, of course, and had our own special little cove we went to. It was sort of a protected little place where you could sit on the rocks and

watch the waves come in and deposit shells, then head back out to sea, leaving the shells. Paulette spied an especially pretty shell one day, and Daddy jumped down to get it. She still has it, of course. We would always lose our flip-flops to the waves and have to wait until the returning waves brought them back. I remember wondering if the same thing would happen if children washed out to sea.

One really traumatic experience for me at the beach was when I suddenly found myself surrounded by crabs on three sides of me. I was too terrified to escape through the fourth side, so I just stood there and screamed for Daddy. He came running to save me, pointing out as he did so that two of the crabs were dead. It didn't matter; they were still scary-looking.

I don't get to go to the beach much now, but I still love to see the ocean, even though it is terrifying. Crossing the ocean three times in our travels on a huge ship was especially terrifying to look out onto that big ocean and see how insignificantly small you are.

I guess that makes me afraid of water too?

Other memories are saving my one dollar allowance per month for three months to be able to buy a musical jack-in-the-box. We would get a dollar for putting away the grocery bags after our parents went to the commissary. I think that we went grocery shopping only once a month because Daddy only got paid once a month. Things were a little tight. I remember that our big splurge was to go to the Sears in Honolulu and buy a pound of chocolate-covered peanuts. I still love chocolate-covered peanuts. Back when

the Sears stores used to have candy departments in them, their chocolate covered peanuts were the best because they would double-dip them. Yummy.

That also is my earliest chocolate memory, a delectable start to a lifelong compulsion.

After three years, it was time to leave Hawaii. I have all these memories of the last night of being in Hawaii, but Mother has since told me that they didn't really occur. I remember somehow Paulette and I each got a box of four little bottles of perfume. I think that one of them must have been gardenia because I can't smell gardenias without thinking of that box of perfume. I also remember looking out a window and seeing calm water at night. My memories have interpreted that as a last midnight cruise in Hawaii, but Mother says no.

I do know sometime that happened for sure, however, and Mother remembers this too. I was extremely seasick the whole way back and did a lot of throwing up. In fact, every ocean trip I took, I spent a lot of time either in my bunk sick or throwing up.

Then, it got worse. Right before I got off the ship in San Francisco, I caught the red measles. The whole ship almost got quarantined, but my parents convinced the doctors that we were going to go straight to my aunt's and uncle's house (Alvin and Rena) in Salinas, California. So they let us go, and I remember a horrible trip to their house. I don't remember how far it was, but I remember feeling like I was burning up and suffocating. I must have had something around my neck like a scarf or something because I remember feeling like I was choking, and to this day, I cannot stand to have anything,

even a turtleneck, tight around my neck or to be in closed, stuffy places.

We spent a couple of days in Salinas, and I have one clear memory at this time. I was lying on the couch sick and everyone else was outside, grilling something I believe, when all of the sudden everything in the house starting to move. I ran outside as best as I could and found out that we were having an earthquake. I don't know how bad it was, but it was bad enough for me.

Then we made our way to our new assignment, which was right back to Ft. Riley, Kansas. This time we stayed for longer—for three years—and it was one of the places that I have my strongest and happiest childhood memories. We lived there for the second through fifth grade for me and kindergarten through second grade for Paulette.

We lived in a little pink house on Sloan Street in Manhattan, which was about 16 miles from base. When Mother and Daddy visited Manhattan again in the mid-eighties, they said it was a real ghetto, but it wasn't when we were there. When Mary Susan and I drove through on our way to Utah in 2007, it looked pretty run down, but it wasn't a ghetto. A really small house, but not a ghetto.

There was a whole neighborhood of kids to play with and families to hang out with. Across the street were Hazel and Virgil Lemon, an older couple (probably in their forties, as I think about it now) with a 20-something-year-old daughter, Shirley. They acted like our grandparents to us, and we loved them to pieces. Paulette and I were in Shirley's wedding at one point. We wore red velvet dresses with a scalloped hem and eyelet lace showing through. I was the flower girl, and Paulette was the ring bearer. I

threw red rose petals. We kept the dresses for a long time, but I think they finally deteriorated with age. (Don't we all?)

Hazel and Virgil always gave us nice presents for Christmas and our birthdays, except for the year they broke my heart and gave me a bag of nothing. Everyone thought it was funny but me. They had been asking me what I wanted for my birthday, and I kept saying "Nothing," trusting them to come up with something cool on their own and not wanting to be too demanding. They and my parents decided to trick me and brought over a big bag on my birthday. When I opened it up, full of excitement and expectation, there was just that in it—absolutely nothing. I was so heartbroken and embarrassed because I didn't know how to react. I didn't know if they were teasing or serious, so I didn't know whether to beg for my real gift or not. They did finally give me a gift, but I don't remember what it was; I just remember the bag full of nothing. That's why I don't like teasing children.

One Christmas they gave Paulette and me little pink stuffed poodles that played Brahms Lullaby. We loved to turn out the lights at night, wind those up, and listen to them until we went to sleep. I thought it was a haunting, almost scary, melody and still feel a little uneasy when I hear it. If a pink poodle ever showed up, I'd probably be afraid of that too.

We weren't able to travel to Virginia for holidays much, so Hazel and Virgil were our family away from home. During the warmer weather, we would cook out with them and other families in the neighborhood with the men taking turns cooking one holiday

and the women the next. We also would go with them to a watermelon stand in the summer in Wamego, Kansas, and get cold watermelon by the slice. We would also go to the Dairy Queen and get dipped cones. In those days, you could also get cones dipped in green topping. Paulette and I called them “snotty cones.”

Daddy would love to play a trick on Mother while he was driving and slouch down in the seat so it looked like he was a lot shorter than she was. It drove her crazy. He would also sing the only song he ever sang (with good reason; Daddy was not a singer). It was “Old Brother Bill had a still on the hill where he ran off a gallon or two.”

We also went for ice cream to John’s Dairy Bar. I hated to go in because they had a fan that would suck in the bugs and deposit them in a bag. I thought it was disgusting, especially in an eating establishment. Remember, there was very little central air, so windows were open everywhere. Mother would never go in, and Daddy would always ask her what she wanted. She would always say, “I don’t care,” and he would always get her lemon custard, which she hated. Finally, one day she told him. Why she didn’t tell him earlier and just tell the poor man what kind of ice cream she wanted, I’ll never know.

During those years, life wasn’t as dangerous for little children as it is now, so kids could leave the house in the morning and not check in until mealtime. We would make the rounds of the neighborhood. Next door to us lived the Griggs with three boys—Roy Lee, Ryan, and Scott. Across the street and down a little lived the Long family. They had four children. Johnny was the oldest, and Paulette had an on again/ off again love affair going with him. The parents were Diane and Bill. I loved to play with their baby girl, but

she wasn't always the cleanest little baby, so if she was dirty, I would ask Diane to clean her up before I would watch her. Diane wasn't the best housekeeper either. They raised Brittany spaniels and kept them in a big wooden pen on legs in the backyard. That was our wagon when we played cowboys and Indians, but most of the time, the whole yard smelled awful.

One indication of Diane's housekeeping abilities was that if one of their puppies died, she would wrap it up and put it in the refrigerator until they could take it over to Kansas State veterinary school for the students to examine. (She also put the end of my cut off finger in the refrigerator in case we could sew it back on, but that story comes later.)

One day the whole neighborhood was in an uproar because their little son Scott disappeared. He could climb over the fence and escape pretty fast. Right behind their row of houses was a huge field (probably not as huge as I remember) and a railroad track, so our first concerns were about Scott getting hit by a train. After the whole neighborhood searched for him, however, Diane found him peacefully sleeping under his bed, oblivious to what he had put his family and friends through.

Paulette and I could also take off on our bicycles and ride over to our school, Northview Elementary School, to play. That was about a mile away. We would pack a peanut butter and jelly sandwich, play a little, take a break for lunch, play some more, and come home. I remember it being awfully hot, and I don't remember what we drank because that was before the days of aluminum drink cans and plastic bottles.

We do laugh about the time that we were in a summer play camp and were making candles one day. We stood in this long line until we reached the pot of wax, dipped our candles, and rejoined the line. It didn't seem like much fun. Then we remember the day we had had to take a laxative the night before and started off to day camp. We didn't get very far on our bicycles before we had to turn around and head back home.

Other fun things were the neighbor fights we were always having. With so many kids in the neighborhood, we were constantly dividing up into groups and planning wars against each other. We'd throw mud balls across the fences and plan how to make catapults out of trees, but I don't think we ever got very far. I do remember being pretty stupid one time and getting so mad at Roy Lee Griggs that I kicked him with my bare feet. I wound up with several sprained toes and never tried that again. We also would plan tree houses and clubhouses we were going to build. We never got very far on that either because no one ever seemed to be able to come up with anyone who had any wood or know-how.

We had a lot of fun connected to the Army also. "Organization Days" were especially fun, where everyone sort of showed off. There were parades out in the hot Kansas sun, different kinds of races, good food, and all kinds of tanks to crawl all over. I even remember getting to drive a tank for a little ways.

Daddy was a first sergeant so he had a degree of clout in his company. One of our favorite Christmas decorations growing up came from that clout. The poor little privates

and other low-ranking people in his company were not allowed to have Christmas decorations in the barracks during the Christmas season. Daddy went through one time and found a PFC (private first class) with a cheap little Christmas band. (Those of you who are reading this and care at all will know the band I am talking about—you now each have a member of it.) Daddy absolutely reduced the private to tears and then had the audacity to “confiscate” his illegal, and tacky, decoration. He brought it home to us, and it has been part of our Christmas traditions to this day. Daddy used to love to set it up for the grandchildren every Christmas and see if he could make them believe that the band actually played. Most of the time, while they were little, he was quite successful. One time he even put a radio in the drawer underneath the band and tuned it so it was playing Christmas music so softly that you could barely hear it. That worked and brought a smile of wonderment and incredulity to the eyes of whichever child it was until the radio went to a commercial and Daddy was found out.

We also went to a great school that gave us plenty of opportunities for fun. Mother was quite active in the PTA and was even one of the stars in the play Oklahoma the PTA put on. It was during the time of the performances that I got the mumps and was heartbroken that I was going to miss the performance. (The mumps were horrible; thank goodness there is now a vaccine for them. You got all swollen up on the side of your neck, and if you moved your head it hurt like heck. Everyone kept telling me not to hang my head over or it would be agony. So, of course, I had to do it. I leaned over the side of the bed, and it was agony.)

Back to the subject. So my mother was in this play, and I had the mumps. And I had a crush on the principal who was also in the play. There was some reason Daddy couldn't babysit the night of the play, so Mother took me to the library at school (where she also volunteered and taped the spines of books with thick gray tape) and made me a bed on the floor. There I lay swollen and heartbroken. But, wait, it gets worse.

Then Mother arranged for the principal to come back in costume and see me before the play began. I'm sure I was delirious with fever, but the most intelligent thing I could think of to say was "You look funny!" He leaned over and said right back to me, "You look funny, too!" I was crushed. I lay on my lonely bed the rest of the evening, cast aside and insulted. (Maybe that's being a little dramatic, but it was traumatic enough for me to remember it to this day.)

One nice memory of Kansas is our Sunday dinners. Every Sunday after church at Blue Valley Methodist Church, Daddy would grill steaks and fry homemade French fries. We would also have huge glasses of iced tea. It was so good. One particular Sunday stands out when our neighbor next door was playing her music too loudly. Houses were real close together, and we had asked her to turn it down several times before, but she wouldn't. So Daddy put our little stereo pointed out our back door towards hers and turned it up as loud as it went, blasting out "Mule Skinners Blues" from some awful country record he had. We didn't have any more trouble after that.

Another memory of Kansas actually has something to do with a national crisis. It was the Bay of Pigs crisis when President Kennedy sent warships down to Cuba and told

them they had to remove the Russian missiles from their island or be attacked. (For further or more accurate details, read a history book.) What I remember about it most is that Daddy was “on alert,” which in the military means that they have to be ready to ship about at a moment’s notice. This was such a crisis that Daddy was supposed to stay home and wait for a call. During that time he built the bookcase/entertainment center that my parents used for years. I don’t remember why that stands out so much in my memory, except that maybe it was a scary time for us and one of the first times I was aware of something going on in the nation, especially something that affected me.

That reminds me of something else scary—tornadoes. We were never really in any, but we sure were in a lot of tornado alerts. We regularly had tornado alert practices in school where we had to go into the hallway and sit down with our arms crossed behind our bowed heads. Then I remember several nights that Mother came and woke us up and took us down the street to a neighbor who had a basement. I still think that one day I am going to actually experience a tornado.

That reminds me of another scary experience that happened one time while Daddy was “in the field”—a military term for going out someplace in the wild and playing soldier on maneuvers. We were having a terrible thunderstorm, and Mother had gotten up for some reason. She noticed that our car lights were on and a door was opened, which scared her to death. Evidently someone had sought shelter from the storm in our car. She didn’t call any neighbors, which they fussed with her afterwards for, but she woke me up and told me to call someone if she didn’t come back in soon. She went outside to shut the

door, and whoever had been in the car was gone, thank goodness. Pretty scary to a young girl wondering if she was going to see her mother killed.

My worst memories of Kansas actually happened toward the very end of our life there. I suppose we already knew where we were going to be stationed next. That was always an exciting time—waiting for your daddy’s orders to come. We had found out that we were going to be moving to Baumholder, Germany in the fall. I remember the evening we found out we sat on the curb out front and told all of our friends and joked about moving to a place that “holds bombs.” True to form, I also remember what we ate for supper that night. It was pancakes. I just loved it when we had pancakes for supper, and I think I had eaten about eight of them. (That could explain my rapidly growing waistline in my pictures about that time.)

It was in the summertime, which was very hot in Kansas. Back in those days, the 60’s, no one had central air conditioning, but if you were lucky you had a window unit, maybe even in a couple of rooms. We had one in the living room. It cooled off the living room, but also made it so that you couldn’t hear anything going on outside. So Mother and Daddy were sitting in the living room unable to hear anything from the outside while Paulette and I went over to the Lemons to roller skate on their patio. (Roller skates back then screwed onto your shoes with a strap around your ankle and were infamous for falling off as you dragged them with the strap still around your ankle to someplace where you could re-screw them).

Anyway, Hazel and Virgil were gone, and Paulette and I were skating when I saw

one of their folding lawn chairs that had fallen down. I went over to pick it up but slipped on my skates, and it collapsed catching my ring finger in one of the joints. There was a lot of blood, and I guess I realized I had hurt myself badly. I yelled at Paulette to go get Mother and Daddy, and she took off, dragging a skate by the ankle, screaming, and crying. With the air conditioning on, they didn't hear for a while, but when they did, Mother called Diane to come get Paulette, and Daddy threw me into the car for the long ride to the base hospital.

It wound up that I had cut about half an inch of my finger off and wasn't supposed to even ever have a nail again, but I did. I remember losing a lot of blood because I almost passed out when I went to the rest room. The worst part (and I hate to even think about this) was when I went back a few days later and had to get the stitches out. The skin had grown over the stitches and two different times they dug through that tender flesh to get to them. I had my face in Daddy's stomach and just screamed. He was crying too. I don't know why they didn't numb it. Of course, I remember eating corn on the cob with Daddy at the mess hall before we went over to the hospital.

This happened in July, I believe. I remember closely watching the election of some pope on television and taking care of my pet horned toad. Yes, horned toad. I had friends up the street who had it, and they let me take it home to ask Mother if I could have it. While I was gone, and while she was saying no, they packed up their moving van and moved. The toad was so gross and it was so hard to feed with my finger bandaged that Daddy went and let it out in a cornfield.

Remember Diane?—The one who would put dead puppies in her refrigerator. Well, good friend that she was, she went over to the patio and found the end of my finger, wrapped it up, and kept it in the fridge in case the doctors wanted to sew it back on.

My woes weren't over with. I was still all bandaged and wearing a sling because it hurt terribly if I put my arm down when we had a going-away cookout at Hazel's and Virgil's before we left a couple of weeks later. Paulette and I were walking around the house and looking at the pile of sand and cement that was left over from some building project of Virgil's. I was barefoot, and I walked over to sink my feet into the pile of cement that I imagined would be so cool. Instead it turned out the pile was the pile of hot coals that Virgil had just emptied from the grill. It immediately burned the soles of both of my feet. No one really knew what to do for bad burns. Hazel poured vanilla extract over them, which I had never, and still haven't, heard of as a burn remedy.

Anyway, as we traveled to Virginia a few days later, I had blisters all over my feet and had to be carried into the restaurants and motels. I remember especially Daddy carrying me into one restaurant and plopping me down at a booth where Paulette and I looked through the little music things on the table and chose to listen to "Big Girls Don't Cry" on the jukebox. It was the original hit, not a golden oldie, at that time.

Back then, of course, there were no McDonald's or Wendy's or any other franchises across country so you ate at Mom and Pop restaurants and sort of took your chances at whether the food was good or not. Paulette ate grilled cheese sandwiches, Mother liked BLT's or club sandwiches, and Daddy said you could never go wrong with

hamburger steak. I don't remember what I got routinely.

Regardless, however, of my bad luck of the last few weeks of my life in Kansas, I have wonderful memories of it. We went back again to see Hazel and Virgil after we came home from Germany, but by that time they had moved to Topeka. I don't remember if we visited Manhattan. Then Gene and I stopped in Kansas and spent the night with them on our honeymoon, basically mooching off of them. But I haven't been back since, even though I've always wanted to.

One last thought on Kansas. It was where I learned to be terrified of grasshoppers and crickets. The grasshoppers in Kansas are huge and have these sticky legs, so they would jump on you when you were outside playing, and it was so hard to get them off. Then I learned to hate crickets when I tried to step on one and kill it when I was getting my bike off the porch one day. It just wouldn't die. Then it just stayed all squashed on the porch forever for me to see every day. I just learned to hate them and never got over it.

On to Germany with a stop in Virginia . . .

1963-1966

Daddy left for Germany in August by plane, but in those days, the dependents mostly traveled overseas by ship, so Mother, Paulette, and I stayed with my grandparents in Danville for two months until we were to leave in October. It was the year I was in the fifth grade, so I wound up going to three different schools that year. That was miserable.

We started school at Forest Hills Elementary School, which, in the days before

integration, was full of rich kids. I was a chubby girl with glasses who was a nobody, and they treated me that way. I remember sitting at lunch one day when the kids were quizzing me on how much I weighed. Needless to say, I hated school there.

It was nice being with my grandparents, though. I really, really loved my grandfather, Dada (Paul Riley Kidd Donahoe). He had retired from the civil service before they had moved to Danville to be next to my Uncle Joe and Aunt Nancye and their two sons, Harper and Stephen. Paulette adored Stephen, and I adored Harper and loved it when they came over.

Dada always smelled like Old Spice and wintergreen Lifesavers. He was an organist for First Christian Church, and I would go with him when he practiced on Saturday mornings. He would also teach me piano lessons, but since I wasn't there for long, nothing ever came out of it. After practice, we would walk down the Five Forks gas station on Jefferson and buy a "Coke-cola." (That's how the real Southerners say it.) My grandmother only bought Pepsis, but Dada liked Cokes. I don't know whether she refused to buy them because he liked them, or whether he liked them because she bought Pepsis. He was the only person in the family who called me by a nickname, and I always thought that was special. He called me "Suki."

Years later, in 1980, when he was close to death in a nursing home and didn't recognize anyone, Mother and I took a hot dog over to him. The last thing he said to me was when he looked over at me and said, "Thank you, Suki." I don't think he had called me that for years.

My grandmother and I never really got along very well. I found her to be a very stern and inflexible woman, even though the example of reading her Bible every night caused me to start reading mine. She took excellent care of my Uncle Billy, who had Down Syndrome, but I always thought she ignored my granddaddy a little in the process. She had a schedule for everything and a place for everything and she was always confident in what she did and who she was. She wasn't a small woman, and I remember her distinctly saying, "I'm proud to weigh 225 pounds, and I wished I weighed more." I also remember her saying one dinner that the hardest thing a person would ever have to face was the fact that he or she had a mentally retarded child. I remembered that always, almost like a premonition that I indeed would have that experience one day.

One thing I do wish is that my refrigerator could be as organized and neat as hers. There was a place for everything and heaven help anyone who moved it out of place. I still feel guilty if my orange juice is in front of the milk in my refrigerator.

So we were there for September and October, and one memory I have is how hot it was back during the days of no air conditioning in homes. Mama and Dada had one big fan in the living room, and you had to try to sit somewhere where you could feel it. Then at night, you would lie in front of an open window, sweating in your thin cotton nightgown and just praying for a breeze or a thunderstorm to cool things off. You would also keep turning your pillow over to find a cooler side. Finally, you would manage to fall asleep, only to wake up later in the night shivering because you had fallen asleep with damp clothes and now it was cool. Going to stores was fun, though, because they had air

conditioning. It was so much fun to walk into a store and feel that rush of cool air, yet the opposite experience when you had to walk out into the heat and humidity, get into a car with no air conditioning, and drive to a home without any either. This generation just doesn't know how lucky it is.

Even though my grandfather played at First Christian Church, they were members at Mt. Vernon Methodist Church. Mama would never be anything but a Methodist since her father-in-law had been a Methodist minister. Joe, Nancye, and the boys, however, attended West Main Baptist Church, Joe having followed Nancye into the Baptist faith when they married. Mt. Vernon was a nice place to go to church because of the beautiful stained glass windows and whole reverential atmosphere that pervaded the congregation because of the raised pulpit, smooth wooden pews, and plush carpeting. I don't remember having any particular problems with the doctrine at that time.

Mostly I worried about my Daddy who didn't seem to be a particularly religious person. My parents had always taken us to church, and my mother had even taught junior Sunday School. We said our prayers at night, just "Now I Lay Me Down to Sleep" with a couple of added "God bless so-and-sos," but we weren't really taught any doctrine of any church, and religion was mostly something we did on Sunday, although we were always taught to treat others kindly, to be honest, and the Ten Commandments.

In October, finally, we got our orders to go to Germany to meet Daddy via a big ship sailing out of New York City. We knew we weren't going to be seeing our grandparents for three years. We wouldn't even be talking to them because back in those

days long distance calling was prohibitive for people living on retirement pay and on military pay. Plus, there was no email and no instant messaging. So we knew that for three years we would be looking forward to letters and only letters. Dada would write us letters in his beautiful cursive handwriting of another age, and Mama would write in her sprawling handwriting that went everywhere. But it was always a special day when we got a letter in the mail.

I don't remember much about the trip across the ocean except that it took ten days, and we were the first ship carrying military dependents to get caught in a hurricane. (I'm sure it was just the outskirts of one.) I do remember being extremely seasick as usual and doing a lot of throwing up. The bad thing about the bathrooms in a ship that increases your nausea is that the water that is used in the toilets and sinks smells like rotten apples. So if you go in sick, you get even sicker smelling the bathroom.

We had to share a cabin with a single woman who was going to meet her husband. The thing I remember about her is that she had had her foot run over by a car at some point in her life. That seems weird now sharing a small, cramped cabin with a perfect stranger with a deformed foot.

There were organized play groups that Paulette and I attended. I remember seeing the movie "Old Yeller" and being upset about that. And I remember that Mother spent her time ironing. She was the only person on the ship who signed up for the ironing room every day. Thank goodness I was born a generation later with permanent press clothes!!

I was disappointed that we passed through the English Channel during the night

and didn't get to see the White Cliffs of Dover, even though I don't think I knew at the time exactly what they were. We docked in the morning in Bremerhaven, Germany, on the north coast of Germany, only to find out that an alert had been declared all over Germany, and all the men were unable to leave their posts. So we faced having to get down to Baumholder in southwest Germany without Daddy.

So the three of us traveled on a train to somewhere with no idea of how we were going to get from there to Baumholder. I made my first contact with Germans and learned that they combined the salt and pepper in the shakers. (What if you didn't like pepper?)

When we got to wherever, being a little dramatic at that particular time in my life, I got off the train, put down my violin, threw out my arms, and questioned the universe, "Daddy, Daddy, wherefore art thou, Daddy?" (A foreshadowing, I suppose, of my further love of literature. That's Shakespeare, if you didn't recognize it.) I then turned around, and there was Daddy! He had somehow gotten permission to meet us at the train station. Mother was so glad to see him after being away from him for so long and making that long trip without him.

The first place that we lived was in Strassberg Kaserne about 20 miles from Baumholder. It was temporary housing, so we knew we were only going to be there a few months until permanent housing opened up at Baumholder. I remember it fondly now, even though I think Mother hated every minute of it. I had a teacher that I really didn't like—a big, scary black man named Mr. Rice. But I also fell in love with Hank Bryan that year, which was to last for the next two years. We also had lots of friends to play with,

and everything about Germany was new and exciting.

I remember getting to Strassberg Kaserne so clearly. Daddy had unpacked our dolls. Yes, fifth-grade girls still played with dolls in those days. And it was so much fun seeing them again after being away from them for so many months. We had big closets with wide shelves and wide drawers that pulled out, and he had put our toys and things in those. Paulette and I shared a room, of course, which was what we did until we moved to California in 1966. There is a feeling about those days at Strassberg Kaserne I can still feel when I think about it.

Then we went down a couple of blocks to the Snack Bar where there was a mini-commissary and a great snack bar. They had the best hamburgers in the world. I've never tasted a better one. Michael would love them! They were fried like places used to do and then mashed down with the spatula. Then the cooks would slap the buns down on top of them to warm the buns and squash the buns down with the greasy spatula. Then they would top the burgers with tomato, lettuce, mayonnaise, and ketchup and served them with fat, crinkly fries. Squeeze a generous amount of ketchup on your fries out of a greasy red plastic ketchup bottle, and it was good eating!

Strassberg Kaserne was next to the town of Ider-Oberstein, a small little town that was famous for its Church in the Rocks. It was a church, or small cathedral, I can't remember how big it was, but it had supposedly been built on the sight of where some prince or someone had thrown himself off a cliff because of a lost love or something. (As you can see, the details are sketchy.) Anyway, it was neat to drive by it and look up at it.

Some time later, we even walked up to it with our church youth group, but it was closed when we got up there.

I don't think I was very happy in school. Mr. Rice was such a strict teacher that he didn't even let you have a drink of water from the water fountain unless he gave permission at an appointed time and you weren't allowed to put your feet in the aisle outside your desk. He also was very strict about margins on papers and would hold your paper up to the light to see if there was any writing outside the margin lines. If there was, you would have to do the whole paper over. It made me quite paranoid. Having always been a model, well-behaved student, I was also mortified to have to stay after school because, while my class was marching out to go home one day, I was so thirsty that I glanced behind me and, not seeing Mr. Rice watching, I stopped to get a quick sip of water. "Dean!" he hollered from where he had been watching us from the corner. "Get back here!" I had to stay after school, and I cried and cried about it.

My grades also suddenly dropped from A's to a C on my report. This made Mother very angry, and she marched to the principal's office, threw my past report cards on his desk, and demanded to know why her A student was suddenly getting C's. Evidently the principal talked to Mr. Rice because things got a little easier after that.

Our apartment building was right across from the school, and, during my unhappiest times there, I would look longingly over to the window of our apartment and wish I were home.

We used to go home for lunch, and I remember Mother would make me one of

my favorite meals—browned hamburger over mashed potatoes. She had lots of time on her hands then. We had no television, and the apartment was not very big so it didn't take long to clean it every day, even though she thoroughly cleaned it every day. (Until she was about 60, my mother dusted and vacuumed the whole house every day and cleaned the bathroom, including the bathtub and mopping the floor. She also had all the dirty laundry done at the end of every day. Imagine having someone like that coming to visit you.)

Mother did have friends and spent time coffee-ing with them. We had traveled across the ocean with the women in the Saner family, which included a mother and three daughters. They would later live in the building across from us down the hill in Baumholder.

Since we didn't have a television, we did a lot of activities together as a family. We played a lot of Scrabble and went for a lot of walks. We also did a lot of reading. The kaserne had a great library down the street, and Paulette and I would trudge down the street with our armload of books to refill them every week.

We also went to the movies it seems like every Saturday. Back then, movies cost a quarter, and for another nickel you could buy a bag of popcorn or potato chips. I remember seeing the Beatles movie "It's Been a Hard Day's Night" and the movie about the Lippazano stallions. I remember that movie especially because I got butter from my popcorn on my glasses and couldn't get them cleaned during the whole movie.

Actually I think I saw the stallion movie on a Saturday night when Paulette went

to a Cub Scout banquet with a little boyfriend of hers. It was actually her first date. A little early, don't you think? All I had was the unrequited love of Hank Bryan. Although it was the first night she was introduced to bleu cheese dressing, which was not a pleasant experience for her, so maybe my night was better.

In fact, let me tell you a thing or two about my little sister. She did a lot better at moving around than I did. She would move into a school and immediately have a boyfriend, or two or three, and be running for school president. She would always have tons of friends and be at home wherever she was. I, on the other hand, took a year to get settled into a place and find friends. In fact, it seemed like as soon as I got happy in a new home, it was time to move. Fifth and eighth grades were particularly miserable for me as was my first year in college. It's a wonder I love Paulette as much as I do at this stage in my life!!

We both agree, however, that our first year in Germany was great. Mother disagrees, but that just shows you how different perspectives can be. I'll give her version after Paulette's and mine.

The Germans really celebrate Christmas on December 6th. That's when Kris Kringle comes and puts treats in your shoes outside the door. (Why would anyone want to eat candy out of a shoe?) I don't know how Mother and Daddy arranged it, but our shoes actually got filled with candy outside our door. I think one of the neighbors came and did it, but I've always wondered.

Then there were the different Christmas decorations and lights of Germany, which

were delightful the first year. Paulette and I also remember the first year in Germany as the “Year of the Bath Oil Beads.” We discovered the little, brightly colored gel balls that enclosed this awful-smelling bath oil. They were pretty in their plastic cylindrical containers, and we thought everyone should have some. We gave them to everyone! (Did I mention they were cheap, too, at the PX?) They were the perfect Christmas gift that became our standard in the coming years. Bath oil beads, in fact, made a comeback several years ago and just smelling them put Paulette and me back into Germany that first snowy, magical Christmas.

Mother, however, in a healthy dose of reality, remembers that we moved to permanent housing on their anniversary, December 21st, and Daddy got furious because the clothes hangers got all tangled up. She also remembers that my uncle, who was stationed a few hours ago in Ulm, his wife, and their drunken bachelor friend, came to spend Christmas with us. She was so upset when Daddy had to get up Christmas morning and wake the hungover friend up before we could come out and see what Santa Claus had brought us.

Paulette and I prefer to remember our version of that first Christmas in Germany!!

On to permanent housing in Baumholder. . .

Our apartment house, or quarters as the Army calls them, was an interesting place. It was a bunch of buildings going down a hill with I think four rows of apartment buildings and the elementary school up to the fourth grade down on the bottom street.

Each building had three stairwells with eight apartments, four on each side. (Can you picture that?) Anyway, we lived on the fourth floor. That was a long way to climb for three years. It gave a whole new meaning to running out to the car for something you've forgotten.

If you were standing in front of the building looking at it, we had a street to the right and on the other side of that a farm. That could really get smelly because the German farmers used real live manure as fertilizer. They would bring it on what were called "honey wagons" and, boy, you knew the days the honey wagons came.

Behind our building was a long hill starting from the left at almost the level of our windows and sloping down around the end of our building. That was some really good sledding in the winter. If you started at the top of the hill and came down that hill, you would fly over a smaller hill at the end of the building, hit the street, and, if the streets were icy as they usually were, sled on down the street to the last street on the hill. We spend a lot of time doing that in the winters, which usually had a lot of snow.

One time Daddy came sledding with us and had me lie down on top of him on the sled. We came all the way down the big hill, but when we hit the smaller one, I went up in the air, then Daddy did, then Daddy came down, and then I came down hard on him. It wound up spraining or cracking his ribs, I don't remember which one. I just remember he was in enough pain to go to the doctor. When he told the doctor what happened, the doctor laughed and said that he wasn't going to put down what really happened to him; he was going to put down that Daddy slipped on the ice taking the garbage out.

The hill behind the house also sloped down to the back of the building, and during the summertime we would have wonderful cookouts with the people in our building. The men would bring their grills out and stand together telling jokes while the women would sit together (I don't remember on what) and talk about what women always talk about. We kids would play on the hill, rolling down it until we were dizzy and itchy from the grass, then claw our way back up the steep hill to roll down again.

Behind us on the hill was a big brick building where Mother worked, actually volunteered, at a place called Family Aid Services. They would collect household supplies for families who had moved in and hadn't gotten their "household goods" yet. My most outstanding memory of that place was one afternoon when I was helping pack canned goods in boxes and Daddy's colonel's wife, who also happened to be pregnant, bent over the box. I picked that particular time to drop a can of food on her head. Mother was mortified, and I felt really bad.

Up the street from that building was the officers club. We weren't allowed in there, of course, but it was fun to watch it the night it caught on fire. I think it did major damage to the roof, but didn't burn down. I remember too that they eventually opened a little fast food window on the side and anyone could go and order food from there. The last day of school in the seventh grade, when I was so sad we would be leaving Germany, I went up there and ordered a big order of French fries all wrapped in aluminum foil. (Maybe that was the start of my emotional eating Dr. Phil accuses me of.) The thing I remember hating about walking up to the officers club was that there were always

squashed frogs on the road. That's a real juxtaposition of memories, if you ask me.

I finally got happy in school again. In January, after we moved the Baumholder, I started school in nearby Neubrucke in a hospital on an Air Force base. The elementary school only had room for up to the fourth grade, so they shipped the fifth and sixth grades 16 miles away on a great big brown Army bus. We were schooled in a wing of the hospital. It was two floors high and had two classrooms on each end separated by what I remember as a long hallway. For lunch, part of the time we ate at the officers club and another part we ate at long tables set up in a hallway. I don't remember which came first. All I remember are the great big canned peas the Army fed us that the boys would stick in their straws and blow across the tables. When we ate in the officers club, I remember I used to take my lunch in a metal lunch box. There was a particular smell of opening up that metal box and catching whiff of a bologna sandwich on white bread with lettuce and mayonnaise. If I ever smelled that again, I would instantly transported back to that time in my life.

For recess we played in a huge field next to the school. I think it was mostly organized activities. The most wonderful time was in the springtime when the weather finally warmed up and thousands of daisies would bloom. The girls would make long daisy chains or pluck the petals off and play "loves me, loves me not." During the winter we would have phys ed in a gym close by the field. That could prove embarrassing at times. You see, girls were not allowed to wear pants to school then, so on phys ed days girls were supposed to bring a pair of pants to wear under their skirts. If you forgot to

bring a pair of pants, you had to get in the last row and hope that the boys couldn't see your underwear when you exercised. I remember the embarrassment of having to wish that on at least one occasion.

I fell in love seriously for the first time while going to school there. Plus, a boy fell in love seriously with me. Unfortunately, it wasn't the same boy I had fallen in love with. I fell in love with Donald Carmouche, and Steve Potratz fell in love with me. Donald was a couple of inches (or perhaps feet) shorter than I was with a dark butch cut. I don't exactly know what attracted me to him. Steve was taller than I was and really, really nice. Steve had something wrong with his lip, so part of his lip on one side hung down a little bit. He also owned a real nice pigskin leather jacket, and on the mornings when we had to wait outside on the basketball court before we could go inside, he would let me wear it if it was cold.

Donald left during the school year of the sixth grade, and what an unhappy day that was. I remember we sang "The Red River Valley" as sort of a good-bye to him—"From this valley they say you are going / I will miss your bright eyes and sweet smile / For they say you are taking the sunshine / That has brightened my pathway a while." I knew I was singing it to him, and my heart broke.

He came to see me and tell me good-bye when they were staying on post the night before they left. He also brought me about 500 of his Superman, Batman, and similar other comic books. We later sold them before we left, but if we had only foreseen eBay, we could probably have made some money off of those babies. He also kissed me good-

bye, and I think that was my first kiss. And it had to come from someone who had to stand on tiptoe to reach me!

After that, I concentrated on Steve. At least until seventh-grade came along.

One more word about the sixth grade. I had a great teacher named Miss Hartman. She was really tall, about six feet tall, and she was in the play *Oklahoma*, produced there on base. I went to see it at least twice and fell in love with the guy who played the main guy character. (I fell in love a lot back then, I guess.) I just always liked her because I knew she had been around him.

I also faked my way into the school chorus. I never have had a very good voice, but if the range is okay and not too high, I can sing okay. Luckily, when it was time to try out for the chorus, the song we were all singing was “Dominique” from *The Singing Nun*. The teacher went around and listened to all of us, and I must have sounded okay because I made the chorus. After that, I got in a little over my head and didn’t do very well when we sang songs that were high. I guess it was my punishment for getting into the chorus under false pretenses.

On to seventh grade, Mike Ray’s blue eyes, a failed writing attempt, and a cool science teacher . . .

For the seventh grade, I attended Baumholder High School, which was on a hill across the town from where we lived. It was a lot shorter bus ride, and it had seventh through twelfth grades. Even though I was just a lowly seventh-grader, I felt like I was in high school and watched the older kids from afar with awe. Watching *Grease* is like

remembering back to those days with full skirts and bouffant hairstyles.

I loved seventh grade. I met a guy named Jim Robertson whose father was in the Air Force, and another girl and I shared lockers with him. He took shop class, so for a long time we had a big pile of sawdust in the bottom of our locker. He was friends with another Air Force brat, Mike Ray, who had the prettiest blue eyes you've ever seen—until I had two blue-eyed babies and married blue-eyed David. He also had acne, and back then you couldn't do much about that but look past it to his blue eyes. He never really had much to do with me until a party we went to at my best friend's house. Her name was Cindy Something, and we had a party up in the attic of her building, and we played post office and spin the bottle, pretty daring games for those times. I think Mike at some point was forced to kiss me. I like to remember so anyway!

Cindy was a good friend of mine, even though I knew her only one year, I believe. The thing I remember most about her is that I went to see the movie *Fail Safe* with her, which scared me to death about nuclear bombs, and I went home with her the afternoon of the party, and she ate a big chunk of raw hamburger. I hardly ever look at raw hamburger without thinking about Cindy. She also had said that it had taken her two hours the night before to clean the bathroom, which I thought must have been extraordinarily dirty, and made me a little afraid to spend the night with her. Mother later said if she had known that it would take two hours to clean their bathroom, I would have never been able to spend the night there.

European Vacations

Of course, we had some really cool vacations living in Europe. Then we had some that I'm sure I remember as being cool, but Mother probably doesn't. One of those might be the camping trip we took to Holland. Mother hated to camp, and we just happened to pitch our tent one night at the bottom of a hill. There was a huge rainstorm during the night, so we woke up (what little we slept!) basically floating in a puddle. Everything was soaked! Daddy kept telling us not to touch the side of the tent because it was waterproof until you touched it. Did we listen? No. I think we packed up pretty quickly and headed for home, eating only licorice candy for breakfast. I do remember the night before that we had some really good meat grilled on the little grill we brought with us. That was also the evening that Mother tripped over the tent peg, and Daddy yelled at her, and so she wasn't very happy at all that evening. Hmmm . . . I'm thinking that that wasn't such a cool vacation after all.

One thing that was fun was that we got to take a ferry ride across some body of water to the island of Marken. It was restored to be an old Dutch village with people wearing wooden shoes and in the native dress. We visited one home that was open, and I remember the woman was cooking a big pot of cabbage. Boy, that smelled awful! It almost made me sick. I remembered that years later when I was a married student at BYU and one of the missionaries who baptized me came to visit me in married housing while I was cooking a big pot of cabbage (it was cheap, and I was pregnant and craving it), and I

wondered if they were getting sick from the odor. I kept apologizing and apologizing.

We did take one better vacation down in Austria with Uncle Alvin and Aunt Rena. It was another camping trip, but I think the weather was better. We pitched our tents at the bottom of these beautiful Alpine mountains, and the camp had a babbling brook running through it. I don't remember how long we stayed there, but one evening I put a little can of apricot nectar in the stream to chill overnight, and the next morning went and pulled it out of the chilly water. Standing at the foot of the mountain early on that clear, cold morning and drinking my juice that was almost too cold to drink, I was almost overcome by the beauty of nature. It remains one of the most beautiful sights I've ever seen and an enduring memory of the beauty of God's creation.

We also went up in a cable car to the top of a humongous mountain. I think it was the Zugspitze. I don't remember being terrified in the cable car, although I can't imagine why I wouldn't have been, but I do remember being terrified when we got to the top and only a railing separated us from plunging down to our deaths. I was glad to get back down the mountain. We also went to visit a beautiful lake whose name I can't remember and King Ludwig's Neuschwanstein Castle, which was absolutely magnificent.

Unfortunately, color photography either wasn't invented or wasn't affordable at that time, so all we have are black-and-white photos of the trips. If you would like to see the castle, however, let me refer you to the Web site at www.germanworld.com/neu.htm.

One trip Paulette and I took that wasn't fun was to visit my aunt and uncle. I don't think we wanted to go, but in Paulette's and my eternal quest to please everyone, we

went. It was so-o-o-o-o boring. (How boring was it?) There was no TV on the base as I remember, so there was really not much for us to do hour after hour. Our aunt wasn't too talkative, we didn't have a car during the day, and at time our uncle cooked everything in beer. I think he cooked himself in beer after dinner. At some point in his life about that time—I don't remember if it was when we were there or not—he got drunk enough one night to pull his own aching tooth out with a pair of pliers and wrench.

They were really wonderful people, though. After they retired from the Army, they went to live in California where Alvin did beautiful woodworking. (My stool, the cradle, Paulette's plant stand, and Mother's clock are all works from his hands.) Rena became sick with something, and Alvin took care of her for 15 years. Rena died at the end of 2003, and Alvin came to visit us. It was wonderful seeing him. He looked so much like Daddy it was painful. He was still very tearful about Rena. He later sent me a piece of a Christmas cactus that had come over on the boat with the Read side of our family about 1850. I hope to see him again and to take Brady up to Michigan where he plans to move after Brady gets off his mission because Brady has an interest in woodworking.

Probably our best vacation was to West Berlin the Thanksgiving of 1965, I believe. We ate Thanksgiving in the mess hall before we left on the train. Daddy was a feared first sergeant at that time which was evident when the gravy was left off of Mother's food. Daddy held up the tray, snapped his fingers, and immediately a private showed up to obey. Daddy said (I'm sure politely), "She needs some gravy." The plate was back in minutes swimming in gravy.

We traveled by train to West Berlin, which was an overnight trip. It was a lot of fun sleeping on a train overnight. West Berlin, for those deficient in history, was in the middle of communist East Berlin so we had to pass through Checkpoint Charlie where scary East German guards stood watch. Daddy told us not to open the windows or stick anything out of the windows, but as I recall, I disobeyed. I don't remember all the details, but I'm here writing this years later, so I guess I wasn't arrested and thrown in an East German prison.

Our best friends from Baumholder were Bob and Biggi (Brigitte) Martin. Biggi was from Berlin, so met up with her family, and they picked us up at the airport and showed us around. It was difficult communicating, however, because we didn't speak German and they didn't speak English. The international language of love spoke, though, because they had a really, really cute son, maybe 16 or 17, named Bernhardt. I developed a huge crush on him. I had already met him when he had visited the Martins, but I fell head over heels in love in Berlin, even though we couldn't carry on much of a conversation.

There was one moment, though, that was so humiliating and helped open my innocent eyes to the fact that life very seldom lives up to its expectations. Bernhardt came to pick us up to go somewhere—the Berlin Zoo maybe—and I spent a long time getting ready. I pictured myself as a tall, beautiful teenager with shiny hair when, in fact, pictures from that time period prove that I was a chubby teenager with a bad home perm and black glasses. (The same type of glasses that my children later observed in a picture of

me and asked why I wore my swimming goggles to school.) The military hotel where we were staying had a long staircase, and I tried my best to float down it in the best tradition of the Southern belle. My best, however, turned out to be tripping at about the third step from the bottom and falling flat on my face at his feet. What a pathetic memory!

He did give me a picture of him to take back with me that I could show off to everyone. A few months later in California, Paulette took the picture to school to show it off and a girl snatched it from her hand, and it ripped. It was just one heartbreak after another in that unrequited love. He did kiss me good-bye on the cheek at the train station as I cried. I wonder if it was just a pity kiss! I can still remember that total pain of having to say good-bye and go back to Baumholder and school. Every time I see a piece of citron I think of that pain because when we pulled into Frankfurt, there was nothing to eat but some pastries, and mine had citron in it. I hated citron. It pretty much defined the way I was feeling. And then I had to go back to school that afternoon and stand at the bus stop with the fat black girl who hated me.

The next summer we got our orders to leave Germany and go to San Diego, California where Daddy would serve as a National Guard advisor. Knowing that retirement would be soon, he requested a duty station close to the East Coast, so he could start lining up post-Army employment. Typical for the Army, we got sent about as far away as we could get.

I hated leaving Germany. After a rocky start, I had grown really happy. We had lots of friends and activities, a happy family, and I was looking forward to being a

teenager. Cliffhanger: Moving to California changed all that.

California: 1966-1968

The trip back to the United States was different this time because we got to fly. It was the first time I had ever flown. We flew from Frankfurt, Germany, in to Fort McGuire, New Jersey, and then Daddy somehow got down to Paramus, New Jersey, to pick up a new car we had ordered before we left Germany. It was a new red Ford Fairlane station wagon. Without air conditioning. What a bummer! Not a whole lot of cars back then had air conditioning, and, as conservative as Daddy was about gas, ours wasn't one of the lucky ones that had it.

I remember the motel stay there was fun since everything in the U.S. was so new to us again, even TV commercials. Plus, the motel had a swimming pool, which was fun, because we had only gotten to go swimming a couple of times in Germany. Of course, I also remember what I ate for breakfast. There were the most delicious peach pancakes. I've often thought about trying to recreate them but never have.

So on we traveled to Virginia after a three years' absence. Seeing our grandparents and cousins (Harper and Stephen) again was wonderful, but, after a nice visit, we had to

move on to California. At some point during our visit in Virginia, I had decided that I needed to lose weight. I think maybe one of my cousins said something hurtful to me about my size. (What do I mean “think”? I remember exactly who it was and what was said.) So as we traveled across country, I began to adjust my diet. I don’t know what I ate during the day, but each supper I ordered a chef’s salad and then took my little bag of Waverly Wafers back to the motel room to eat later as a snack. Hang on—this will all be significant information to have later on.

By the time we got to California, I had lost five pounds. That was the beginning of my battle with anorexia over the next few years, even though at that time the condition did not even have a name. I don’t think I ever got to the point that I endangered my health, though. I did wind up in the hospital for about a week, but that was more so they could diagnose my symptoms because it wasn’t well-known back then.

All I knew was that I was suddenly thrust into an unfamiliar world after I had been so happy in Germany. It seemed like I was a dark-haired chubby 13-year-old non-California when everyone else had long blonde hair and was a native Californian. I wasn’t even the right branch of the service. Daddy was stationed as a National Guard advisor in National City, a bedroom community of San Diego. With San Diego Naval Base nearby, the only service brats around were Navy, and I was Army. (It made a difference to a military brat!)

I was dreadfully homesick for Germany when we first got there. We lived in a three-bedroom ranch about a mile from our school. Our next-door neighbors were nice,

though, and had a daughter, Karen Prince, a year younger than I was and a younger son. They showed us around the community a little. I don't remember why, but I didn't become friends with Karen at school, maybe because she was younger.

When school started, I was even lonelier. Everyone had known each other for forever and wasn't used to people moving in and out as is the custom in military schools. I remember one time sitting in history class and just starting to cry I was so lonely. The teacher saw me and came over, quietly asking me if I was okay. I said yes, but asked to be excused to go to the bathroom. I went to the bathroom and was crying when one of the girls from the class came in to talk to me. Her name was Becky Ballard, and I started to do a few things with her after school. She was Pentecostal Holiness, and I started to go to church with her, which really started me on the search for a church that I felt was teaching truth. I even went up to the altar one time at the end of a church service with her to express my faith in Jesus Christ as my Savior. All of the people in the small congregation came up, put their hands on my head, and begin to pray very loudly and tearfully over me. I remember thinking, "What in the world have I gotten myself into?" My friend Becky said, "Pray, pray." I said, "I am, I am." I think I was a disappointment to them. When I got home, I told my parents about it, and they weren't very happy. As they saw it, I had joined a Pentecostal Holiness Church. I didn't feel good about it either, so I didn't really get much more involved in that church. It was just another step in my life towards the Church.

Also, in the eighth grade, I was bullied by a couple of girls. Romaine Delani and

Trina Clements. I'll never forget those names. For the next year or so, they made my life miserable, and I don't even now why they hated me. They were in orchestra with me. I was the first chair violin, and a boy named David Hunter sat between the two girls. David was my salvation as he kept us separated. I remember one time he challenged me on my first chair position and terrified me that I would have to sit by Romaine and Trina. We had to go into a small room off the orchestra room and play for the rest of the class, who would then judge who played the best. My main problem with playing the violin was always that I couldn't vibrato, but I was so scared that day that my hands were shaking, and I did a wonderful job vibratoing! I won the seat back, thank goodness!

Finally, I believe it was sometime in the ninth grade, I decided to confront them and see if they would leave me alone. We were in a phys ed class together. That was really excruciating because back then you had to change into a stupid gym suit in front of everyone in the locker room, and that was always awful. Anyway, we were playing volleyball one day outside, and they were on the other side of the net, when they started yelling at me or making fun of me somehow. I got all my nerve up and yelled back, "Why don't you two just shut up?" I don't know what else I said, but I do remember that it stopped their abuse of me. They were one reason why I have always been conscious of how my children have treated other people and tried to urge them to be a friend to the person at school who doesn't have a friend.

The ninth grade was happier. I was a lot thinner by that time, which gave me more self-confidence. I think I finally lost 40 pounds and got down to a size nine. I also had

that whole anorexic lifestyle going, though, even back then anorexia didn't even have a name. I kept myself on a very strict 1,200-calorie-a-day diet and exercised fanatically every night to my records. If I ate one calorie over 1,200, I was frantic. Finally, the doctors became concerned over some of the symptoms I was having and stuck me in the Balboa Naval Hospital to run some tests. That was a lonely, boring time, too, back before there were TV's in hospital rooms and cell phones to call home all the time. I think Mother came to see me every day, which was a real sacrifice for her because it was about a half hour drive away from Chula Vista, and she was terrified to drive on the California freeways. The doctors finally took my medical records to a big medical convention and decided that the problems I was having were due to the fact that I had lost a significant amount of weight so quickly. I stayed very thin throughout high school and basically until I started having children. Since then, I've only tried to be! But I think my body has some primal urge to not be starved again and resists my efforts to be thin. I don't know if Dr. Phil would buy that or not, but I like to use it as an excuse/reason!

So, ninth grade was happier. I had a good friend, Kay Cook, I fell in love with Scott Whitely, who in retrospect was really a jerk, and I became involved with the Christian Reformed Church there in Chula Vista. Kay was the pianist for the orchestra, so I had her when we went on the orchestra trips, and she helped with the Romaine/Trina things. We also enjoyed being together after school. Her family was a little weird, though, and did things like not eat white sugar, sweetening their Kool-Aid instead with brown sugar. Her mother also meditated a lot, and we had to be quiet when she was doing that.

They also were in to some weird religion, and I went with them to a healing crusade in Los Angeles one time, but we wound up picking up some homeless person and taking care of her, so we never made it to the crusade.

Finally, Kay and I started going to the Christian Reformed Church there in Chula Vista where one of her neighbors, Francine Collins, went, and I truly felt at home there. They had a huge, active youth group, and we did a lot of fun things together.

Religiously speaking, I came a long way in my search for happiness in a religion. My family wasn't really going to church at that time in their lives. We tried a Methodist Church a couple of times since we were actually Methodists on record, but it didn't work. So I found this church and was happy with it, even though I never did go up to the altar and profess a belief in Christ as was their tradition also. I don't remember if it was because I had already done it in one church and believed that was sufficient or there were just some things I didn't believe that they taught. I remember I never could accept their whole concept of pre-ordination, or the idea that the people who were going to be "saved" were already chosen before they came to earth. That didn't seem fair to me, and I remember questioning the minister, Rev. Veenstra, many times about what happens if you decided to accept Christ but you hadn't been fore-ordained to. He kept telling me that if you accepted Christ you would be fore-ordained, but that seemed like putting the cart before the horse to me. He said it was like walking through a door, and, if you decided to walk through a door, you were there. That just added to the whole confusion I had over the issue of God choosing to share his gospel with some people and not with others.

It never seemed fair to me that the people who lived in the parts of the world or in the times of world history when there was no news about Jesus Christ were sent to hell through no fault of their own. I did read my Bible a lot then, more than I sometimes read my scriptures now. I woke up every morning, rolled over, and read before getting out of bed. I even memorized huge passages of scriptures from the New Testament, which still continues to bless me.

I realized at that time of my life that religion was a very important part of who I was and that I wanted to follow Christ in my future. I determined to find a church that would answer my unanswered questions and truly felt that somewhere there existed the church that would “bless those who hunger[ed] and thirst[ed] after righteousness.”

On to Scott Whitely. He was a tall, dark-haired, really smart guy who really liked me but didn't have enough guts to cut the ties with his girlfriend of many years, Chris Campbell. I think he liked me a lot, but he knew I was going to be leaving at the end of my ninth-grade year, and he wanted to still have Chris after I left. He played the trombone, so we were in the orchestra together and had a little bit of hand-holding going on some of the trips. I also kept a muffin paper from a spice muffin he ate on the night we put on an orchestra program at school one night.

Scott was also in the Latin Club, so we went to Disney Land together one time. It was so funny because Chris wasn't a member of the club so I figured that was my best chance at Scott. It took me almost all day to get beside him on a ride, but we finally wound up on the “It's a Small World” ride on the bench together. I blush to think how

obvious I was. I left my hand in between us, palm up, just praying for him to take it and hold it. He finally did, probably about as the ride was ending. But then we went on some kind of roller coaster ride. (With my fear of roller coasters, I can't believe it was too wild.) But he put his arms around, and I was in seventh heaven! But then, heartbreak hit, and we went in search of something to eat, a frozen banana I think, and got separated. I didn't see him again until we got on the bus to go back home. His behavior that day proved to me that he liked me, though.

I was president of the Latin Club also that year, and the big event of the year was the Latin Club banquet. The president of the club was either the reigning emperor or empress of the banquet, which made me the empress. My responsibility was to find an emperor. The scary thing was that the banquet traditionally ended with a food fight where the emperor and empress were pelted with grapes. So, I needed an emperor, and I wanted him to be Scott. I decided that my best chance to ask him to be my emperor was when he went up to the pencil sharpener. I waited until that happened and followed him up. I got up all the nerve I had and asked him if he would like to be the emperor at the Latin Club banquet. He just laughed out loud at me and said, "No!" Laughed right out loud! I was absolutely humiliated and went back to my seat. Later, though, I don't remember if it was the same day or another, he asked me, "Do you know what happens to the emperors at the banquet?" I realized then that the reason he had turned me down was because he didn't want to be pelted with grapes, not because he didn't like me. As it turned out, he was the emperor, and that is the end of my memories of that Latin Club banquet.

To end the whole Scott Whitely segment of my life: He came to a party I had a few weeks before I left California where Daddy grilled hamburgers for several of my friends, and then I guess he went back to Chris Campbell. He wound up going to Stanford, and I wrote him once when I was at Westhampton, but that was the last I heard of him.

It was time to move from California, and I don't remember being too sad about it, even though I hated leaving the Christian Reformed Church and my friends there. Paulette had gotten somewhat involved also. The last summer we were there, a group of young people on summer missions came, and I sort of fell for a really cute one, but, alas, it was just a summer romance. The last time we met together and told them and us good-bye, we sang, "God, Be With You 'Til We Meet Again," and I can never sing that hymn without thinking of the bittersweet ending to our stay in California. I hadn't been really happy there for most of my stay, but there were some good moments.

So it was the summer of 1968, and we traveled up to Sacramento, California, where Daddy retired after almost 21 years in the Army. He chose that time to retire for several reasons. He knew that his next tour of duty would be Vietnam, and he didn't want another war tour. While he was stationed in California, it was part of his job to notify the next of kin of the men killed in Vietnam. It was awful for him, and we knew to leave Daddy alone the days he had to do that. Combined with his memories of the Korean War, he felt he had done his duty and wasn't anxious to go to Vietnam. We were glad he chose to get out of the Army then. Plus, he had promised me that I could go to high school all in

one school, and he was always good for his promises.

We were going to Virginia to at last live close to family—something I had always wanted to do—and we were excited about it.

On to Virginia

When we first reached Virginia again, we found a home to live in right across the street on Montague Street from my grandparents. That was nice. I loved going on long walks with my grandfather and having our cousins over. Sundays were especially fun because we always ate at my grandmother's and grandfather's after church. She had some standard menus she served, and they were all good. She made the best fried chicken and pound cake you have ever tasted. If you were lucky, you got to lick the batters of the pound cake on Saturday morning. The adults would sit around the big table, and the four cousins would sit at the card table and talk about young people things.

Harper and Stephen were some pretty cool cousins. Both of them were on the football team, even though Stephen had to quit later because his diabetes made it difficult for him to play. (Footnote: While we were on our way to California in 1966, it was discovered that Stephen suffered from juvenile diabetes. He almost went into diabetic shock before they caught it. It affected his life from then on and eventually took his life from a massive heart attack at the age of thirty.) But being their cousins gave me a little bit of a heads-up starting school at George Washington High School. In fact, the map I took with me the first day of school to know how to find my way around that huge school

was a map that Stephen had drawn for me on a Wimpy's napkin where we were eating lunch.

I think I'll interrupt the flow of the narrative here and talk a little bit about my grandparents. My grandfather was Paul Riley Kidd Donahoe. The grandchildren called him "Dada." He had been named after everyone who was in the room when he was born, and he always said he was glad that there weren't fifty people in there. I adored him, as I think I have said before, and loved the chance I then had to take long walks with him. He wrote in a long, flowing script, the one men of that generation wrote in, and later in life I loved getting letters from him. Mail time was a big time of day for him, and I can see him standing on the sidewalk looking up the street watching for the mailman. Dada could talk to anyone, and he had a real wit about him, which some of us lucky ones in the family inherited, or like to think we inherited. Years later, in 2006, I interviewed a retired postman for a newspaper story, and he still remembered Dada.

I can't remember what Dada did before he started working for the Civil Service down in Cherry Point, North Carolina, but most of the time I remember him he was retired. I have always thought he was sort of a sad person, even though I don't think he saw himself that way. He just never really accomplished much as far as the way the world defines success; he and Mama never even owned a home. While they lived in Danville, they lived in two real small homes. I never remember them going on a vacation because of taking care of Billy, but then I never remember them complaining. One thing he did brag about and maybe future generations will enjoy knowing, if they know who Shirley

Temple is at all, is that he gave piano lessons to Shirley Temple Black's daughter for a time on the Eastern Shore. (She was a really, really famous child movie star back in the 1920's and 30's who won an Oscar, served as a United States ambassador, and was the most photographed child star ever, according to the shirleytemplefans website.)

Dada always smelled like wintergreen Lifesavers, which he always kept in the pocket of his white shirts he always wore along with several folded Kleenex. Even though his father was a Methodist minister, Dada had trouble behaving in church even as an adult and would entertain Paulette and me by folding handkerchiefs into bunny rabbits and feeding us candy. He was bald the whole time I knew him, and when I was little, I would shine his head. One time, when we were staying with them after returning from Hawaii, I was shining his head when he said, "Susan, my head feels wet." Army brat that I was, I answered that I had been spit shining his head. I don't remember that he liked that too much. But he really loved me—I was always sure of that. That same trip to visit them, I was a little behind in my reading, so he sat for endless hours in the evenings listening to me read about Dick, Jane, and Spot.

My grandmother was a good woman, but I just never liked her as much as I did my grandfather, nor was I able to get along with her very well. I always sensed her disapproval for me. I certainly have always admired her, though, for the wonderful care she took of my mentally retarded uncle (Down Syndrome) Billy for so many years. And she never seemed to resent it or even think that her life was meant to be anything less than Billy's mother. As I've said before, I remember one Sunday dinner her saying that

the hardest thing you would ever have to face was that you had a retarded child. For some reason, perhaps the Spirit speaking to me, that struck a chord in my heart, and it was almost like the Lord was telling me that I would one day have to face that same situation.

But she loved taking care of Billy and built her whole life around that. I have struggled the whole time since Dawn's birth to accept the fact that I am not the good caregiver of Dawn that she was to Billy. I don't know if I'm just not meant to be a full-time caregiver or if I am and I'm just not accepting that as God's will for my life. It just depends on my mood which is the right answer.

I think her relationship with my grandfather suffered from her total devotion to Billy, but I don't think that seemed to bother her. Dada was also devoted to Billy, but Mama and he were devoted separately, if that's possible to understand. He and Billy had their own time every Saturday of watching wrestling on TV. Dada would keep very careful records on 3x5 cards for Billy of everything that happened in the world of wrestling.

They were all three on a schedule, and you had to go by it if you were staying there. Billy ate lunch every day at 12 and had a specific lunch he ate on different days of the week, like turkey noodle soup on Tuesdays and Thursdays along with exactly eleven crackers. Supper was at 4:30, and heaven help your bladder if you needed a bathroom between six and seven when he was in the bathroom for his shower for one whole hour. In his spare time, he watched TV, went for a short walk (same place every day), and wrote in his books every day. He copied the cast lists from hundreds of TV Guides year

after year. Luckily, he had gone to the Virginia School for the Deaf and Blind for two years when he was four and learned to read and write. It totally enriched his life.

The three of them also had a place for everything, and everything had better stay in its place. I used to think it was ridiculous. Still do actually, and I have tried very hard to fight the genetic material that would turn me into a person who has to do everything by a strict schedule and go ballistic over something being a few millimeters from its appointed spot. (Generations to come: If you are reading this and are one of the Scheduled People, please know I tried to dilute the gene pool that has made you that way.) I used to love to go over and put the milk in the wrong place in the refrigerator and see how long it would take Mama to straighten that mess out.

But I have pleasant memories of evenings at their house. Not one minute before 8:15 every evening was “freshments time” when you ate a bowl of ice cream. The pink bowl I have only one of is one of my grandparents’ bowls that we used to eat ice cream in. It was especially nice if we ate out on their porch in the summer and talked to the people going by. Then we would go inside, hoping to get a seat close to the big blue fan, and watch the shows that are now are TV Land.

Dada eventually died of hardening of the arteries. He spent a few weeks in Roman Eagle Nursing Home before died. Mama died a couple of years later after arthritis attacked her, and she basically decided to starve herself to death. A stubborn woman to the end. We were afraid that Billy wouldn’t be able to survive without the mother he adored, but he went to live with Mother and Daddy and lived for another 13 years. He

finally died of Alzheimer's and basically starved to death too. But he lived a lot longer and better than the 16 years he was predicted to live. He was a wonderful person, and I have faith I will meet him again in his exalted state.

Back to me:

I look back fondly on my years of high school at George Washington High School. I certainly wasn't one of the "in" crowd, but I had my own group of friends and was happy there. I was one of the smart ones, but not the "cool" smart ones! I think I was too much of a goody-two-shoes (and proud of it!) to be "in." In fact, I was named Saint Susan in my sociology class because I was the only one who scored a perfect score on the morality test we took. I don't even remember what the questions were.

For two years, I was involved in the publication of the yearbook and discovered there that I had a talent for writing, especially light, humorous writing. My senior year we decided to go with an ad section with written-out copy advertising the advertisers' products instead of just display ads. I was put in charge of the whole ad section and turned out to be quite good at it. I would contact the advertisers and find out what they wanted said in their ad. Then I would group together similar, but not competing businesses, and write bright, witty copy about them. It was quite successful that first year and turned my sights toward journalism. I'm not sure why I didn't work on the newspaper with my interest in writing, but I think it had something to do with the fact that my Latin teacher, Cheney Lea, was the yearbook sponsor.

Mrs. Lea popped back in to my life throughout the years until she finally died in 2001. She was a part in a big moral decision I made in my life and a stand I took. I was in advanced government class, and everyone in Danville knew that the teacher gave the same multiple choice tests every year. One of the senior traditions was to pass those tests down to the next class. I assume he knew what was going on, but just didn't care or liked the fact people did so well in his class. Also, he never taught anything and spent his time talking about sports in class. I decided, however, that it wasn't honest to memorize the answers to the tests, so I spent hours every night learning the material, and I never did as well as everyone else did on the tests.

So I decided that I would transfer to a regular government class. The difficult part of that decision, of course, was that I would have to get his signature on the transfer slip. While making the decision, I consulted Mrs. Lea, and she told me that I should do the right and honest thing and transfer. So I got up all my nerve and took my transfer slip into Mr. Houser. He looked at me and told me that I was making a big mistake because the other class would be harder. (That to me proved he knew what was going on.) I said I knew, but I wanted to do it anyway, so he signed it, and I transferred. And that was my big moral stand. It impressed Mrs. Lea so much that every time I saw her through the years, she would talk on and on about it. She eventually wound up in Roman Eagle Nursing Home, and when I was with the Young Men and Young Women Christmas caroling one year, she made them listen to the whole story again. I think that incident strengthened me later for the stand I was going to have to take to join the church against

my family's wishes.

I seemed to always have a boyfriend in high school; a couple of them were even interesting. My very first date was with some guy whose name I don't even remember. He was older and was in my art class. Looking back, it seems like he was at least thirty, but I'm sure my parents wouldn't have let me go out with someone that age. And I don't even remember why I remember him as older except that he listened to WBTM on the radio in his car, which was the radio station for older people. We went to a football game, and that's about all I remember, except that we never dated again. (Maybe he checked into nursing home or something!) That's pretty pitiful that that's all I can remember about my first date.

The summer between my sophomore and junior year I met Randy Owen, and I guess he was my first real boyfriend with a driver's license and everything. He was a red-headed baseball player (with a hot temper I found out later), and I met him through his cousin who was dating a friend of mine. Soon after we started dating, he left for a baseball tournament down in Florida. He left on a bus from the Pepsi Bottling Plant on Riverside Drive, and I went to see him off. He gave me a carnation corsage he had had his aunt make me, and I was totally smitten. He also brought me home a pair of pierced ivory earrings that I couldn't wear for a few years until I convinced my Daddy to let me get my ears pierced.

I dated him through an exciting summer of baseball games in Market Garden, movies, getting to know his family, and hanging out with our friends. When fall hit,

however, and school started, things started changing a little. I suddenly realized how totally possessive and excessively jealous he was about anyone who even spoke to me. At this time, I actually had a best friend, Claire Perkins, and he didn't even want me to talk to her. He had a lunch that started earlier than mine, so he would stand outside the door of Claire's and my Latin class and stare into the window in the door at me the whole time. I think he was checking to see if I was talking to another boy. Anyway, it drove me crazy.

Then he would hover over me at lunch, even eating part of the pitifully small lunches I was eating at the time. (Although my eating habits were better, I still tried not to eat over 1,200 calories a day all through high school to maintain my weight and usually ate either a pack of Nabs or an apple for lunch.) After school, he would drive me home and want to stay forever. I finally convinced Mother and Daddy to tell him that he had to leave by a certain time. But then he called me as soon as he got home. It drove me crazy!! I finally went to talk to Claire's youth minister about it at First Baptist Church whom I had gotten to know through participating with her youth group activities. He told me that I need to get rid of him ASAP because he was just a little too jealous.

That fall also Paulette and I were part of "Sing Out Danville," which was a local offshoot of an "Up With People" group that had started after an "Up With People" concert in town. (Posterity: If you don't know what that is, look it up on whatever form of the Internet is now running.) Mother and Daddy were the faithful sponsors of the group, and we were awful. We never really had anyone to be our director, and most of us couldn't sing. But we did have several shows throughout the area during that fall.

Anyway, back to Randy: He was in “Sing Out Danville” and, of course, was involved when we decided to have a float in the annual Christmas parade.

Why is this significant? Well, because he was driving me crazy, and I had decided that I had to break up with him that night because he wouldn’t even let me go around to the other side of the float without getting upset with me for leaving him. The only problem was that I knew he had bought me a pre-engagement ring for Christmas, and I sure wanted it. I was really conflicted in a materialistic sort of way. But I chose free agency, even though I’d never heard of that expression, and independence, and broke up with him that evening.

He was devastated! He also went a little off the deep end. (Can you go a *little* off the deep end?) He kicked a parking meter and broke his toe or something and then slugged the dash of his car and put a big dent in it. He also went to see my neighbor and told her he had taken an overdose of aspirin to kill himself. He lived, though, so he must not have taken enough!

I was lonely and suffering but with a wonderful sense of freedom at last. I remember driving around with another friend of mine and listening to “I’m Leaving On a Jet Plane” by Peter, Paul, and Mary and worrying that the death of another person would be on my shoulders! Then, in the back of my mind, I was thinking that I had just blown a chance of having one of those pre-engagement rings that so many girls at school had.

One little note: The axle on our float broke going down Main Street, and we had to hobble through the rest of the parade. I’ve gone to most of the parades since that time,

and I've never seen that happen since. It even made the paper the next morning.

A couple of weeks later, I made a big mistake, however. I don't remember if I talked to Randy in the next couple of weeks, but right before Christmas, he convinced me to come over to his house and see what he had bought me for Christmas. Of course, it was the pre-engagement ring. Actually, it was a tacky little heart-shaped ring with a bunch of microscopic diamond chips in them. But Randy convinced me that we could start over, and he gave me the ring. Things get foggy after that day, but I think we just lasted together another couple of days before I couldn't take him again and broke up for good. Whatever happened to the ring I just don't remember.

Not long after I broke up with Randy for good, I suddenly noticed Bobby Bryant, a friend of Claire's from First Baptist Church. He also was in "Sing Out Danville" and had a really good voice. He had pretty blue eyes too as I remember but really strange naturally curly hair—sort of like white man's afro. He also loved basketball and baseball, and I think the first place we ever went for a date was to a basketball game. We sort of hit it off I guess and started going steady after a little bit, probably around the end of my (and his) junior year. He did have a strange mother, though, and a little brother who ate nothing but Captain Crunch cereal. He also had a grandmother who lived on Paxton Avenue, and we would go over on Saturday nights when we didn't have anything else to do and watch Lawrence Welk with her. I think I hated it. Mother remembers Bobby as never having any money to take me out but always having enough money to buy himself a baseball magazine he liked. Figuring it up now, I guess we went together our whole

junior year, even though he really irritated me. I have no idea, looking back on it, why I didn't break up with him.

His father worked for a grocery store and was transferred the summer of our junior year to Richmond. I think I was secretly glad. But still we decided not to break up. Go figure. Back then, there was no email or instant messaging or even cheap long distance, so (imagine this!) we actually kept in touch writing letters. I remember that summer as being very hot since we didn't have air conditioning and as doing nothing but sitting around and embroidering. Plus, writing letters.

The only excitement that summer was when Bobby's mother kidnapped me. Yes, she did. I went to spend a weekend in Richmond and visit Bobby. I was bored out of my mind. There was absolutely nothing to do and very little to eat in the house. His mother did nothing all day but lie on the couch. She had lost a lot of weight on Weight Watchers, so she didn't keep any food in the house either. I remember Bobby finally telling her one day that she had to go get some groceries because there was nothing to eat and he had had to eat a green tomato sandwich for breakfast. So I went with her to go grocery shopping, but there still wasn't much to eat as far as I could see. I couldn't wait to go home.

Then, the night before I was going to ride a bus home I think, Mother called and Bobby's mother didn't even call me to the phone but told Mother that they wanted me to stay a couple more days so we could go to Williamsburg and Jamestown. Mother said yes, not knowing that I did NOT want to stay any longer. I was so homesick and cried that night when I found out I wasn't going home the next day.

So we packed a picnic lunch the next day and went sightseeing. I don't remember anything about either Williamsburg or Jamestown except that Mrs. Bryant had fried chicken thighs for the picnic lunch, and they were disgusting. It was one of the longest days of my life, and I was so glad to get back to Danville and away from Bobby.

The school year was bad, too, every other weekend because Bobby would come to Danville. I had a novels class sixth period and every other Friday I would watch out the window and see his red and white Gremlin come across the then-new Aiken Street bridge. My heart sank. Again, I have no idea why I just didn't break up with the guy.

I finally did, and it was pretty rotten of me the way that I did it. When the school's hippie poet finally noticed me and actually wanted to date me the spring of our senior year, I was so thrilled and so in love with him that I sent Bobby a letter and broke up with him. The timing was pretty bad, though. It was right before the senior prom at GW, and Bobby had already rented his tux to take me to it. He was devastated and came and sat on my front porch wanting explanations. I told him about Sidney, and he couldn't believe it. Sidney and this muscle-bound cheerleader had been going together for years, and no one could believe he would drop her for me. So out with Bobby and in with Sidney.

Sidney came into my life at a time I was feeling very intellectual. I don't remember if Sidney was in my English class or not, but we both had discovered Romantic poetry and its connection to nature and we both loved to translate Latin, which we used to do sitting on his back porch. He also loved Jimi Hendrix, which love I didn't share. He was the only child of fairly older parents and pretty much got to do what he

wanted to do. We each had a bike and did a lot of bike-riding too.

Above all, he wrote beautiful poetry. Really. He finally got a PhD in classical languages, married Sidney, and at the time of this writing is a professor at the University of Arkansas. (I hear he's divorced too.) He lived down the street from Claire, and I remember I went out one day from visiting Claire and found a piece of notebook paper stuck in my windshield. On it were two poems he had written to me. I kept those poems for years in a cedar jewelry box, but one day after I had several children I went back to find them and didn't have them anymore. I think I finally threw them away because I felt guilty keeping them. I've often wished I hadn't though. Who knows, maybe he'll get extremely famous one day, and I could make some money off of the poetry? He also drove a jeep that was painted in red, white, and blue stripes, and I always thought that was fun to drive around town in. When he broke up with Lindsey to go with me, she wasn't too upset. She said, "He's done this before. He'll come back." Since I didn't see what a poetic, classical-language-loving, Romantic with a capital R as in the literature guy like he could see in a shallow, muscle-bound cheerleader like Lindsey, I was sure he wouldn't.

So I had a rather strange last few weeks of my senior year. I had helped decorate for the senior prom, but Sidney didn't really "believe" in proms, so we sat on the hill on Christopher Lane outside the gym and made fun of the students going into the prom. I think one night we also went into the Grove Street cemetery and read Shelley. I don't remember if I really enjoyed doing stuff like that (I know I was afraid of being caught

cemetery trespassing) or if it was just another indication of my being passive in relationships with the male species so they would not get mad at me. We also spent the night of graduation not at the usual graduation parties, which I wasn't really into anyway, but driving to a pine woods someplace and eating a watermelon. (For those who don't know, Romanticism in literature is all about a person's relationship with nature.)

As an interesting sidelight, I also got a job working with Sidney's mother, Helen Burris, as a Virginia Tech Extension agent and going into low-income neighborhoods teaching children and women how to cook nutritious and low-cost meals. I would just drive around in my little VW bug until I saw some kids or women and ask if I could come into their home and cook something. As I look back on it now, it seems like a very dangerous job.

But, alas, Nancy was right, and Sidney just couldn't live without her. I went several days without hearing from him and getting really nervous about what that meant. Finally, I got up enough nerve to call him and ask him why he hadn't called me. He told me that he just couldn't live without Nancy and that he had missed her so much that he had gone back to her. I thought he could have at least had the decency to call and tell me, but evidently he didn't. So, in one brief phone call, my world fell apart. I remember crying and wailing, "Why did God do this to me?" which was quite dramatic, but at the time, it hurt. I think I preferred being the one to drop boyfriends!

Now that I've gone into great detail about my boyfriends in high school, which I hope someone in my ancestral line will be interested in, let's turn to my spiritual quest at

that time for a church I could believe in. That seems slightly more important than missing my senior prom!

When we moved to Danville in 1968 when I was a sophomore, we, of course, started going to Mt. Vernon Methodist Church, although Dada always went to First Christian Church because he played the organ there. Mt. Vernon was close to where we lived, and there was no question that we would go to a Methodist Church because my great-grandfather had been a Methodist minister and Mama had adored him. I never quite understood how she wound up at Mt. Vernon, except that it was just up the street, since it is one of the “Main Street” churches in Danville (still is at the time of this writing in 2004) and mostly rich, influential people who don’t want to get too involved with religion go. Of course, that’s just my opinion. Their membership lists are a veritable roll call of “Who’s Who in Danville.” And we went there?!

But I was never very happy as a Methodist. The sermons always seemed to stop just short of telling me how to achieve salvation but were full of social comment in vague terms about Christian discipleship and endless litanies others had written. It was a long way from the more personal religion I had found at the Christian Reformed Church in California. I just always left as empty as I had come. Paulette tells me that one day as we left Sunday School to walk home, I turned to her and said that one day I would find the true church on earth and, when I did, I would tell her about it.

But Paulette and I were faithful Methodists. We tried very hard to be active in the youth group and Sunday School, even though no one else in our family went to Sunday

School or did much else in the church. We even helped start a coffeehouse in the basement of the church where teenagers were supposed to be able to come and hang out. But I don't think anyone ever came. I remember one night being stuck at the coffeehouse for hours with a lot of doughnuts that no one came to help us eat. It's not a totally unpleasant memory, however!

One particularly miserable memory Paulette and I have as far as religion was a rally we went to in Richmond one time. We laugh about it now, but it was the longest day of our lives at that time. We rode on a bus to Richmond, and I don't remember that we knew anyone else. The other kids on the bus sang what seemed to be endless choruses of "100 Bottles of Sprite on the Wall, 100 Bottles of Sprite, Take one down, pass it around, 99 bottles of Sprite on the Wall" in this absolutely tuneless melody that only changed notes on the last "Sprite" in the chorus.

I don't remember where in Richmond the rally was—a pretty big place—but we sat on uncomfortable bleachers and listened to folk singers. Lunch was the worst, though, because it was some sort of bag lunch with a little bottle of Coke. Graceful person that I am, I dropped my Coke all the way off the bleachers, and it was empty by the time I got down to get it. So I had to go stand in line forever to get a drink of water out of the fountain after I ate, and I was so thirsty. Anyway, it was an endless rally, and, in the end, we were on the bus again for a long ride home, listening to the same songs, and eating a box of Twigs. It wasn't the inspiring religious experience we wanted it to be.

Sometimes I would go to West Main Baptist Church with Joe, Nancye, Harper,

and Stephen, and I really liked it better there. I especially liked the fact that the Baptists baptized by immersion, as I believed people should. I studied the New Testament constantly and was always concerned when I found a discrepancy in what my church taught and the Bible said. Sprinkling as a means of baptism was one of those discrepancies because it was apparent to me that Christ had been immersed by John the Baptist and not sprinkled. I think Joe and Nancye would have liked Paulette and me to join their church. I remember Nancye telling me one day that we needed to make a decision about which church we should go to and that we shouldn't switch back and forth. I couldn't imagine telling Mother and Mama that I didn't want to go to the Methodist Church any more. Little did I know how drastically I was going to go against their beliefs within a couple of years.

I just always had questions about things written in the Bible that no one, not even my minister, could answer. What did Christ mean when he said he had "other sheep that are not of this fold" which he had to go and visit? What did the reference to baptism of the dead mean? What did it mean that Christ went to preach to the spirits in prison after His resurrection? And, most importantly of all, what was going to happen to all the people for eternity who had never heard of Jesus Christ? How could they be condemned to hell when they hadn't even heard of Christ, or if Christ hadn't even been born yet? That was especially troublesome to me because it didn't fit in with the picture of the loving God and Savior I knew. And then all that confusing talk about the Trinity no one could even explain seemed just ridiculous And why were there so many churches

espousing so many ways to get to God? I asked and asked, but no one could answer unless they answered, “It’s just one of those mysteries of God that we aren’t supposed to understand.” But that didn’t make any sense either because it seemed to me that if God wanted each one of His children to return to live with Him that He would provide very clear directions on how to get there. Where were the answers to all these questions? I was constantly searching, and something within me seemed to whisper that if I searched long enough, I would find the answers to these questions.

I got to be friends with the associate minister’s wife at that time, and asked her those questions, but she didn’t seem to have any answers either. She said that Christianity was one very beautiful way to get to God, but there were other ways also. That made no sense to me because it sort of made Christ out to be deceptive when He said, “I am the way, the truth, and the life.”

So that was the state of my religious mind when Sidney broke up with me at the end of my senior year. By the way, I had been accepted at Westhampton College, the girls’ college at the University of Richmond, for the fall of 1971 and had accepted. (Unfortunately, I had accepted while I was still going with Bobby, who was also going to the U of R. I didn’t look forward to have him close.)

On to my conversion:

My boyfriend’s breaking up with me in the spring of my senior year of high school became the catalyst for my finding the church I had always searched for.

Heartbroken and lonely after Sidney returned to the muscle-bound cheerleader, I went

next door where we had lived for two years to talk to my neighbor, Lou Simmons. She and her three children were Mormons. Her husband died of a bleeding ulcer when her children were young, and she had remarried a man, Richard, who was a member of the Church of Christ church and who himself had three sons. Her oldest daughter, Joyce, was staying with her, along with her baby boy, while her husband was a helicopter pilot in Vietnam. Her next oldest child was her son, Gene, and her youngest was Jane, who was a year older than I was and a good friend of mine. We drove to school together, and Jane always ate hot strawberry Pop-Tarts in the car and made our car smell so good.

Gene was away at college at Utah State and then BYU when we first moved in, but when he came home to go on a mission, I thought he was tall, cute, and nice. We eventually wound up double-dating—he dating my best friend, Debbie Ellis, and I dating his best friend. After a few dates, Al wanted to trade and date Debbie, but Gene wouldn't switch because he didn't want me either! Gene left for his mission to Mesa, Arizona, in 1970, the first missionary ever to leave from the Danville Ward.

So I wrote Gene, and I don't even remember what I said. I do remember what he wrote back, however. He told me how thankful he was to be a missionary for the true church of Jesus Christ and that his church was the only one on earth that had the answers to where we came from, why we were here, and where we were going after this life. I was enraged at his arrogance! I wrote him back rather quickly and told him that he couldn't tell me that he knew his church was true. I don't remember my reasoning since I had been searching for the truth, but I do know at that point I was insulted that he would

tell me his church was true. He answered back rather speedily with an apology and said he hadn't meant to insult me.

(By the way, at the time of this writing in 2018, all the letters between Gene and me, plus letters when he was away in the Army, are in the chest of drawers in the upstairs spare room.)

Things moved quickly after that. I began to pelt Joyce and Lou with questions about the Mormons. I didn't realize it but Lou seemed very uncomfortable answering some of my questions, but it was because her husband was in the room and he didn't like to hear about the Mormons. My mother later told me that he warned them that he had seen the Mormons work before and how they brought people into their church. By that time, though, Joyce, had moved into a trailer with her son, so I would go over to her house and ask her questions.

One of the first things she gave me to read was a Joseph Smith pamphlet with the story of the First Vision. I was sitting in the living room at home with my mother when I read it. I had read about a paragraph when I turned to my mother and said, "If this is true, it's the best news I've ever heard." To think that Jesus Christ had once again come to earth and that the heavens hadn't been closed to revelation since His death was phenomenal news to me. I couldn't imagine anyone not wanting to know if this was true or not. I knew then that I had to find out for myself if the Savior and God the Father had appeared to this fourteen-year-old boy.

My mother was less than thrilled to put it mildly. And I never really understood

why. It wasn't like my parents were openly religious, although they were wonderfully good Christian people. What I really didn't understand was why if they were so upset at my looking at another church why they didn't look into it themselves and see what it was that I was so attracted to.

I also started reading the Book of Mormon, and it seemed to make perfect sense to me. It certainly answered my questions about who the "other sheep of the fold" were, and it made sense that Christ would care just as much as other people who lived on this earth. It was like this huge body of knowledge that was opening up to me and giving me a wonderful feeling. Later, when I got my patriarchal blessing, I realized why I was able to accept the truthfulness of the gospel so easily when others have such difficulty and struggle so much and so long. My blessing said that it "was a reawakening of truths that I had known before and loved." I knew what I was being introduced to was true because it *felt* true.

Before I even talked to the missionaries, I knew I wanted to join the Mormon Church. My parents did not want me to find out anything else about the Church, but I was determined I was going to. And this was a radical departure from the kind of child I had always been. I had never gone against my parents' wishes in anything yet.

I finally got to the point that I stopped at the phone at the 7-11 on Kemper Rd. and called the missionaries. (I'm not sure where I got their number from.) I introduced myself and told them that I thought I wanted to be baptized into their church. It was a dream-come-true for a missionary! Whoever I spoke to—either Elder Neil Powell or Glenn

Sykes—was speechless. He stammered a little and said, “We’ll have to check with our mission president [Rex D. Pinegar] because we think that you have to take the discussions first.”

So I arranged to have the first discussion at Joyce’s house, and Mother went with me. Her going was sort of the death knoll to their acceptance of my wanting to become a Mormon. Bruce Spangler went with us too. At that time, there were six discussions, and during the first discussion, the missionaries used a flannel board and built a church on the board with the different parts Christ’s original church had, such as prophets, healings, speaking in tongues, etc. Then, when it was all built, they would ask the question, “And what does this say about all the other churches on the earth today?” The correct answer, of course, was that they weren’t true, and the missionaries would flip the board somehow, and all the pieces would fall to the floor. Mother was livid. I remember going home and standing in the hall and hearing her tell Daddy about it. And that was the last time she was interested at all in hearing anything about the church, and the project of the whole family became keeping me from joining the Church.

I was forbidden to see the missionaries again, and Daddy called Bishop Smith and told him that if the missionaries ever showed up on his doorstep, he would shoot them. (He didn’t own a gun, though.) Then my favorite teacher, Evelyn Miller, who had been alerted to the situation, called and invited me out to lunch to celebrate my going off to college. I was naturally suspicious, especially because she and her husband went to Mt. Vernon and were our youth leaders. We went to the Hallmark Cafeteria in Ballou Park,

but nothing was said. I kept waiting. Then, just as we pulled up in front of my house, she turned to me and said, "I hear you have been looking into the Mormon Church." I said that I had, and she told me that she had a boyfriend in college who was a Mormon and that I should be careful because the Mormons weren't the people they said they were. I don't remember what I said, but she didn't convince me of anything. No one else seemed to have anything else to offer me, nor had they ever.

I also was asked to take my grandfather downtown to pay the electricity bill. This was sort of an oddity, so I was suspicious. I sort of postponed it until one day my mother insisted that I take him downtown. So I did. It went fairly well until we were almost home, and he turned to me and said, "I hear you want to be a Mormon." I don't remember what I said, but he started crying, and I felt like a total heel. I hated to cause my grandfather any pain.

Mostly, I remember that I kept trying to give people vague answers so they would just leave me alone until I could get it all sorted out in my mind. Plus, I knew that I would be going away to college in just a few weeks, and I figured it would be easier to do whatever I wanted to do after that. I also knew that I would be turning 18 right after I got to school and that I wouldn't have to have my parents' permission to be baptized after that.

My minister was also in the hospital at the time with gallbladder surgery or something. He really was a nice minister, and, when my mother asked me to go talk to him, I did. He laid there in his bed and told me about a Mormon secretary he used to have

who committed adultery. I guess that was supposed to convince me that Mormons were fakes. He, like others, had a hard time differing between the fact that we claim to have the truth about religion, yet we never claim that Mormons are a perfect people. I asked him a couple of questions—the same ones that the missionaries seemed to answer so easily—but he just once again told me that there were mysteries of God we weren't meant to understand. I left from him unconvinced. Looking back, it must have been like Joseph Smith felt when he said that he couldn't lie however much people wanted him too. He had seen a vision, and he knew he had seen a vision.

Then for the first time in my life, I lied to my parents. Either they had told me that I couldn't go back to Joyce's house for another discussion or I didn't want to upset them again, so I decided to tell them I was going to a movie with Al but go over to Joyce's for another one or two discussions. Al was supposed to be the one who carried on the conversation after we got home, so I technically wouldn't be lying. (See, some Mormons lie too!) I remember standing in the doorway between the hall and the living room when Mother asked how the movie went. Al, male person that he was, had started watching television as soon as we got inside the door, and didn't hear Mother's answer. I didn't want to lie, so I started of nudged him and told him Mother wanted to know how the movie was. He sort of started and said, "Not very good." Mother probably knew I was hiding something.

I was just miserable. I felt good about what I was being taught, and I wanted desperately to join the church that seemed to have the answers to the questions I had. But

I was receiving so much persecution from my family that being at home was awful. (Paulette at this time was going through a crisis with her boyfriend Stuart, but when I asked her as I wrote this she said, "I rose above my own troubles and was supportively noble.") My friend, the associate minister's wife, tried to be supportive, but didn't think the Mormons were the way to go either. She said one day, "I don't know where you'll wind up, but I know whichever corner you are in will be blessed to have you." When I did join the Church, she wouldn't speak to me again. Even Joyce said to me one day, "Maybe the Book of Mormon just isn't true for you right now." That thought appalled me. If it was true for other people, why wasn't it true for me too? I realized that the nature of truth meant that it existed independently of what other people believed and had to be true for everyone. Why would God leave me out?

I remember one conversation I had with Mother in the basement one day when she was doing laundry. She said that they just wanted me to go off to school and to look into a lot of different churches before I decided on one. I didn't really answer her; I was just trying to get through the summer. Then I decided to start living the Word of Wisdom. I had never smoked, so that was no problem. I did drink coffee in the morning, though, and every afternoon Mother would have a big glass of lemon iced tea ready for me when I got home from work. That was going to be tricky. I don't remember the coffee in the morning being a problem, but one afternoon I came home and refused the tea Mother offered me. She hit the ceiling and said, "You're planning on joining that church, aren't you?" I don't really know what I answered. I was backed up against the refrigerator, and I

just really felt like the forces of heaven and hell were fighting for me.

At some point I just gave up and decided to just put my investigation into the Mormon Church on hold. I was instantly even more miserable. Blackness just seemed to envelop my soul because I knew that I had denied the truth I wanted in my life. Mother took me to Sears to buy a raincoat to take to college, and I remember standing in front of the mirror trying on a blue raincoat and looking into my eyes. They were absolutely dead. There was no joy in them or in my life at all. I felt like I had turned my back on God, and I hated my family was causing me to do it. I didn't know at that time that the missionaries and Joyce were fasting for me. The missionaries fasted for three days for me.

Then my defining moment for my testimony came. I don't know if it was that night or not, but one night soon after I decided I wouldn't join the Church, I knelt down beside my bed after everyone was in bed and read my Book of Mormon. I told the Lord then that I didn't care what happened to me or whether anyone in my family ever spoke to me again, but I knew the Book of Mormon was true, that Joseph Smith was a prophet, and that I was going to be baptized when I could do so without my parents' permission. Immediately, a wonderful feeling poured through me, and I knew that my prayer and my commitment had been heard. I have looked back on that moment many times since that night and know that it was the witness of the Spirit spoken of by the prophet Moroni.

While I was still kneeling by my bed, my mother came into my room and sat on the side of the bed. I told her then very quietly that I knew this was true and that I wanted to join the Church. I have no idea what she said, but I know things got a little better after

that and the open hostility disappeared. They seemed to know what I was going to do when I left for school and chose to ignore it. Soon after, I don't know how much longer, I left for school.

The missionaries had gotten permission from President Pinegar to travel outside their zone to go to Richmond and baptize me. Lou and Joyce went also. I remember hardly anything from my baptism except that Joyce gave me a copy of Jesus the Christ and Articles of Faith by James E. Talmadge. They took me back to my dorm, and Joyce said, "I guess we'll go; Susan has a lot to think about." I felt very lonely then and didn't want them to go. But I knew that I had finally found the church I had looked for for so many years.

Paulette was baptized six months later. Knowing that she would go through everything in my room after I left, I had left some pamphlets in the drawer for her. She read them and asked Mother and Daddy if she could take the discussions. They not only said she could, but they gave her permission to be baptized.

The relationship between my family and me did not improve for a long time. My grandmother, who never liked me much in the first place, never quite forgave me, I think. I came across a letter years later that my mother had written me while I was at Westhampton in which my mother said that I couldn't expect the family to accept me back quickly and forget all that I had put them through. I never really understand what I had done all that wrong. All I wanted was a church I could believe in.

I've thought about it often and what I would do if one of my children wanted to

change churches. It would be a little different for me, I think, because no one who wanted me to not join the Church believed that what they had to offer was actually the true church of Jesus Christ, so the stakes would be higher for me. But I hope that if it ever happened that my children found something they wanted more than the Church, I would sit down calmly and find out what it is that attracted them to another church and lifestyle. Maybe my parents would have joined the church at that time if they had ever sat down and rationally and reasonably considered that what the Mormons believed was true and prayed about it.

After my baptism, there followed the most miserable year of my life. Yes, out of all fifty-some years of them, and I've some miserable ones.

My School Year at Westhampton College of the University of Richmond

I really was unhappy at WC, and now that I know about depression and its symptoms, I truly believe I was in a deep, dark depression. That seems sort of ironic since I was finally satisfied spiritually, but I think that was part of the problem. I knew how I should be living and how I wanted to be living, and there was a big disparity between the two. I was the only Mormon among 600 girls, most of who were sleeping around and drinking themselves mindless every weekend.

I had two roommates—Chris Murphy, who was a faithful Catholic girl and my good friend that year, and Linda Lickerman, who was from Mexico City and was a drinker. It never seems to work out with three roommates. Chris and Linda got along

okay, but I was always totally intimidated by Linda. It didn't help one night when I asked the drunken party on the floor to be quiet so I could sleep and Linda came in, leaned over my bed totally drunk, and chewed me for treating her friends that way. Chris and I eventually hooked up with a couple of other girls and had our own little group of "good girls," which was better. When I left that next year, the three of them roomed together for the rest of their college stay, I believe.

I hated living in the dorms. I lived in North Hall, which was built of stone in 1912, and was dark and gloomy. I always had thought I would like living in a Gothic-type of building, but I had been wrong. People kept saying they liked living in North Hall because it was "homey," but my home certainly wasn't dark and stony. The inside steps were of dark stone and worn away where hundreds of girls had run up and down them. We all shared a bathroom at the end of the hallway, and I always hated that.

Plus, after several years of having a room to myself, I had to suddenly share a room again, and I found that very difficult. Linda was on a totally opposite schedule than Chris and I. She slept late and went to classes late, while Chris and I did just the opposite. The point is I was never alone, and it drove me crazy. I wanted to have quiet to read my scriptures and to pray, but I was never alone. I tried a couple of times stopping at the Westhampton Chapel to pray, but someone walked in on me one day, so I never did that again. I have real sympathy, which I express to my students now, for those who are struggling with roommate problems and living in a dorm situation.

I was very involved in my local ward, which met on Monument Avenue. I enjoyed

that, but even that depressed me because I would have to come home. My salvation there was a family who adopted me and helped me as much as they could through my year. It was Jesselene McMillan, her seventeen-year-old daughter Rosie, son Andy, and an older daughter I don't remember much. Jessie was in the middle of a divorce and had found the Church a few years before. Rosie was pretty and smart and just a year young than I was. They picked me up for church on Sundays and then most Sundays took me home afterwards to eat dinner with them. It was wonderful. They also gave me a ride on Wednesday nights to MIA. I have kept in touch with Jessie through the years. She has lived in Utah since the late 70's I believe, and I have gone to see her several times as I've traveled to Utah. She's a wonderful, wonderful person. I even used her as the basis on my character in True Rings the Heart. I think that really tickled her because she mentions it every time I see her.

I even had my first church calling at that time. I can't remember exactly what it was called, but it was something about culture. I think my only responsibility was to find someone to give the opening and closing prayer at MIA, but I did it very faithfully!

Back to WC, I counted every minute of every day of every month until the school year was over. I really wanted to go home at Christmas and finish the school year at Averett where I had been offered a full four-year scholarship, but Chris kept telling me I would be giving up, and I didn't know how it would work being back at home with my family when they weren't too thrilled with me, so I decided to stay and stick it out. There was always a thick cloud of blackness hanging over me, though, and struggled sometimes

just to get up every morning and go to class. I felt like I never felt like I belonged there, and I didn't enjoy anything. I just seemed to endure.

I think feeling like that made me vulnerable to falling in love with Gene through letter-writing. I guess. Looking back on experiences like that when you feel like you have received a witness of the Spirit—a happy feeling that fills your soul with peace and light—but that turns out bad, you wonder if you really received a witness of the Spirit or if you just thought you did because you wanted to. Maybe you do receive a witness of the Spirit because that is what you supposed to do and, even it seems to turn out badly from the mortal perspective, from the eternal perspective it will be just exactly what you needed to experience.

I can say with confidence that I have always sought the will of the Lord in my life and have always tried to receive confirmation of the Spirit for decisions. Sometimes it comes; sometimes I muddle along. So I think I was meant to marry Gene and experience what I did.

I just can't explain why. Maybe it was to get the wonderful kids I wound up with!

So anyway, Gene and I continued to write letters. Mission rules were a lot more lenient back then, so Gene probably wrote me at least three times a week. I think I wrote him every day. He listened to all my problems with being unhappy, and I listened to all his problems he had about his mission work. Someway, somehow, we fell in love and decided we wanted to get married when he got home. He actually proposed to me on a tape he sent me. He called me occasionally too. (Remember, mission rules were more

lenient then.) So I accepted over the phone. It seemed to work out to get married right after he got home in August 1972 and go to BYU right after. I didn't have any trouble getting accepted, and we put ourselves on the list for married student housing.

Then I told my parents, who accepted it better than I thought they would, and Mother and I went over and told Lou. I don't think she ever really liked me after that. She sort of had in her mind that her little boy was going to come home from his mission and be her little boy again for a while. (She always told everyone what a mama's boy he was.) As my boys grew up and married, I understand more of how she felt and have felt that I wasn't the best daughter-in-law.

Looking back, I would have an absolute fit if one of my children, at the age of eighteen, told me he / she was getting married to someone he / she hadn't dated and that the wedding was going to take place two weeks after the fiance got home off a mission. This doesn't really fit into what I said on the last page about witnesses of the Spirit, but I think that if Gene and I had dated for about six months that I would never have married him. I would have realized we wouldn't get along. Maybe not, though. I was young enough in the Church to still almost deify returned missionaries. I probably wouldn't have had enough nerve to back out anyway. Who knows? I don't. I hope after this life I'll see how it all works out.

The school year finally ended, and I had a real epiphany that has lasted throughout out my life, as epiphanies are wont to do, that time does pass. I gained a testimony that one day I would be thirty; one day my children would be grown and leave

home; that one day I would be old; and finally, unless I'm alive at the Second Coming, that one day I will die. That knowledge has helped me through trials innumerable and giving me strength and patience while waiting for something good to come to pass. It has also terrified me that labor and delivery would finally happen, as well as my children leaving home and my growing old and dying. (I think all writers share that perspective, which is why so many are alcoholics and eventually kill themselves—I always explain that to my students when they wonder. A testimony that the future will come is a tremendous burden to bear.)

I returned home for the summer and worked three jobs to save money for the upcoming wedding, marriage, and school year. How very naïve I was. I worked during the day as a secretary for my Aunt Nancy at Bellevue Elementary School where she was the principal, in the evenings at the only McDonald's in town (on Riverside Drive); and during my spare time selling Luzier makeup. At the end of the summer, I had saved up \$700. I remember that amount because that was the amount Gene owed for tuition for the first semester at BYU, and he totally wiped out my savings account without asking me about it. It was one of the first times I was not happy with the situation I had gotten myself into.

(I am going to try hard not to be vindictive and mean when talking about my marriage to him. A big part of the reason we didn't make it to the end was very personal, and I'm just not going to go into it since I am writing this for his children. I will not use this personal history as a means of revenge, but I want everyone to know that problems

cropped up very early.)

So, after eleven months of writing Gene and waiting for him to come home, he came home on August 10th 1972 at the Greensboro Airport. He made the big mistake of hugging me first, although I think the reason for that was that his mother hung back for some reason. I don't think that put me in her good graces, and, having grown sons now who have returned from missions, I certainly understand. (I have always been thankful my boys did not leave girlfriends when they went on missions.) I wore a pink little dress that was certainly a lot shorter than the dress standards are today. And I had baked him a "Mile High Raspberry Pie." I have never made one since, but I still have the recipe, I think.

Time passed quickly until we were married two weeks later on Daddy's birthday, August 24th. My Aunt Nancy gave me a fancy shower at her home, and I remember being so embarrassed and so afraid that someone was going to ask me how long I had known Gene and how long we had been dating. ("We've been on one date—to a drive-in to see Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid." I would have died.) If I had had any sense, wisdom, or caution at all, I would have gone out to BYU, dated him that semester, and seen how things had gone. Oh well, again--I guess it was meant to be.

At that time, remember, there were not temples dotting the land. The closest temple to us was the Salt Lake City temple, so we were married in a little ceremony at the church on North Main Street down the street from the one now. My grandfather played the organ, and Daddy got to walk me down the aisle. I hadn't been a member of the

church even a year, so someone should have told me I should have gotten to the temple anyway I could to be married. We weren't really supposed to travel out by ourselves, so we decided to do it the way we did. After it was over, Lou said they she would have driven out with us, but I don't remember her saying that beforehand.

We had a nice reception at my aunt's and uncle's house, which was their wedding gift to us. (Plus, they were considered the only society people in our family at that time.) Then we left to honeymoon our way across the country to BYU. Pictures of our leaving showed my stuffed dog Sophie in the back of the white station wagon we had bought if that's any indication of just how mature I was. Maybe I was mature, but I was just eighteen, and with a sixteen-year-old and nineteen-year-old child at the time of this writing, I just can't believe that! The sad thing is that I don't know what happened to Sophie and when she left me.

When we got to Utah a week later, we were sealed in the Salt Lake Temple. I had to get special permission from President Harold B. Lee since I had not been a member of the church for quite a year at that point. I don't know why we couldn't just wait 18 more days, but we were sealed on August 31, 1972. Gene's Aunt Fanny who lived in Sandy was my escort. It was the first and only time I ever saw her.

It was hard for us to find a place to live because all the houses and apartments were full. We were on the waiting list for married student housing, but they told us that might take up to a year. We finally found a basement apartment in the home of a widow at 374 S. 1300 East in Provo. I looked for the house many years later, but it was gone. It

had a tiny living room with a tiny kitchen, tiny bathroom, and tiny bedroom. The bathroom was dark avocado green, and the shower had little tiles that were loose. I can't believe that I didn't scrub the tile down with Clorox every time before I got in it. All I remember now is that I didn't spend any more time than I had to in that bathroom.

The kitchen was pretty nice and bright, though, and I set about being a wife. In the mornings we would eat cereal and I would slice cantaloupe. In the evenings, I began to build a collection of recipes; the first one was hot dogs. We had gone to the grocery store and spent about \$15 on groceries to set up housekeeping but forgotten to get salad dressing. But I remember the first salad I made, we mixed together ketchup and mayonnaise and pickle relish like Gene did on his mission. It was disgusting.

I can't possibly go through every meal I cooked for the next thirty years, but I do remember the first time I fried chicken. I didn't have a clue how to make gravy because Mother never made gravy with chicken. So I made it the way I had learned to make roast beef gravy. I mixed up flour and water, got the grease really hot, and dumped the flour mixture into the grease. It sort of got all lumpy and separated, but naïve bride that I was, I served it to Gene. He took one taste of it and spit it out into his plate. I was devastated, and I would advise a young groom to never react that way. I cried and told him how I had done it, and he proceeded to tell me how I should have done. Looking back, I don't know how he knew because he never really cooked, but he knew that.

I was happy at first at BYU. It was a beautiful school; I loved my classes; and loved the novelty of being around so many members of the church. We were really poor,

though. Gene worked part-time at the Cannon Center washing dishes, and that really helped us out with groceries. He would get the food off the plates that the students didn't eat and bring it home to us. I hope that I remember correctly that it was the food that they hadn't half eaten! We ate a lot of fruit, but I also remember wonderful slices of roast beef that I could make sandwiches out of the next day. Gene worked in the evenings, so I spent a lot of time by myself.

Then we got so poor that we decided I needed to work the next semester. I interviewed for a job toward the end of the semester at the Home Study department, which in pretty explanatory I guess. The job was editing the syllabi the professors wrote, making them consistent and giving the typists the instructions they needed. I told the boss, Ron Malan, that I was planning on going home for Christmas because by that time I was really homesick. So he called a couple of days after my interview and said I had the job, but the only thing was that they wanted me to start before Christmas and I wouldn't be able to go back to Virginia. Well, we thought about it for a couple of days and decided that we had to go home for Christmas. But he called back and said that they wanted me and they were willing to wait until after Christmas. I was to start before Christmas and get together some old courses for the typists to work on while I was gone. I don't know why they wanted me so much. I was an English major, but a very young one, and I certainly had no editing or publishing experience.

So we were able to go home for Christmas, which is always a little weird going home the first time married. We drove straight through with a couple of other friends, and

it was absolutely miserable as driving straight through always is. The trip through Wyoming wound up being exciting because we went around a bend in the road in Provo Canyon and ran over a big boulder a snow plow had thrown into the road. We didn't think much about it until two in the morning 16 miles outside of Cheyenne, Wyoming when our oil light came on. There was a snowstorm going on, and black ice on the highway everywhere. We drove very slowly to a trailer behind a gas station but couldn't get anyone to come to the door. (This was back when there were mostly Mom and Pop gas stations across the country and no WaWas or Buck-ees.) We did find a pay phone, though, so we looked up the name of one of the bishops in town and called him (Two in the morning!) He woke up a mechanic in the ward, loaded him and some equipment up in a pickup truck, and came out in the snowstorm and fixed our car. Evidently the rock we ran over bent the oil pan and the oil had leaked out. We didn't even know his name, but he will surely receive his reward in heaven for so readily helping some desperate BYU students.

I don't remember anything about Christmas that year. I do remember falling asleep and waking up after we had entered Virginia. Even in the middle of middle, I thought it was the most beautiful place I had ever seen. I was so tired of brown mountains.

Speaking of misery, the trip back to Utah was horrible. Paulette decided to go back to Utah to work and/or go to school. That wasn't the bad news, however; the bad part was that she had a stomach virus on the way out there. So there we were with five

people (two other students from the Waynesboro area) in the white station wagon and luggage piled all the way up behind the back seat plus two huge coats Paulette and I had. And Paulette laid down in my lap the whole way. I was so claustrophobic. But, wait, things got worse. Every once in a while, Paulette would say that she was sick, so we would pull over quickly, hold her out the door, let her throw up, pull her back in, and continue our trip.

We finally got back to Provo, got Paulette settled into an apartment with a bunch of girls she didn't know and headed back to work and school. We also moved into student housing at Wymount Terrace, which was fairly new housing for married students at that time. It was funny to find out years later that Matt and Jenny moved into the very same building we lived in.

In a couple of weeks, I figured out that I must be pregnant and went to the health center to find out for sure. (This was back before the days of home pregnancy tests.) I decided to break it to Gene in as totally romantic a way as a couple living in poverty could. I planned a romantic dinner for us at Denny's, a local hamburger place. I can't remember what I said, but I expected that he would look at me tenderly with tears in his eyes and tell me how glad he was that I was going to be the mother of his eternal children. Instead he looked at me and said. "Well, we already figured that, didn't we?" Oh well, at least, as much as he liked food, he didn't ask if he could finish off my French fries.

There followed a semester of being so pregnancy sick and so homesick. I

remember I had an early morning creative writing class, and the only thing that got me through it was sucking on a whole roll of five flavored Lifesavers the whole class. When it got too bad, I just laid my head down on my desk and tried to die without causing a commotion in the classroom.

I got so sick of the snow too. Finally, by the end of the semester, even after we knew we would be moving back to Virginia that summer, I didn't even open the drapes the first thing in the morning to see if it snowed or not.

Plus, we were so poor, even though Mother and Daddy were helping us out by paying our \$60 car payment. I had exactly five outfits I could wear that fit my expanding waist line. We went downtown to Provo one day and bought cheap material for me to make two jumpers, and that gave me two out of the five outfits. When I had been home for Christmas, Daddy had taken me to Sears to buy me a pair of shoes because the only pair of shoes I had were a pair of black flats that were ripped down the side. That is so sad thinking back on it. I didn't even have a pair of boots to wear in all that snow. Anyway, when Daddy and I went to Sears, I felt bad about spending his money, so I picked out a pair of shoes that were on sale for five dollars. And there was a reason they only cost that much—they were probably the ugliest shoes that had ever been produced by man. Brown wing-tips for women with brown laces. Daddy kept saying, "Are you sure you want these?" I sort of convinced myself that I did.

And I wore those the rest of the semester even though they did not look good with dresses and hose. But a lot of people back then were so poor at BYU that we were in the

majority. I remember our bishop looked out at us all one Sunday with tears in his eyes and saying, "I know you are all faithful tithe payers, so I know how little money you are living off of, and I know you are only surviving because you are paying tithing." How true that was!

One more thing about poverty: Mother and Paulette called one Sunday after they had been to the Festival in the Park the day before, and they told me they had just had angel food cake and fresh blackberries for dinner. I almost cried because I wanted that to eat so badly. I think we were having about the fourth meal of a pot of beef stew I had made out of a fourth of a pound of stew meat.

Times were hard. And we made probably stupid decision to move back home that summer, supposedly to save money through summer jobs and return in the fall. I often wonder if things would have turned out differently if we had stuck around BYU for the rest of our college career and Gene had had three more years of that environment. We did plan of returning, however, but never did, so I never got my fill of the BYU experience, which is why I love so much going back and visiting you children out there and why I have wanted so badly for all you children to go there and experience it vicariously for me. Back home to Danville . . .

Returning to Danville

So we returned to Danville with plans to save up money and go back to BYU. When we first got there, we found an apartment on Lee St. on the second floor of an older home across the street from the Lee Street Cemetery. An older couple, the McFarlings,

owned the home and lived on the first floor. Gene got a job working as the bookkeeper at Goodwill Industries, and I stayed home waiting for a baby to be born. I think the job paid \$425 a month.

I was sort of bored—the last time in my life I was ever bored. We only had one car, so if I wanted it I had to get up and take Gene in to work. I remember I did some sewing because I had no maternity clothes to wear, and I read a lot. On Thursday mornings, Mother would come pick me up and I would go grocery shopping with Mama and her.

Gene hated his job because there wasn't much to do; he was as bored at work as I was at home. Luckily, however, Bishop Stan Davis helped Gene find a job soon after with a construction company that was working out at Corning where Bishop Davis worked.

Gene made \$1,000 a month there, so we were sure we could save money and return to BYU after the baby was born. We also didn't have insurance, so we had to save money to pay for my medical care, labor, and delivery.

It was a hot, long summer because we only had one air conditioner in the living room, so I lived in there except for cooking. One night we had the missionaries over for supper and we set an ironing board up in the living room and ate off of that because it was so much cooler in with the air conditioner. A second floor apartment in the hot, humid Virginia summers is not a pleasant place to be.

An awful thing that happened twice that summer was that I forgot to put the hose from the washing machine into the bathtub to drain, and I flooded the hallway of my

landlords. It was so awful! Mr. McFarling was so mad at me. He came up the second time it happened and yelled and yelled at me, even taking me downstairs showing me the water streaming down from their hallway walls. I finally begged him to let me go upstairs and clean the water up. It is my most outstanding memory of that apartment.

Except, of course, the birth of Dawn. I will not, thankfully to the readers of this probably, go into detail of all the births of my children. Let it suffice to say with Dawn that had she not been my first child to be born, I would have known that it was not a normal delivery. At that time, husbands were not allowed into the delivery rooms and there were no routine fetal monitoring. Either of those might have helped because I had specified that I did not want drugs, so the nurses, busy that night, went out into the waiting room and had Gene sign a release form to give me Demerol. While one nurse took my blood pressure, another stuck a needle in my arm. I immediately conked out although I was ready to deliver, and when I finally woke up Dawn was there. Enough details. At some point during that time, Dawn was deprived of oxygen.

Although we did contact a lawyer several years later to see if we could hold the hospital and Dr. Marsella responsible for her brain injury, I know that it was decided long before Dawn and I came to this earth that we would meet under the circumstances we did. So I don't hold any grudges—I later delivered four more babies at the same hospital and one by the same doctor, although not by my choice.

So we brought Dawn home, and I proceeded to live life as a full-time mom. It seemed easy at first because Dawn slept a lot the first couple of days, but after that she

didn't. I do remember the first night she was home, I didn't want Mother to stay because I was sure I could handle everything. By two in the morning, though, Dawn had been screaming for quite a while, and we called Mother. She came, I went to bed, and when I woke up in the morning,

Mother was asleep on the couch with Dawn sucking on her finger. Nothing makes a young mother more grateful for her own mother than the first night at home with a new baby!

If Dawn had not been my first baby, I would have known something was wrong with her immediately. She kept her hands clenched, she couldn't suck very well, and she cried a lot. When she had her first shot, she developed a high fever, a huge lump on her leg, and screamed a high-pitched scream for hours. That is the second possibility of what caused her brain damage—a severe reaction to a DPT shot. I don't know. This is when life started to get real difficult and stayed that way for years.

Dawn couldn't entertain herself, so you had to entertain her. At the age when babies discovered their toes and fingers and could hold rattles, Dawn couldn't. She was also terrified of being on her back because children with cerebral palsy retain their newborn startle reflex, and she couldn't stay on her stomach without rolling over. So we did a lot of walking and holding of Dawn. Although the doctors kept telling us it was preliminary to say anything was wrong with her and she could just be a slow developer, we had to live with the reality of taking care of a very unhappy baby.

Sometime around her birth, Gene got fired from his construction job. He and his

boss never got along. I don't remember why because at that time Gene was a little easier to get along with, but anyway his boss didn't think so, and when Dawn was about four months old, we moved to Vinton, near Roanoke, so that Gene could start a manager trainee program for Kenney's Fried Chicken. It was the franchise owned by his former stake president in Waynesboro and for which I think he worked in high school.

We found a two-story apartment to rent in Vinton, which was really nice. It was a lonely time, though, because we only had one car, which Gene took to work with him, plus he worked afternoons and evenings. So Dawn and I spent a lot of time alone. She got older and, although she was a bright observant little thing, of course she couldn't do anything physically except hold something for a short time in her hand like a toothbrush. I did a lot of holding her, reading to her, and holding her up to look out the window while I watched television. I remember the morning Richard Nixon resigned the presidency and left on a helicopter, I was holding her up against the back of the couch to look out the window.

I would also prop her up in her high chair with towels and blankets while I would bake things. Back then there weren't even umbrella strollers, and she couldn't sit up in a regular one, so we couldn't go for walks. We didn't have a lot of friends either. Our best friends were an older couple with teenage kids, the Perdues, who sort of took us under their wings. I also had a neighbor I would visit with who had a little baby boy. We would sit out on the front stoop together and watch the traffic go by. We didn't have a whole lot in common, though. I remember one day she came over with a whole stack of diapers like

she was going to stay all day, which didn't appeal to me. So when she took a cigarette out to smoke in my house, I said, "I'm sorry, but we don't allow smoking in our house." She lasted about five more minutes until she got up and went home.

Paulette also decided to move up to Roanoke and work. She lived with us for a little bit but then found a sad little bedroom to rent in an old lady's house not far from us. She also found a sad little job. And that completed her sad little life there. I don't remember how long she stayed. I enjoyed having her there to keep me company, but she really led a lonely life and soon moved back somewhere. (Paulette will have to explain her life in her own personal history; I've never been able to get straight all the places she moved to.)

Still the doctors wouldn't say anything official about what was wrong with Dawn. They just kept saying, "She's within the range of normal development." Again, if she had not been my first baby, I would have known by then. It took forever to get her to sleep at night because the slightest noise would make her jump and wake her up.

Our bishop's baby girl was one month younger than Dawn, and she was beginning to crawl and walk holding onto their fingers, so we began to suspect something was really wrong with Dawn. It was depressing

About this time also we decided to have another baby because, as I believed, surely by the time the baby was here and Dawn was 17 months old, she would be at least sitting up. Surprise, surprise. How little I knew about cerebral palsy or suspected how bad it could really be. So I was pregnant with a baby due in February of 1975.

Gene also decided to change jobs and start selling family portrait plans door-to-door. His boss was really successful at doing it. They had a nice new and big house. They also had a baby boy a little younger than Dawn, who was doing all sorts of normal things babies do, which made us believe even more something was wrong with Dawn.

To make a long story short, Gene wasn't as successful as that guy was. It got so that we had to live off of the money the people paid Gene in cash, which was deducted from his paycheck, so the paychecks got smaller and smaller. We had to do something.

The Army seemed to be the answer, even though Gene had tried to join the Army at BYU and was rejected because he was totally deaf in one ear. But he tried again, and he was accepted. It seemed like a good idea at the time to have medical benefits, which we were beginning to believe we would need for Dawn, and, when Gene got out after three years, he would have the GI Bill so he could go back to school.

About this time, I took Dawn back to her pediatrician in Danville who had taken care of her when she was born. He held her up and saw how her legs scissored (crossed over one another when you held her up) and declared, "Yes, I think she has cerebral palsy. But don't worry; you can always put her in braces." Some compassionate diagnosis and some solution.

Mother and Daddy drove me back to Danville and, before I could even get out of the truck, I started crying. Gene was home, though, so they just pulled off and let us be alone with the news I had just received. I remember that evening vividly because Gene still went to work, and I was left home alone with the news that I had a handicapped

child, unable to fathom how severely she was handicapped. It's a good line the Lord does gives us knowledge "line upon line, precept on precept." I think the knowledge of what is ahead of you as far as trials and tribulations would be overwhelming if viewed at once.

One thing I remember about that night is that I baked a fudge ripple cake, really just yellow bundt pan cake with a ripple made of hot chocolate mix running through it. It was sort of my declaration that I wasn't going to give myself over to total despair and that there was something to enjoy, even though it was a piece of cake. I tried to have that same perspective throughout life and look for something that I could enjoy or laugh about even when things are the hardest. I've succeeded most of the time. And I've never made that cake again.

So Gene joined the Army and took off for basic training in Ft. Knox, Kentucky. Dawn and I went to stay with Mother and Daddy. I don't remember much about that time except that I helped clean Mother's house while she worked at DCC in the bookstore, and it was nice to have help entertaining Dawn. Daddy had endless patience with her and walked around and around the circle of the living room, dining area, and kitchen, talking to her.

Bedtime was difficult, and it took her forever to get to sleep, so at Mother's suggestion, I stopped putting her down for a late afternoon nap and bought her a tape recorder and tapes ("Winnie-the-Poo, Winnie-the-Poo, fluffy little cubby all stuffed with fluff"—I'd add musical notes if I knew how) for her to go to sleep by. That suddenly made bedtime easier, and I discovered the joy of early bedtimes for kids and a couple of

hours to myself.

After basic training, Gene was sent to Ft. Gordon, Georgia, for twelve weeks of “advanced individualized training” (AIT). That was a really cool time, even though looking back on it now, I don’t know why I felt that way because entertaining Dawn was always a problem. We lived in a trailer in Augusta I don’t know how far from base, but I think several miles. It was a nice trailer, and it was always spotless because I didn’t have much else to do. We got one channel on TV—no such thing as a vcr back then. Luckily, it had Captain Kangaroo on in the morning for Dawn. I would sit her up in her high chair stuffed with towels so she could sit up and let her bang on a toy while I washed dishes. She and I ate a lot since I was 7-9 months pregnant there, and she just liked to eat. We had gone to some store and spent what little money we had on a new-fangled invention called an umbrella stroller, which she could sit up in. I would sit her in that, put a toothbrush in her hand for her to chew and slobber on, and wheel her around with me to clean the house.

We would also go for walks around the trailer park and visit one or two other young mothers there. One girl had no kids and was my friend until she babysit for Dawn one day while I had a doctor’s appointment and I was gone was seemed like forever. She practically threw Dawn at me when I finally got back. Her husband worked with Gene, so they carpooled.

Dawn also took long naps in the afternoon, and I would curl up on the really uncomfortable fake leather couch and watch “Days of Our Lives” and sleep.

Mother came to visit me, which was nice. She remembers the tuna and noodles I made and the cinnamon graham crackers I would eat with raspberry jam on them. I also craved chocolate really badly, and most every day Gene would bring me home a giant Hershey candy bar (the really big ones) which you could buy at the PX for about fifty cents.

I think I spent most of my time at the hospital, though, between Dawn's appointments and physical therapy and my prenatal appointments. Mother went home about three weeks before the baby was due, but then was soon back because Jenny came ten days early. I almost had Jenny in the frozen food section of the commissary because we were shopping when I started getting sharp pains in my side. We didn't even have a phone, so we stopped at a pay phone to call the hospital, and they said to come in. When they checked me, the doctor turned to Gene who was standing there holding Dawn on his shoulder and said, "You better find a place for that baby fast because she is six centimeters dilated, and the baby will be here soon."

He left and took her to a lady who had been keeping her when we went to weekly classes. He got back just barely in time to see Jenny born. He called Mother, and she and

Daddy headed south to Georgia. To make a long story short, Mother and I flew back to Virginia with the girls, and Gene stayed down there to finish school. I do remember I was a little about going into labor though because Gene was in some kind of secret school and was in a big building with no phones and no way to call him. And there I was with Dawn who was as helpless and dependent as a newborn herself. It all worked

out well, though, because the Lord in His infinite care and goodness arranged for her to come to earth on a Saturday when Gene was home.

Let me tell you what else happened that proved the goodness of the Lord and the power of revelation His appointed servants have. We found out that Elder Rex D. Pinegar was going to be presiding over a stake conference in Columbia, S.C. He had been the mission president when I was baptized and was familiar with the difficulties I went through to be baptized. So I wrote him and asked him if he would give Dawn a blessing after stake conference. Back then, General Authorities came to at least stake conference per stake per year and would give blessings.

So we trekked off to Columbia for stake conference with Dawn and Mother in tow. At the end of the conference, we went up to him. I don't remember what I said to get him to remember me, but I remember he turned to the people who were pressing around him, and he said, "Excuse me, I have to go bless a baby." So we went into a room where we talked a bit, and then he laid his hands on Dawn's head and pronounced that she would one day be a normal little girl. That's really all I remember he said.

Clearly burned in my memory, though, was when he turned to me in my clearly pregnant state and said, "Sister Smallwood, don't worry at all about the baby you are carrying. It will be born healthy and strong and totally normally." I had not in anyway mentioned the fears that had plagued me throughout my pregnancy that Dawn's problem would be repeated in another baby. I knew the Spirit had revealed my concerns to Elder Pinegar and then prompted him to reassure me. I didn't worry another minute about the

baby. The doctor who later delivered Jenny declared afterwards that her delivery was the most normal delivery he had performed in a long time, and I recalled the words of Elder Pinegar.

Throughout the years, I have wondered why Dawn did not turn into a “normal little girl,” and that blessing was probably the motivating factor for all the work and searching for answers I have done throughout her life. In my worst moments, I wonder whether I have lacked the faith to have that blessing come true, but I haven’t really felt that that is the reason.

Paulette wrote Elder Pinegar once and asked him. He replied in a letter I have lost track of that General Authorities don’t have the answers to why the blessings they give sometimes aren’t fulfilled in this life, even though the blessing is given for this life. Our understanding isn’t perfect, and we can just keep on doing the best we can. One day we’ll understand.

The funny thing is that the day after she received the blessing, I was holding her in my lap at the table, and she reached over and picked up a carrot stick just as perfectly as possible. I was sure then I had witnessed a miracle. Little did I know the trials and years and tears that lay ahead of us in dealing with Dawn.

On to Kentucky . . .

We got stationed at Ft. Campbell, Kentucky, and moved there in May of 1975. We found a nice older house in Hopkinsville owned by a member of the ward who lived next door.

Gene and she didn't get along very well, but she liked me, and she adored baby Jenny. The house had a huge porch on the front where Dawn, Jenny, and I spent hours rocking on the porch swing and watching the traffic go by. We were right across the street from the city's hospital, so there was lots of traffic to watch. We only had one vehicle, still the white station wagon, and the base was 16 miles from home, so I never had a car and spent most every at home with the girls. I couldn't have gone anyplace anyway and pushed two strollers.

One thing that was wonderful about that time was watching Jenny grow and develop. I remember one Sunday afternoon Gene and I just sat in the living room for the longest time watching her roll around on the floor and be happy entertaining herself. Dawn couldn't entertain herself and constantly had to have something done for and with her. She did have a baby walker that we modified so she couldn't slip out of the back of it that she sat in and could hit the toys that were on the walker or watch television in. I also would sit her in that out on the porch when we were out there. She watched the traffic go by and the people walking to and from the hospital.

Dawn always had a very alert little mind, so she was never happy to just sit like other handicapped children were. She wanted to always be doing something, but her body wouldn't let her. Thank goodness she liked Sesame Street. That gave me a couple of hours during the day to get something done. We also did therapy on the floor every day while Jenny toddled around.

One morning when I was pregnant with Dennis and feeling very sick still, I took

Jenny and Dawn to a playground someplace close by. I pushed them in the red wagon that Daddy had built up with wood around the side so Dawn could sit up. But I did some things with Jenny at the playground while Dawn sat by looking sad, and I realized that she realized she couldn't do it.

It was so hot outside, and I got so sick, but I made it back to Charlie's house and sort of collapsed on her couch. She didn't have air conditioning either, but she had an attic fan that cooled her house off, so made it cool in there and gave me a drink until I was strong enough to go home. That was a defining day in my life, and it was the last time I ever took Dawn to a playground when I took the other kids. It was too sad. We were realizing more and more how seriously Dawn was affected.

I look back on the time in Hopkinsville as wonderful though. There were so many young couples, and I had so many friends. We also had a lot of ward activities, and it like someone was always coming over and visiting. We also had the missionaries over a lot.

One of the missionaries who was there—Neil Wells—wound up working with Dennis at Novell after Dennis graduated from college. I got to meet up with him again when we took Mark out to the MTC.

We lived in that house until August of 1976 when Gene had to go to Germany for a couple of months. We were really stupid and decided to move out of the house to save money and rent and find another house when he came back. The kids and I went back to Danville to stay with Mother and Daddy. I really couldn't stay by myself because I couldn't even go shopping by myself since Dawn had to be in a stroller too, and Jenny

was only about 8 months old. So we spent the next few months in Danville. It was a lonesome time, but it had some good times too. I remember Saturday nights were always fun because we either ate out or Daddy would go pick up seafood from King of the Sea.

While I was at Mother's house, friends of ours in the Hopkinsville Ward, Dale and Sondra Scofield, wanted to know if we would stay in their house while Dale was on temporary duty from November to February. It was a nice house because he was a major, and it was right across from the church. But we said no at first, although I don't really remember why.

We lived to regret that decision because when Gene got back from Germany, we couldn't find any place to live in Hopkinsville. We should have kept Charlie's house. thought we had found a place—111 Easy Street by a lumber yard and a railroad track, but it didn't work out. But Paulette and I started writing a really cool country western song about "111 Easy Street"—what a name!

Anyway, I think it happened this way. We came back from Danville and spent a couple of days with the Scofields while Gene painted the whole little house. And it was little! We fit our dishwasher into the kitchen, but that made it wall-to-wall appliances with very little room to pull the chairs out from the table. On her way to Relief Society on Thursday morning, Sondra took the girls and me over to the house the morning that the man was supposed to come turn heater. (We still had only one car.) It was a really cold morning. Jenny was almost two and toddling around, and Dawn was sitting up in the corner of the couch. We didn't have the television hooked up yet. It was freezing in the

house, so I tried to keep Dawn bundled up. I eventually heated up vegetable soup, and we sat there eating that to stay warm.

Finally, the man came and said that he had to condemn the heater and we couldn't live in the house. Our whole life sort of fell apart at that point. And there I was stuck in the little house on 111 Easy Street with no telephone or car and two babies. I prayed.

Thank goodness that Sondra listened to the Spirit that morning that whispered to her to come and check on us again after Relief Society. She found us stranded and took us back to her house.

That's when we decided that we would stay in their house while they were on TDY. It required living a couple of weeks with them before they left, which was really long, but I'm sure it was longer for them than it was for us.

We enjoyed staying in such a nice house, though, even though compared to the Parker Rd. house, it wasn't that big. It had three bedrooms, living room, family room connected to the kitchen and dining area, and an office I think they made from the dining room. It also had a garage that was filled with all of our stuff.

I was so naïve taking care of a real home. I did such stupid things that I'm surprised they ever spoke to us again! They told us to consider their home our home and don't worry about things getting hurt. That was good because one day two-year-old Jenny took a pen and drew a line on the wall all the way around the hall into the living room and office. Then she drew a design that looked like a big pig on the wall. It must have been cheap paint too because when I tried to clean it off, the paint came off. Then our hamster

escaped once and chewed the red, white, and blue shag carpet all to pieces trying to get out of the closed door. Daddy had to steal carpet from around the vent to repair that. I never mentioned it to them and wondered if they ever noticed that the carpet near the door wasn't as high as the rest. When we went to visit later, it smacked me in the face every time.

I also had never had a microwave—they were relatively new to the scene of modern life—so when something boiled over and got down beneath the glass, I didn't know how to clean it and just left it until Sondra came home and showed me how easy it was. I also let a cat stay in the house while we went to stake conference in Nashville, and it pooped on the bedspread. I then washed it, only it was dry-clean only, and it shrank from a king-size to about a double-size. I also didn't know where the lint filter in the dryer was because I'd never had a dryer, so I never cleaned it out. It was so embarrassing to go back to their house after they got back and find Sondra vacuuming out the lint filter.

Okay, now I've confessed all those things, so maybe I can forget them! (Then years later my son Mark married a girl who was related to them and I met up with them in Bentonville, Arkansas!)

The worst thing was that when the Scofields got back, we still didn't have a place to live and had to continue living with them for a few days. After a real test of our faith, we found a little house to rent. I guess the Lord was waiting until the house opened up by a family whose wife was an inactive member of the church and whose husband wasn't a member.

We wound up being good friends, although their life was a real mess, and he beat her up occasionally. Larry eventually was baptized, and, later, after we moved back to Virginia we went to the Washington Temple with them. They later went totally inactive and divorced, plus a couple of missionaries got sent home because of her. Interesting story I don't want recorded in my history!

Dennis was also born while we lived in the Scofield's home. There was a historically horrible ice storm in the East during that winter, and he was born in the middle of it. The hospital had no heat the night he was born, so I remember very clearly an icy bedpan and cold scrambled eggs for breakfast. It was also a very long ride 18 miles to the hospital on an icy highway.

I spent a long of time indoors with the three little children that winter. Paulette came to stay with us also after having some emotional difficulties and being in the hospital for a couple of times. If I am still alive when you read this, you can ask me about the details. It was finally time for Gene to get out of the Army and us to leave Hopkinsville. I did not want to move at all. I had so many friends and was so happy there. But he didn't think he could find a good job there, so he wouldn't even consider staying. I just hated leaving, but we left in August, right around the time Elvis died.

Back to Virginia . . . but first to North Carolina

We had decided to move to Greensboro because we had found out that there was a school there for children with cerebral palsy. We found a real nice apartment on the left going into Greensboro on 29 right before the Cone Blvd. Gene soon found a

job selling insurance with Life of Virginia—not my choice of a job since it required his working at night, and we had never made much money when he was in sales. But it was a job and finding and keeping a job always was a challenge for him.

The nine months we lived in Greensboro was not a real happy time. At first Dawn was in the Greensboro cerebral palsy school but then we read about a kind of therapy for brain injury that involved moving the patients in the normal pattern of crawling to teach their brain how to do it. (More details below.) We applied to be admitted to the program at the Institute for the Achievement of Human Potential and began to fast to be admitted before the 18 months it looked like it would take.

We also started patterning Dawn, but weren't able to get many volunteers, even from church. At that time, Greensboro only had two wards; I think we were in the second. Gene worked most evenings, and then after the first of the year (1978) he started doing taxes at Montgomery Ward, so he worked on the weekends. I was home with three children all day long. We had bought a second car before we left Kentucky, but with Dawn, three-year-old Jenny, and 1-year-old Dennis, it was impossible to go anyplace.

Luckily, Mother came one day a week to visit, and we were able to get out then. I also found a couple of babysitters, and that helped too. Gene always worked very hard to support his family and certainly wasn't afraid of hard work. His problem, however, which later proved to be one of the major conflicts in our marriage that led to its downfall, was that he defined his role as purely the breadwinner and mine as purely the one who took care of the children, somehow losing along the way his responsibilities to spend quality

time with his wife and children. He didn't realize the necessity of balancing his family, church, and work responsibilities once we moved from Kentucky.

Dawn was in school during the day, which was nice, but I had decided to do things the way the Institutes for the Achievement of Human Potential (IAHP), so I wasn't a very cooperative parent with the school staff. Everything they wanted to do in therapy, such as have her stand at a standing table,

I wouldn't let them do. I also had a hard time letting them take care of Dawn and insisted on going on field trips with her. It was sort of stupid now that I look back on it.

I was basically miserable, though, and I think more than slightly depressed. I can remember one day just shutting the drapes in the living room and staying in the darkened apartment all day. I lived to go back to Danville where I had help with Dawn and the kids and some company. I guess it was pretty selfish now, and I'm not sure Mother and Daddy were always glad to see us pull up.

Finally, during an ice storm one time, we had no electricity and Gene was drivingus back to Danville to stay until we it was back on when he turned to me and said, "The only time you are happy is when you are pointed in the direction of Danville, so we are going to move back." I was thrilled! He soon after made arrangements to transfer to with Life of Virginia, and we began looking for a house.

It must have been "meant to be," too, because I looked in the Danville paper and saw houses available that had been built through on Virginia Housing Development Authority program on Lockett Dr. I called the builder and found out there was one left. I

told him I wanted it, and he sort of laughed at me and said, “Don’t you even want to see it?” So I did go over and see it, but Gene didn’t before we bought it.

It was 1208 Lockett Dr. off of South Main Street. We stayed there for ten years, so all my children probably remember it, except for Mary Susan, who was three weeks old when we moved to Parker Road. Maybe Brady can’t either? He was only three when we left.

I can’t remember if we first went to the IAHP in Philadelphia before or after we moved, but it was sometime around the same time because the television station in Greensboro did a short segment on Dawn and what we were going to start doing, and on it

I said something about our plans to move to Danville. It turned out that was how Gene’s boss found out he was leaving!

Hey, here’s an actual spiritual experience I can share: We had put Dawn on the waiting list at the IAHP and were told that it would be at least 18 months before she could come. So I decided to fast and pray weekly that she would be accepted earlier. I called a couple of weeks after I had started and found out that she was something like 16 on the list still. So I fasted a couple more times, and one day I got a phone call saying that her name was next. Evidently, there was some reason that all the children before her couldn’t come.

So that’s how we found ourselves heading for Philadelphia in the spring of 1978, I believe.

I don't want to get all bogged down in the next two years that we had Dawn on the

IAHP program, but let me explain it in the beginning. Their basic philosophy is that there are six areas of human neurological development—vision, hearing, feeling, speaking, transportation (crawling, walking, etc.), and reading—and within those there are six or seven stages of development. If you take a brain-injured child through each stage of development, they will be normal. It sounds wonderful to parents of brain-injured children. To accomplish this, the families agree to work on a 12-hour-a-day therapy program to bring the children through the different stages of development. One of the most important things you do is “pattern” in which volunteers come in throughout the day and help you move the child in the pattern of crawling while lying face down on a table for five minutes at a time.

(Daddy made all of our equipment.) This is supposed to signal to the brain how the body is supposed to be moving. Then they are supposed to spend the rest of the day on the floor on their stomachs unless they are doing a treatment.

We also did all sorts of things like strap her onto a barstool and twirl her around, onto a table and whirl her around, and from the ceiling with straps on her ankles. This was supposed to help her balance. She loved it, but it seems cruel looking back on it. We also put an oxygen mask on her every eight or nine minutes throughout the day for two minutes I think to increase the oxygen to her brain. (No oxygen attached—I think it just made her breathe deeply.) She was also on a strict nutrition plan and a reduced water

intake plan to decrease the fluid around her brain.

Dawn proved to be very difficult to motivate. With difficulty, she could push and pull herself across the floor to crawl on her stomach, but she was supposed to eventually move up to crawling 300 meters a day. We were not successful at this at first, so when we went back to the Institutes for one of her six-month checkups, they put her on a program designed for another stubborn little kid. We added I think five meters a day to her program, and once she reached her goal she didn't have to crawl for the rest of the day. It was nice the days we got done in the afternoon. Mother, of course, was the best at motivating her.

They read stories on the floor, played with toys, and looked at family pictures—whatever it took to get her to move.

Let me interject how difficult and godless the people at the Institutes were to work with. They made no allowances for going to church or for any family activities. “The program” was everything to them. No exceptions. Plus they required that everything be written down—every minute on the schedule and every mouthful and amount of water put into her mouth.

So that put us in the position of lying if we wanted to do anything other than the program, such as going to church and doing any family thing with. Sometimes we could manipulate activities to use as rewards, but it was a constant struggle to decide whether to lie on the report and do what we thought the Lord wanted us to do or to risk getting kicked off of the program.

Once we almost did get kicked off the program. It was after Dawn had achieved her crawling goals and she was supposed to be up on her hands and knees creeping. The truth is that she just didn't have the ability to creep. Her legs were just too spastic and would constantly stick straight out, and she would fall. Their answer was to create an anti-sit device to strap on her bottom to make it uncomfortable for her to sit back. But no matter how uncomfortable it was, she just wasn't able to control the spasticity. Anyway, we didn't reach our goals for creeping when we returned, plus I think I had been very sick either with mononucleosis or with being pregnant with Michael—I can't really remember. What I do remember is one of the IAHP staff members giving me a stern choice whether to go home then and decide whether to stick with the program or stay the rest of the week and vow that I would do the program when I went home. I was devastated. I cried and cried. I thought I had tried my best, but it wasn't good enough, and they didn't have any answers for how to get Dawn to except for me to figure it out.

I was staying with a relative of someone here in Danville that visit, which was pretty miserable because she had loaned me her car, and it had the tendency to cut off and not restart. I was trying to navigate the Philadelphia traffic too, and I was terrified while I was driving.

But when I called home and told my family what had happened, my dear, sweet daddy said he would cancel his jobs and come up to be with me. So I moved to a Holiday Inn, and he drove 12 straight hours to come to me. That was one of the sweetest things anyone had done for me. When I wonder about the love of my Heavenly Father for me, I

think of this example of my earthly father's love for me.

So we decided to stay on the program, but things didn't get better. Dawn still couldn't creep, and the Institute thought it was because I couldn't motivate her. (And these were all young people who had no children.) Finally, I wrote them in desperation and explained the situation. All I got back was a letter from them referring me to a page in Dr. Doman's book on motivating children and telling me that if I couldn't do that, then maybe I shouldn't be on the program. I remember standing at Dawn's patterning table, reading the letter, then folding it up, and knowing that I was finished with that program. We then started looking and praying for something else.

Years later, I read a story about a family on the program who eventually went in and shot their brain-injured son while he slept. I can't remember if they killed themselves or not, but I remember having compassion for that family knowing how much they must have tried to please such godless people and bring about the miracle we were promised, but isn't always possible.

It seems like I didn't write much about this time in our life, even though it was a tremendous effort to do a 12-hour a day therapy program. I couldn't have done it without Mother. I think it is impossible to imagine suspending your life for 12 hours a day seven days a week for more than two years and then fitting everything else around that, such as laundry, cooking, cleaning, being pregnant and sick, arranging a full schedule of volunteers, and raising other children. It was so hard.

The Next Attempt to Make Dawn Well

Somewhere and somehow I read about another theory about helping brain-injured people. The name of the doctor was Moshe Feldenkrais, and I don't remember the basic tenets of the therapy or how I found out that there was a therapist in Washington, D.C. who practiced it. It was somewhat the same idea as the Institutes—something about sending messages back to the brain by making the body do what it was supposed to do. Anyway, Mother and I found ourselves trekking up to D.C. for the next few months every other Tuesday through Thursday to take Dawn to see a therapist who lived in a big old house with a bunch of other people. I think this was about 1982-83. (This is why you should keep good journals.) We would leave on Tuesday morning and get up there for a Tuesday afternoon appointment, have another appointment on Wednesday, and then leave after another appointment on Thursday morning.

We would stay in a motel in Silver Springs, Maryland. Gene, and I had no extra money at that time—I can't remember exactly what Gene was doing then—so the church paid the \$90 for the therapy bill every other week, and Mother and Daddy paid for the motel and most of the food. (I don't know how I ever would have gotten through taking care of Dawn without them!)

We had fun during those times. We always got supper the first night at KFC and brought it back to the motel room. The Wednesdays we were up there, we would even venture out and try to find a few places. One day we even went to the DC temple and walked around.

The funniest evening I ever had as a mother also occurred to me (us) one night when we were up there. Some of this time was before Dennis started kindergarten, so we wound up taking him with us unless Daddy could take care of him, and Michael was two or three, so we always had him with us. Jenny would stay with Daddy or friends and go to school.

On this particular evening we had Dennis, Michael, and, of course, Dawn with us. As an aside that will figure into the story later, Dennis was always terrified (might still be for all I know!) of public toilets, and was always sure that they were going to overflow. He also slept on a rollaway bed in the motel and loved to get into the bed while it was still folded up and watch TV with only his head sticking up.

This particular evening, I was going to try to go to a class that the therapist was offering, and Mother was going to stay at the motel with the kids. I was excited because I had no kind of life to myself at all. We ate across the parking at a restaurant called the “Brasserie” that had really good cream of broccoli soup that Michael just loved. The little guy ate and ate the soup until he was stuffed. When we were finished eating, we headed out and saw that it looked like it was going to rain. Mother was carrying Dawn, and I had Michael. But just as we finished paying, Michael threw up several times right in front of the bar and register. Mother left with Dawn and Dennis through the rain that had just started, and I stayed to clean up the floor with a screaming two-year-old. Not a single person helped me clean up the disgusting mess. I didn’t expect anyone to actually clean it up, but no one would even bring me paper towels or anything. So I had to keep running

back and forth to the to get paper towels while carrying this screaming toddler. I finally got it cleaned up, although I'm sure the carpet needed a thorough cleaning. (Whether they ever cleaned it, we don't know because we never had enough nerve to go back in there!)

I opened the restaurant door and faced a torrential downpour and a parking lot that was already flooded with water up around my ankles. So I headed through that with Michael. I finally reached our motel room soaking wet to find Dennis with only his head stuck out of the rollaway. We looked Michael over and discovered he had broken out with the chicken pox.

But, trooper that she was, Mother assured me that I could still go to the class, so I headed for the bathroom for a quick shower before I went.

I got totally undressed and turned to water on full blast only to have the whole faucet fall out of the wall and the water begin to gush straight across to the end of the bathtub and begin to rapidly fill it up. I screamed for Mother and told her to call the office, while I started to throw clothes on again. Dennis, of course, thought the toilet was overflowing, and began screaming from his rollaway bed, with only his head sticking out, "I knew it was going to flood! I knew it was going to flood!"

Mother must have sounded desperate enough because the manager came running down as the water was reaching the top of the tub. I finally got my clothes on, even though later I found out they were wrong side out. The manager discovered the water turnoff valve was in the wall, so, with no time to get any tools, he began to kick a big hole in the wall to get to the valve. He barely made it.

It was an exciting fifteen minutes! I didn't go to the class that night. I think I decided something or someone didn't want me to go out! I always think of this moment as the "Things Couldn't Get As Worse Than This" moment in my life. Excluding real tragedies, of course, if things didn't get anymore out of hand that that evening with the children, I knew I could handle it and laugh about it.

After a few months, my grandmother got really sick, and Mother and I just weren't able to keep on going. The therapist got Dawn to do some amazing things, like sit up by herself on the edge of an exercise bed, but I don't think much of it transferred over as a lasting improvement. I remember walking it one time and finding Dawn sitting up by herself on the edge of something where she could have injured herself had she fallen off. The therapist wasn't even beside her, and I was scared to death, but Dawn seemed to do okay.

Another thing we tried with Dawn was taking her up to the South Bronx in New York City and having a spinal cord stimulator inserted in the back of her neck. A wire then ran down internally along her spine, and a box was inserted under the skin on her side to receive an electrical signal from a transmitter we taped to her side. It was supposed to reduce the spasticity that was coming down from her brain and allow her to move better. It was a horrible five weeks in that place. I was six months pregnant with Mark and ate a lot of M&Ms to survive

Dawn didn't feel bad but had to stay up there for five weeks so every day they could come in and change the setting on her stimulator to see which one was best.

Keeping her happy and entertained during that time was so hard.

Mother came up at least once I remember and stayed for the week while I went home. (We flew back and forth out of LaGuardia, and it cost \$99. The taxi rides were harrowing.)

Then a couple of weekends Gene came up to visit me and stayed in a room they had for families.

I also got sick with the worst cold I had ever had right before we flew home. My ears were in agony on the plane because of the fluid. I finally asked the flight attendants if there was anything I could do to relieve the pressure, and they had me hold Styrofoam cups filled with warm wet paper towels over each ear. Not only was I in agony, but I looked like a fool.

As an addendum, the stimulator never did much good, and we had it removed when she had her spinal fusion surgery.

Soon after I put Dawn in the public schools, which gave me a nice break during the day. Then I think her major surgeries began about 1985, which was a nightmarish time. But I'm going to leave the subject of Dawn for awhile and tell you a little bit about our life when the kids were little and we lived on Lockett Drive, even though Dawn, because of her overwhelming needs, tended to overshadow whatever else was going on.

People often ask me how I had enough nerve to have more children after I had Dawn. Probably the totally truthful answer is that I didn't plan for most of the kids at the times I had them; the Lord seemed to move heaven and earth for me to get pregnant. My

overall plan was to have seven kids—maybe I’ve already mentioned that—and somewhere along the way that happened. I do know that I wanted to have more children because I thought I would go crazy if Dawn and her problems were the only thing I had to concentrate on in my life, and I had always wanted a large family. I wanted some degree of normalcy to fulfill the dream I had had since I read about Jo in Little Women having four boys and a rambunctious household.

I thought if I surrounded myself with the laughter and challenges of normal children that it would help me bear the pain and challenge of an abnormal child. Somehow, naively I guess,

I figured the Lord had given one tremendous trial in my life and wouldn’t give me another. Ha, ha. So I delighted in the normalcy in the lives of my other children and found strength in that to face taking care of Dawn. I’m so glad I went through with my plan to have a large family because it was a lot of fun, and I adore my children.

Looking back, Lockett Drive seemed like a fun place to live. There were lots of kids around, and we lived at the end of a dead-end, so it was relatively safe, even though I was always scared of kidnappers so I watched the kids closely. (At this time, kidnappings of children were just beginning.) I made friends with a neighbor named Gail Jones, and we took a lot of walks together, especially in the evenings. I would put Dawn in her wheelchair once she got too big for strollers, the kids would drag out their bikes and Hot Wheels, and we would rattle off down the street. It was a long walk, so it took up a good chunk of the evening.

I can't remember what Gene was doing at this time, but everything he always did involved not being home in the evening. I finally just gave up, resigned myself to being basically a single mom, especially during tax season, and entertained us the best I could.

It was very difficult emotionally for me to get the first wheelchair for Dawn. I just kept getting bigger and bigger strollers. When she was four or five, I found one I could strap her carseat on. (Carseats were new inventions that first happened when Jenny was a baby.)

One evening, though, I was pushing Dawn across the yard and had forgotten to strap her seat in.

She went tumbling out. When Mother and Daddy found out, they told me it was time to get a wheelchair and they took care of ordering it for me and having it delivered. It is heartbreaking to put your child in a wheelchair, even though at that time I still had hope she wouldn't be in one the rest of her life.

I've learned throughout her life that it's a good thing we don't see the future because the pain would just be too much. s

All the ten years on Lockett Dr. start of mush together in my memories. I can no longer distinguish between the years there and the years of the kids growing up, so this will probably end up being sort of a stream-of-consciousness kind of writing. (Refer to your high school English classes to remember what that is!)

I remember lots of Little League games, school plays, Cub Scouts, Girl Scouts for Jenny, and birthday parties at home. Little League games were difficult because the

season started before Gene finished up tax season. I guess Mother babysat; I don't really remember. I do remember almost fainting at one game because I was pregnant and sick and I just sat down behind the backstop with my kids all around me and no one stopped to help me until I could get up and barely make it to the car to drive us home.

But I do remember that I got famous within the family for messing up birthday cakes, Mother's. I always seemed to be able to find a new way to make her birthday memorable.

One year I made baked Alaska and set the meringue on fire when I forgot it in the oven. One year termites decided to swarm across the dining room as we were eating. And one year I had made some kind of blue frosting which slid off the cake when I held it up for someone to take a picture. And chocolate pies—her favorite—were never good. But I kept trying.

One funny thing that sticks out that is on a video somewhere is when we were making sugar cookies one Christmas. The day after making the cookies we had found a nine-volt battery down in our carton of milk which whoever was the toddler at the time had put in the milk.

Anyway, to make cookies (or eat tacos) I usually just stripped all the little kids down to diapers or underwear and stuck them on top of the table to contain the inevitable mess. So the day we made cookies, (I warned you this would be disjointed) we finished cutting out our cookies and put them on a cookie sheet. I held them up for a picture of the nice Family Home Evening we had completed, and the cookies fell off the cookie sheet.

The funny part, though, is that is the background we see a toddler boy,

I think Brady, sucking on a nine-volt battery and putting it down in the carton of milk. We finally understood how the battery got in the milk. Now, I ask you, what kind of mother lets her child suck on a battery?

Another funny story the kids like to tell on me is the day I fed them chainsaw oil on their pancakes for breakfast. Here's how it happened perfectly innocently: A really kind man in the ward, Bro. William Jones, borrowed our chainsaw and bottle of oil which Gene had put in a pancake syrup bottle without labeling it. When Bro. Jones brought the saw back, he returned it to our pantry which was divided into a pantry on one side and a storage area for tools and stuff on one side. (Are you beginning to get the picture?)

So Bro. Jones put the oil on the wrong side of the pantry and, when I made pancakes for breakfast like a good mother does, I grabbed the wrong bottle.

I served everyone the pancakes but turned to see a group of very solemn-looking people staring at me from the table. Gene said, "The kids say the pancakes smell like oil."

I said, "That's ridiculous. Eat them." But they wouldn't, so I went and smelled them.

Sure enough. They had all poured chainsaw oil over their pancakes. I think that was the Sunday I decided to stop trying to be a good little Mormon mother and fix Sunday breakfast and serve Pop-Tarts every Sunday, which is what they all wanted anyway. At least it makes a good story for them to tell people now.

Actually Brady missed most of this time on Lockett Dr. because he was three

when we moved from there; Mary Susan was only three weeks old, so she missed all of it. Just so you don't misunderstand, it was not all fun and games living there. It was extremely hard with so many little kids and being by myself most of the time. Add to that the care of Dawn, and it was exhausting. Dawn also had most of her surgeries when we were living there, so that added to the stress. But I never wanted to do anything else. I never wanted to go to work. I had made a decision, and Gene supported me in it, that we would obey the prophet's counsel for mothers to stay home with their children and trust that we could survive financially, which was dicey at times. I did want to do things better, though, and was always striving to have a more organized and cleaner house and better behaved children. I did have a schedule I went by, but tried to keep it flexible enough that I didn't fall apart when things did. I usually fell into bed exhausted at night.

The Lord always blessed us with the means for me to stay home, however, even though many, many times we got down to our last dollar. I have a strong testimony of mothers staying home with their children, and the wonderful way you children have turned out is a testament to my decision to do that. The down side of this part of my life, which began my history of migraines, was that I never felt like I was taking care of everyone well enough, my house was never clean enough, and I wasn't particularly happy in my marriage. (I remember these points being noted when I took a depression test that declared me slightly depressed, so I figure they must be true.)

Mainly I wanted a normal life without the burden of Dawn's problems. But then feeling that way made me feel guilty because I always felt like I didn't have enough faith

to have Pres. Pinegar's blessing come true to have Dawn healed, plus there were always stories in the church about wonderful families who found fulfillment and joy in taking care of their handicapped family members. I never felt that way. In fact, even at the time of this writing (August 25, 2005), the only blessings I can see in my life from Dawn's handicap are the compassion Dawn's brothers and sisters have for others. I'm sure, however, that in the eternities I will see how her life has blessed mine, and, of course, there is no way of knowing at this time the person I would be if it weren't for Dawn.

I know that more than any other part of my life, Dawn's condition has driven me to my knees in prayer.

Dawn eventually had four orthopedic surgeries in an attempt to alleviate the hip pain she suffered because of her malformed left hip. We didn't even know she had a hip problem until she was on the Institute's program and she had to stand up holding onto a ladder. She began to complain about her hip hurting, so we took her for an x-ray and saw this badly deformed hip. She didn't really have a hip socket, and her femur came to a point, rubbing against the absent socket.

I will make this part short because I can't really stand to think about all those surgeries at Duke. The first time they did a "vulgar osteotomy," which I don't really remember what that is. It involved a plate in her thigh somehow and some work on her hip. That didn't work, so a year or so later, her doctor, Dr. Robert Fitch, decided to try a hip fusion to keep her hip from moving at all by putting pins in and using bone from her other hip. I thought that was sort of sad because her leg would have to permanently stay

in a semi-bent position, changing her wheelchair positioning and keeping her from sleeping on her stomach. I remember watching her sleep the night before her surgery on her stomach, knowing she could never do that again.

She then had to stay in a full body cast for six weeks from her arm pits down to her ankles while the hip healed. The only thing is that after the six weeks the hip still hadn't healed, so she had to have another put on for another six weeks. It still didn't heal, and she still complained. So she had a fluoroscopy (moving x-ray) which showed that her hip was still moving, and they designed a removeable plastic turtle-shell kind of cast for her to wear to keep her body still. It was a pain to manage, and you had to be really careful not to pinch her when you put it on.

Then one day Gene carried her in and sort of tossed her down on her bed. We heard a big crack; it was her hip fusion breaking apart. So it was back to hip pain.

Then it was about this time that she developed scoliosis really bad. In fact, her doctor said it was the worst case he had ever seen come on so fast. Within a couple of months, she went from being able to sit up to having to be tied into her wheelchair so she could sit up fairly straight. Dr. Fitch said it was bad enough that she had to have surgery immediately or she could die—it was something about her ribs taking away the room her lungs had to breathe and her other organs had to function.

The solution was to put rods on either side of her spine and screw them into her backbone to straighten her back out. Then they would take bone from her hip and put in between her discs so it would fuse together. It sounded horrible to me, and I couldn't

stand the thought of it. I cried from the time I heard that until the surgery was actually over.

I cried the whole time we took her down to Duke and the whole time before surgery. I cried the whole time she was in surgery. Even at some point during the surgery, Dr. Fitch came out to tell us all was going (or had gone) well and I was sobbing. He looked at Gene and said, “What is wrong with her?” Gene said I had just been so upset I couldn’t stop crying, so Dr. Fitch assured me that she would be fine and that there just hadn’t been a choice.

Not only had I cried endlessly, but I had prayed endlessly. Plus, she, of course, had gotten priesthood blessing. And it turned into a miracle.

After she got out of surgery, she never complained of one bit of pain from her back. She was still complaining about hip pain, but not back pain. She did so well that she was able to go home far earlier than they originally had thought. And she has never complained since or had any problem. The Lord heard my prayers and accepted my sacrifice.

She still kept complaining about her hip hurting, though. When I took her back to Duke for the six-week checkup after her back surgery, she started screaming at the top of her lungs when we laid her on the table. When Dr. Fitch came in, he just shook his head and said, “I don’t know what to do about her hip, but I’ll try.”

So six weeks later, we made the trip down to Duke for more surgery. When he came in to see Dawn the night before the surgery, Dr. Fitch said, “Please tell her hip pain

is gone.” I said, “No.” He said again that he had no idea what he was going to do, but, hopefully, he could figure out something when he got in there.”

The worst part about Dawn’s surgeries, I think, was that she had no idea what was going to happen. She was always so excited about getting down there and seeing everyone since she had no memory of the pain of the surgeries before. I think it was the last surgery she was just laughing and talking in the pre-op room while I was feeling like a jerk knowing what pain she was going to be in when she got out. It was horrible. Just writing about it upsets me.

So Dr. Fitch did a resection on her hip that last time, cutting off the head of the femur and separating it from her hip. The idea was to let soft tissue grow between the two and cushion them from rubbing against each other. For that to happen, he had to put her in traction. He had told me about that, but he hadn’t explained that it involved drilling a hole all the way through her knee and inserting a rod that was hooked up to the traction device. I almost fainted when I first saw that, but then we realized that it did pull the leg down and relieve the pain she had been in. She was supposed to stay in that for several days while the soft tissue filled in.

Our hopeful expectations were short-lived, however, because some intern came in one morning and unhooked the traction. I guess he was doing it under Dr. Fitch’s orders, but Dawn was immediately in pain again. I was in Danville and Mother was at Duke with her when this happened. I called to check on her and could hear her whining and crying in the background. Mother said they had given her pain medicine, but it hadn’t done any

good.

I immediately took off for Duke, unable to stand the thought of her being in pain. When I got there, I found out that Dr. Fitch would be in surgery all day, and the intern wouldn't believe me when I told him that she needed more Valium to reduce her muscle spasms. It was a horrible day until Dr. Fitch came in for evening rounds and increased her Valium plus hooked her traction back up for a few more days. I'll never forgive myself for not kicking an absolute fit and making the people in charge of the pain control in the hospital come.

Her hip pain was reduced a little, but wasn't completely solved. In the weeks to come, she even stopped eating. We finally had to have an MRI done because she had this huge mass in her abdomen, but when they saw the results they realized it was because she had lost so much weight that her backbone was literally about one inch from the front of her abdomen. I called Dr. Fitch, and he met us in the Duke emergency room to examine her. He agreed with the diagnosis and said he couldn't believe it.

This was in 1996?

After that surgery, things became very difficult with Dawn's behavior. The psychologist I consulted at Duke said he thought that she turned her frustration and inability to deal with her physical pain against me. She wouldn't eat for me and either spit or hit me whenever I came nearby. It was very difficult. By that time, she had been on the waiting list for The Virginia Home for two years with two more to go.

Now let's jump back a little

I had always wanted to be a writer and/ or reporter. Other kids used to watch “Superman” on television for the super-hero, but I liked the part where Clark Kent and Lois Lane were reporters. I had written some stuff for literary magazines in junior high and high school, but they were always rejected and never published. Then it was sort of put in the back of my mind for something to do when the kids were older.

But then Orson Scott Card came into my life as a stake high-councilman back in 1981, I believe. It was the year he and his wife, Kristine, had a son, Charlie, born with cerebral palsy. When he visited the ward and saw how (in his opinion) we handled Dawn so well, he wanted to talk to us, so we invited them to come over for dinner one Sunday after he visited the ward. He had published several books in the science fiction market by that time.

While we were eating, I got up all the nerve I had and told him that I had always wanted to be a writer. He, of course, said, “Well, write something, and I will read it.” I’m sure hundreds had said the same thing to him and he had said the same thing to them. But I did it.

I wrote three short stories over the next week and mailed them to him. He especially liked two of them. One I sent in to the old Ensign writing contest they used to have, and I actually won third place and \$125. I was thrilled! I kept writing stories, and he kept reading them, but he finally told me to try writing a novel. So over the next few months, I put whoever the babies were then down for naps and would write an hour or

hour and a half. I wound up with the book A Rock for Sister Lewis, and Scott really liked it.

I don't remember the timeline, but I sent the book off to Deseret Book, and they liked it! By that time, it was 1986 and Paulette was getting married to Bruce out in Provo, so I told the editors I would be out then because they wanted to meet with me.

It was such a thrilling time. At that time, the Joseph Smith Memorial Building downtown SLC was the Hotel Utah, so Elinor Knowles, the head editor, and another editor took me to lunch in the restaurant on the top floor. I remember I had salmon and raspberries in cream for dessert (just raspberries in cream, not the salmon) and almost knocked over my water goblet reaching for my dessert. They loved my book, and, in fact, only questioned the fact that I had left a period off one of the sentences. They told me the board of directors, which consisted of some amount of General Authorities, would meet and approve the books for publication for the coming year, and they would call me.

It seems like it took forever to get a call back. It might have been several months. Then, finally, one day while I was folding clothes (what else?), Elinor Knowles called and started talking about the weather out in Virginia because it had been really dry. I didn't think it could be good news. It wasn't. She said that some of the people on the board were uncomfortable with the way the character of the bishop was portrayed—he was too bumbling and uninspired, and she was real sorry, but they wouldn't be able to publish it. I was crushed, not only because my book wasn't being published but also because I almost felt like I had sinned.

I think I tried a couple of other publishing companies, but then just gave up and put it away and started on a book in which the male priesthood figures would be impeccable! I was determined then to publish a book with Deseret Book.

I think it was about a year later—I know it was after we moved to Parker Rd., so it must have been after 1987—that Scott Card suddenly called one evening and said that he was starting a publishing company, which had always been his dream, and that he wanted my novel to be the first book they published. Once again, I was thrilled!

Then, at some point, I sent True Rings the Heart to Deseret Book, and they loved it and this time they wanted to go all the way and publish it. So that is how I got a book published in 1989 and then the next year in 1990. I had made sure the priesthood holders in the book were of perfect in every way—unrealistic but necessary.

This was back when the custom was to give royalties, so with the \$500 royalty I got from Scott, I paid to take a journalism class at Averett in the spring semester of 1989. David Hoffman was my advisor, and Mike Hammond was my first teacher. I had decided that if I liked school and if I could get some scholarship money, I would go full-time and finish. Well, I loved school and I got some scholarships, so I started school in the fall of 1989 to get a degree in English and journalism.

I absolutely fell in love with going to school, and there followed two-and-a-half years of pure pleasure of going to school full-time. I wound out being good friends with the professors more so than the students since they were so much younger than I was. But I loved learning, and I was good at it. I had a 4.0 GPA the whole way through college and

on graduation day earned several awards for my achievement.

I also did an internship at the Chamber of Commerce, which was a lot of fun and not much work at all for three semester hours.

During this time, Dawn started going to the Virginia School for the Deaf and Blind in Hampton. It had been approved for the multi-handicapped at that time. I think she started in 1991 because Gene and I took the kids to Atlantic Beach for our first vacation in about 12 years during that summer and then again the next summer.

At first Dawn only came home once a month, but then at some point, they started sending them every weekend. She made the long trip home on Friday afternoons and then back on Sunday. She never seemed to mind, but I always felt guilty about it. I wish now in retrospect I hadn't sent her, but the school people seemed to think it was the best thing for her and it was nice having the time during the week to spend with the other kids. She finished up there in June of 1995. (I'll have to check on those dates—I know she didn't go for that many years.)

I was so sad when I was finished with Averett. And little did I know that an incident that happened the day of my graduation was a foreshadowing of the next few months when my life was to change dramatically. Gene was upset that I wanted him to wear something other than blue jeans to my graduation. He didn't have many other clothes since he wore blue jeans to work, so he finally pulled out his suit pants and threw a shirt at me, saying, "Now that you're finished with school, you can go back to ironing shirts like a good wife should."

One fun thing that happened toward the end of school was that I had an assignment in one of my classes to write three columns. I wrote three humorous columns about raising seven children, and the class and Dr. Hoffman thought they were really good and funny.

So I got up all my nerve and sent them to Bonnie Cooper, the editor at the Register & Bee, and told her I would like to be a columnist for the paper. Well, she called me back a few days later and said they would love to run my column. So over the next eight years I wrote a column called 7XMOM. Sometimes it was weekly and sometimes it was biweekly. It proved to be real popular in the city and people still ask me about it. (In fact, some of them don't realize I haven't written in for about six years.)

I hadn't really planned on going to work after I graduated. Gene's businesses seemed to be doing well—a lot better than our marriage was. I had always looked forward to the time when the kids would all be in school and I would have time to write and do all the things I hadn't been able to do while caring for them and Dawn. It didn't turn out that way, though.

The Beginning and the End of the End

Well, now's the part where I really don't know what to say. I don't want to share too many details about what went wrong between Gene and me, yet at the same time I want to warn you children about falling into the same traps your father did. So I will go slowly and prayerfully.

Probably the year before Gene actually left in 1991, our marriage was very unhappy for me, although I hadn't been happy for many years. Gene was always gone, and when he was home, he wasn't very nice to me or you kids. The older ones of you probably remember. He didn't see us all week because he got up after you left for school and didn't come home from working in Clarksville or Keysville until long after everyone was in bed. When he was home, he slept or ordered everyone around. It wasn't like I wanted my marriage to be.

Then in the fall of 1991, I believe, Jane, Paulette, Gene, and I went up to the Washington temple overnight, and Gene was especially mean to me in front of Paulette and Jane. When we got home, he sort of laughed it off when I tried to talk to him about it. But, standing in the door of our bathroom with him lying on the bed, I said what I had been thinking for a long time—that I didn't think I wanted to be married to him anymore. That sort of scared him, I guess, and he agreed to go with me to a marriage counselor.

So we went to many sessions with an LDS counselor in Greensboro, but, unfortunately, this counselor was into “men's issues” and basically blamed all our problems on the fact that Gene grew up without a father. He tried to teach Gene how to be a righteous father, but it didn't work. Gene sort of got the idea he was to be a ruler of his family like King David and that everyone was supposed to obey him and serve him.

To make a long story short, Gene didn't want to go back and things deteriorated even more. I just wanted out, but I didn't want to do anything that would hurt the kids and I took my temple covenants seriously and realized the gravity of leaving a covenant

marriage. So we kept on, but it certainly wasn't a celestial marriage.

A necessary flashback I share for what it will teach you kids: When Mary Susan was just an infant, I found out that Gene was selling adult movies at his video stores, even though he had told me he wasn't. I found a note on the floor he had written to one of his employees to get the adult movies fixed. I firmly believe the Lord caused me to find that.

I was devastated to think he was doing that, had lied to me, and had made such unrighteousness choices in his life. That night I met him at the door when he came home late and all the kids were asleep with a suitcase packed and Mary Susan's car seat ready. I told him what I had found, how and I felt about it, and told him that if he didn't stop selling adult movies and go talk to Bishop Carpenter, I was leaving and would be back in the morning for the rest of the children. It was an ultimatum, and I prayed he would do the right thing.

He took me seriously for some reason and agreed to stop selling them. Over the next couple of days, he talked to Bishop Carpenter, who said Gene had made some "bad business decisions." I think his casual attitude toward what Gene had done only exacerbated the problem, which would crop up again. But I was so happy that Gene had chosen to stay with me and try to make me happy. Or so I thought.

Back to 1992: At the beginning of the summer, Gene and I had a bad argument, and he left for a week, living in Clarksville, I suppose. After several days, I drove to Clarksville to see him at work. I got there just as he pulled up in his car and Debi in her

car behind him, which I thought was strange, especially after I saw the look of shock on both of their faces. When I walked into the store, I felt like they were embarrassed and I was intruding.

Gene said he would talk to me after he did something in the store. I stayed in the office area and found out there he still had a generous supply of adult videos. I got very upset and confronted him about them. He said he had promised me he wouldn't "sell" adult movies anymore, so he had started leasing them to convenience stores. And he thought that was okay. I left and drove the whole way home crying and knowing that things were going downhill fast.

I don't remember how that was resolved. He did finally come home after a week. I thought things were better, but he left again with no promises of staying home. When he was home, his abuse worsened, and I started keeping my eyes and ears open because I started to suspect something was going on between Debi and Gene.

That summer is sort of a blur. I know Jenny and I went out to Utah to check out BYU, and when we were flying home, I didn't want to come home to Gene. I seriously considered getting the kids and going back out to Utah. I couldn't figure out what to do about Dawn, though, and I still felt the duty (or burden) to the temple marriage.

But things got worse. Then Gene left for a video convention and when he got back, he was sick. I found out later he had taken Debi with him. Then, on Thursday August 6th of 1992, I woke up early at 6 a.m. and distinctly heard a voice say, "Susan, go look in his car." I don't often hear the voice of the Spirit speak so distinctly, so I turned

over and tried to go back to sleep. But I heard it distinctly again: “Susan, go look in his car.”

So I got up, went outside, and opened the trunk of his Toyota and found evidence there in the form of letters that he had been having an affair with someone, although I didn’t know who at that time. My whole life crumbled in front of me and, shaking and weak, I went back in the house, woke him up and angrily told him what I had found and told him to get out of the house.

Then I called Mother to come and get me. She met me on the gravel road, and I went home with her. I gave Gene time to leave and then came back to the house before the kids had woken up.

He disappeared for four days. I kept calling the stores, and the employees kept saying they hadn’t seen him. I didn’t know whether to believe he was some place repenting or someplace committing suicide. During that time, I finally figured out the letters had been written by Debi, and I called her and told her what I knew and that I wanted to speak to Gene. She denied it, of course.

Then Gene came down the road four days later. I was shocked to find out he had come back, not to apologize and beg my forgiveness but to collect his things to leave, especially his VCR. I begged him to come back over the next few weeks, but he just kept saying that he “wasn’t ready to do the things he needed to do to come back.” Nothing Bishop Carpenter said did any good either.

Bishop Carpenter was actually supportive to me during that time, but something

happened between him and his wife during that time that caused them to withdraw their membership from the church a few months later. I think it had something to do with me, but I've never known for sure. I wasn't guilty of anything inappropriate, and the stake president, who knew their reasons for leaving, told me I had done all I could do to try to make things better and not to worry about it anymore. (I had tried my best to talk to Nancy and find out what I had done to make them upset.)

Oh well, the next few months were difficult. The kids were upset, deservedly so, and money was a problem constantly because Gene didn't want to give me any money until we met with our lawyers and took care of that problem.

Then Tommy Strange entered the picture. I really don't want to talk much about that period in my life. I've always wished I had one of those lights that Tommy Lee Jones and Will Smith flashed in front of people's faces in Men in Black and made them forget parts of their lives.

I think I know why I was meant to go through that—it certainly saved me from losing the house—but that's all I want to say. He took advantage of my emotions when I was very vulnerable, and I'll never let that happen again.

It ended when he got upset Easter morning in 1996 when the boys got mud on our new asphalt driveway and he attacked me. My boys got him off me, and I had him thrown in jail overnight. (Such white trash stuff.) Anyway, it was over, and I try not to think about it. He had a serious personality disorder, which he would never admit. I wasn't the first woman to suffer because of it.

Daddy's Death

The year of 1996 was also the year Daddy died. He had found out maybe three years before that he had prostate cancer and had decided to have a prostatectomy. But when they opened him up to do that, they also biopsied some lymph nodes and found out he also had Non-Hodgkins Lymphoma. For some reason they just closed him back up, but he decided not long after to go ahead and have the prostatectomy.

Supposedly, the lymphoma was in such early stages that he wasn't supposed to have any problems with it for many years, but it turned aggressive pretty fast. He went through several courses of chemo and radiation, but nothing worked.

On New Year's Day of 1996, his doctor came by the house and told him that it was time for him to go on respite care, which meant that he probably had less than six months to live. It took only 18 days after that for him to die, though. He went downhill rapidly after finding out he was terminal. Blessedly, I guess, he was unconscious the last few days of his life. He died at home on January 18.

Only three months early in October, Billy had died. Daddy was in too bad of health to do much at that time but to sit by Billy's bed. I've often wondered if he wondered how many months it would be before he would be the one in the bed dying.

Daddy was a wonderful father. I learned kindness and a compassion for all people from him. He also loved to cook for people, which I think I got from him. He was raised in poverty and had a horrible family life growing up, but he really turned his life around

and made something of himself.

I still have a hard time thinking about him without crying. I just put it out of mind to think about at another time. I know I will see him again. He was a wonderful grandfather too, and I often think about how much he would enjoy knowing his great-grandchildren, but I know he can look down on them and see them in their lives. I like to think he can be with the children in the family who have yet to born, so he warn them about the family they are getting themselves into! Or maybe the streets of heaven are paved in linoleum instead of gold and he's the one doing it!

I finally got enough sense that summer to call it quits with Tommy.

Then Dennis left on his mission to the Philippines in August, and sometime in that time period, Dawn had her final surgery.

Enter David

I also met and dated David for the first time on August 26, 1996. Our friend in common, Gail Megginson, matched us up. He had been wanting to date me because he thought I sounded interesting in my newspaper columns.

I finally agreed in August to date him because I thought my divorce from Tommy would be final in September. It took until December, though, so I probably shouldn't have dated until then. Oh well, water under the bridge.

Dawn was then too old to go to public school, so she basically stayed home for two years until she got a spot at the Virginia Home in 1998.

I got hired by the newspaper the end of August of 1996. It was my first full-time job, and it was a hard one. Bless Mother's heart, she took care of Dawn and the kids for me free of charge the next two years.

I've talked about it with her several times and thanked her, but she's said she doesn't really have any memory of it being difficult. Plus, she has said she needed something to do during that time to adjust to Daddy being gone.

The newspaper job was hard. I was the arts and entertainment writer. I had asked Bonnie about several reporting jobs before, but she always told me she didn't think I could handle the evening hours. But when the A&E spot came open, she called me and said, "I think I have a job you can handle."

At that time, there was a Saturday reporter, so I didn't have to work Saturdays. We did have to work cops night one night a week, which was hard—especially because it seemed like something criminal happened every night I worked cops. It got to be a joke after a while.

I was also dating David and quickly falling in love with him. He was so good and kind to me and to the kids. After a while, he would come over every night to see me and leave at 11:30. I was also teaching seminary, and I don't remember how I lasted on so little sleep!

Dawn had gotten too old to go to school, so suddenly she was back home and I was working. Mother was wonderful and came over every day to babysit for her and the other kids until I could get home. Dennis had left for his mission in August of 1996 and

Jenny was at BYU, so I still had five kids at home, plus working a demanding job. But Mother helped me out and never asked for anything in return. It kept her busy until Dawn went into The Virginia Home in Richmond in 1998. And, of course, she has always adored Dawn and Dawn her.

So David and I dated for 16 months before we got married. He asked me to marry him on a picnic on the Blue Ridge Parkway on my birthday in 1997. Well, he didn't really ask me. He said, "I want to marry you." I assumed an answer was necessary, so I said yes!

He wanted to get married on Thanksgiving, but I wanted to be able to file my taxes as "single head-of-household" again the next year, so I suggested New Year's Day 1998. So that's when we got married. (And I got enough income tax refund back that year to buy a new computer.)

For our honeymoon, we stayed a couple of days up at the Peaks of Otter lodge. I slipped on the ice going into the lodge and tore my knee all up. I still have the scars.

The Rest of the Story So Far

So finally, I have a peaceful marriage and a man who has been good to me. It took a good man to marry a woman with five kids still at home and writing a newspaper column that revealed to the world all the stupid and crazy things in our lives.

I worked at the newspaper until 1998, but applied for just about every job at Averett during that time. Finally, I bagged the job as director of the learning center, which

immediately resulted in four months less work a year and a \$4,000 pay raise. I arranged for the students at Averett to be matched up with tutors, and I did a generous amount of writing tutoring.

About the second year I worked there, I was asked to teach an English 100 class and gradually through the years decided to go to graduate school at Longwood College in Farmville and get my master's degree in literature. That way I could teach more classes. Finally, I wound up teaching three classes per semester of English 100, the remedial English class; English 11, Introduction to Writing and Research; and English 112, Introduction to Literature.

Then in 2003, the newest English professor was fired because she was so difficult to get along with and Steve Ausband asked me if I would like to be full-time faculty, even though I had only a master's degree and it was going to be a non-tenured position. Dr. Pfau, Averett's president, told Steve to assure me that my job would be protected.

I should have run from that offer and stayed with the learning center. I taught full-time one year, which really was a dream come true, and I thought I did a good job. Then on the Wednesday after graduation on the first Saturday in May in 2004, Jeff Fager, the academic dean, called me and asked me to come into his office the next day. There was only reason he would want me to do that, so I said, "You aren't going to tell me I don't have a job, are you?"

He hesitated and then said, "Well, we forgot to put your job in the budget for next year." He then offered me three adjunct classes for the next year, but I was crying by that

time and said I couldn't talk.

I think I'm still recovering from that. I've never really wanted to work outside my home, but that was about as good as it got since I got so much time off. The papers to grade weren't fun, but I got them done.

So then I went to teach at Hargrave Military Academy the next year, and I was totally miserable again every single day. The students were horrible, especially the ninth-graders, and I just never could handle them. I took it one very long year and then quit, hoping to start a free-lance writing business.

That summer—2005—was a perfect situation for me. I freelanced for the paper, but I was home with my children who came home for college. Then that fall, after my salary with Hargrave ran out in August, I decided to go back to working full-time for the Danville Register & Bee. I'm still there at this writing. I write the Dan River Life feature sections on Wednesdays and Sundays and am the general assignment writer. I'm good at it, other people enjoy my writing and I enjoy it, but the working on Saturdays and holidays won't work for long.

I'm also back teaching two classes at Averett this semester. That's okay. I enjoy the students, even though I never feel as at ease in front of a classroom as I do at the newspaper. We'll see what happens.

How I Decided to Put Dawn in The Virginia Home

Out of all the things that have happened in my life that have made me who I am

today, I think having Dawn has affected me the most. Joining the church was major, but the way I look at it, I was always a member of the church—I just didn't know it for 18 years. I've never thought I could say the gospel has been a major part of my life because, in my eyes, the gospel is life.

So that leaves Dawn. I found out she had cerebral palsy when I was 20 years old. That seems amazing to me. She is now 33, and for every minute of that 33 years, the circumstances of her mortality affect me. Even when I am fortunate enough not to be consciously thinking of her, she is there.

I'm still not at the point where I can see the blessing of having Dawn in my life. I suppose if forced to evaluate it, I would say that I am patient because of the time I have spent with her. Maybe if I have any goodness in my life, it is because of her. I can't really say because I don't know how I would be without her.

Anyway, others might think the decision to put her at The Virginia Home was easy and necessary for me to do, but leaving her there the first times and every one of the hundreds of times I have done so since have been hard. Leaving her always tears my heart out. The trips to Richmond every other Saturday are difficult, but I think it's harder not being there and knowing she doesn't have anyone with her on the weekends that is harder. During the week, she has activities, but not much happens on the weekends, and, when it does, Dawn becomes her own worst enemy and refuses to participate.

So why did I put her there? I think it's hard to explain to someone who doesn't know what tremendous stress is on a person who is taking care of a completely dependent

person, especially someone who can be as difficult to get along with as Dawn. Maybe you kids remember how we always had to consider Dawn's needs first and how difficult it was to live a normal life. It was incredibly difficult to get to ball games, go shopping, go to school functions, etc.

Now, before you think I'm whining, let me say that I think I did a good job at taking care of everybody and making each child think he or she was the only one I had to take care of. So if you think I'm not remembering things correctly and it wasn't that hard, let me assure you it was and my memory is the most accurate, since you all had your own lives and mine was mainly taking care of Dawn. She has always been my Gethsemane from the time I was very young. Think about your own lives at 20 and imagine yourself finding out that your child is handicapped and most of the rest of your life would revolve around that, whatever your hopes and dreams had been. I hope none of you ever know that.

Maybe I'm just not one of those people who can selflessly care for another, but I never enjoyed it. Every minute was hard, but I tried and know the Lord knows my heart. I gradually overcame any patience and tried very hard to treat Dawn as the Savior would treat her or to take care of her as a person whose calling and election is made sure. Every moment of my time with her, I am aware she has earned her celestial reward premortally, while I am still struggling to earn mine.

After her surgeries, however, and during that whole time when we were trying to control her hip pain, Dawn was unable to understand her pain with any kind of

perspective because of her mental retardation and she turned the blame of it against me. (A visit with a psychologist at Duke enlightened me on this.) So she spent several years hating me, hitting me, spitting at me and generally refusing to cooperate with me. That made taking care of her even harder. I don't know what I would have done without my mother.

Her behavior, her increasing size and the difficulty in one person caring for her, as well as the utter lack of services here in Danville finally led us to the conclusion to find a place for her to live where we could see her and make sure she was all right, but where the day-to-day burden of care didn't fall on me. (The "we" is basically Mother and me—your father was out of the picture by that time.)

So someone told us about The Virginia Home, and Mother and I trekked off to see it. We liked what we saw and put her on the waiting list.

During the four years we waited, she spent two at the School for the Deaf and Blind at Hampton and two at home (1996-98) which I think I've already discussed.

I still remember the day I got the call at work at the paper that a spot had opened up for her at The Virginia Home. I cried because I couldn't believe I was doing it, but I did. David and I had been married about six months then, and he and I took her up on June 8, 1998.

She seemed tickled to be there, but within a couple of days (I stayed in close contact), she was begging to go home. So Mother, Paulette and I went up that Saturday to see her. It took everything I had to leave her there again, but I did. In fact, the first four or

five years, Mother and I went up individually to see her, and every time I left I cried.

Then in 2004, I believe, we decided to start going together, and I haven't cried because it would upset Mother, but I feel like it every time. Every Saturday night I come home from Richmond, I'm depressed. Usually, I wind up those evenings in the bathroom, crying and begging the Lord to somehow make this all right.

Even though my patriarchal blessing says I will have a wonderful gift of the Holy Spirit, I don't ever feel like I do. I've never had a spiritual confirmation—a “burning in my bosom”—that has sealed that witness to me that it's okay that I put Dawn in a home. I told Pres. Mitchell Scott one time soon after I took her to Richmond that I wish I would hear a still, small voice confirming to me that it had been the right thing to do, and he leaned over and said, “Yes, you have, Susan. I'm telling you now.” So I guess I'm depending on him being there and telling the Lord in front of the judgment bar that it's okay and I didn't abandon one of His children.

Every breath I take is a prayer for her to be okay and know she's loved. She seems to be happy—as happy as Dawn ever is. Even when she is home, she doesn't seem particularly happy. I think her mental retardation is a blessing in that she doesn't realize what she is missing in life.

My prayer is that she will die before Mother does because I don't know how in the world I would ever go to Richmond and tell her that Mother has died. We laugh and joke about how we will have to take Mother's body to a taxidermist and have it stuffed, so I can keep taking her up with me to see Dawn, but it's a very real worry for me.

I pray every day that Dawn's life will not be prolonged. I don't want her to suffer or to be in any pain, but I wish she would just look up to the sky like Charlie Card did and slip from this existence into the next where she has already earned her exaltation. I guess it's a selfish desire since life would be easier for me, or maybe I haven't learned what I'm supposed to yet, and that's why it hasn't been answered. Who can know the mind of God?

One experience this year gave me just a glimpse into what worth Dawn has been to me in my life. One Saturday this summer, David, Mother and I took Cameron and Ashlyne up with us to visit Dawn and after we had come home that night, I was sitting on the bed in the computer room with Cameron while we were having a lightning storm.

He looked up at me with all innocence and said, "Grandma, when there is a storm where Dawn lives, is she afraid?"

I looked down at him and said, "No, Cameron, because I pray for Dawn all the time that she will be okay, so I know Heavenly Father takes care of her when I can't be there."

That satisfied him, but I was left to ponder on that. Then, the next day in sacrament meeting, Mich Suyama was giving a talk. I don't even remember what it was about, but I remember that while he was speaking in his own sweet, spiritual way, the feeling came over me that had I not had years with Dawn that I wouldn't have the faith necessary to tell Cameron that I knew my prayers were answered and that Heavenly Father watched over her. That is one of the few times I have realized the blessing in my

own life of having Dawn. It will be interesting to see the rest.

I think often about bringing Dawn home, especially now that my life is not busy with other children. The main reason I don't, however, is that I worry about her care as I get older. I can't stand the thought of my getting sick or dying and Dawn having to go someplace here in town or the training school in Lynchburg, which is so depressing. So even when I think I could soothe my conscience and bring her back home, I just can't get to the point that I can take the chance of her winding up someplace other than the Virginia Home, where she would have to wait years again to earn a place.

I pray daily that if there is any way I can bring her closer or even home that Heavenly Father show me the way so clearly that I will not doubt it. So far, that has not happened. But I still struggle with whether it was the right decision or not, and I hope I am not gambling my salvation on it.

The Last Ten Years of My Life

I am going to summarize this or I will never get finished with this. I think I will plan on updating it every New Year's Day.

In the last 12 years, I have sent four sons on a mission. No matter what anyone says about the blessings of sons on missions, it is so hard. By the time Brady left, I was down to just one kid at home, and it turned out being one of the hardest times of my life. I counted every day until he came home. I was terrified of earthquakes and tsunamis.

I missed all my sons, but that last one was the hardest. And it wasn't because I

loved him anymore, but because I could see the emptiness of my house just a few months down the road when Mary Susan left.

If I had my way, all my kids and grandkids would live within a mile of me and all gather at my house for a big Sunday dinner.

I think if I could relive one evening before I died, I would choose to relive a Friday night football game watching Tunstall play. Life doesn't get any better than that. A beautiful sunset, a good hot dog, the sound of the not-so-good Tunstall band and watching my boys play football and Mary Susan cheer were good times for me.

I remember leaving work at Averett early one football Friday night and walking across the commons. There was an autumn nip in the air, the leaves were falling and I was heading home for a football game. I just paused for a moment and felt it. I told myself to remember that night because soon my kids would be gone and there would be no Friday night football. I wanted that evening to last forever.

And I was right. It seemed like no time that Mary Susan was at BYU, and the house was quiet. The first time Tunstall played the first year she was gone, David and I went to watch them play Martinsville. I envisioned myself as a lifelong fan who would always be at the games. But, sitting there in the stands that were at one time the happiest place for me to be, was so sad I cried. We haven't been back to a game since.

It took me about four months to be able to walk into the house after work when there were no school kids waiting for me and not cry. I tried to postpone coming home until David was due home, so I wouldn't have to walk into an empty house. Two years

later, I am doing better, but still know that my greatest work I ever did was being a mother and I will always look back on raising my children as the best time of my life, however difficult it was. I miss them.

But there are been good times with them grown too. Being at their temple weddings is a wonderful experience for me and gives me a glimpse into an eternity when I won't have to say good-bye to them ever again. They have all chosen good, righteous spouses and I am proud of them.

And I can't say enough about how wonderful it is to have grandchildren, although I wish I lived close enough to see them more often.

The Years 56 Through 60

2009-2013

I think I ended the big chunk of my life's story saying I was going to update it every New Year's Day. Hah! That hasn't happened. But here I am, on Sept. 22, 2013, just having turned 60 four days ago and I am going to update what I have done the last four years. I'll note when I actually finish this.

May I begin by saying that I had the most wonderful surprise of perhaps my life last weekend when my children, behind my back gathered for the weekend before my birthday. I'll save myself some time and copy and paste the 7XMOM column I wrote about it and then add details at the end.

Here it is:

I was living a lie and didn't even know it.

For weeks before my Big 6-0 birthday I was being manipulated by my family into believing my birthday was going to be ordinary when, in fact, they were planning an extraordinary birthday for me.

I knew my son Brady and his family were going to be down for a weeklong visit from where he's in graduate school in Chicago and leave the day before my birthday, Wednesday, Sept. 18.

My daughter Jenny and her family and my son Michael and his wife were coming up from North Carolina for a birthday dinner the weekend before.

Having half of my children is pretty typical for any holiday, so I was happy.

Since Wednesdays are a full day of teaching and then a meeting at church at night, there wasn't much room for fun on my actual birthday, and that was fine. My sister said she'd take me out to lunch during my break between classes.

I said, "Sure, but since I'm getting so old, let's do Chinese since I hate Chinese food and I can be really miserable." We both laughed. She was in on the lie too.

I kept assuring my daughter Jenny I had plenty of chicken and sweet potatoes on hand for the various diets and allergies for the birthday dinner, and she kept saying, "Don't you worry about anything! It's all taken care of."

Boy, was it!

The week Brady was there I had everything planned, but in the quiet, persuasive way he talks, one which his older daughter has inherited, he changed most of my plans. Instead of going to the Greensboro Natural Science Center on Friday, he said it would be better to go on Thursday. I don't remember why, but I changed the plans.

When we were at Sam's Club buying food for the weekend, he essentially talked me out of all the meals I had planned and directed me towards hamburgers and hot dogs and then talked me out of buying the meat.

At one point, I turned my shopping cart around and prayed, "Dear Lord, give me patience. He's changing everything."

No one can ever say I'm stubborn.

My sister-in-law, Jane, was in town for a wedding, so he did let me go out to lunch with her on Friday. (Actually she's my former sister-in-law, but I always claim I got custody of her in the divorce.) Brady wanted to go with us, but right before he persuaded me of that, he said he wouldn't go.

I had talked to Dennis the night before so my "mother locator" knew he was safe in Utah. Mary Susan texted me during lunch wanting to Skype so I knew she was in Texas. I don't usually hear from Mark until Sunday so I figured he was safe in Arkansas.

Not so. Dennis was in the car with Michael down at the Raleigh-Durham Airport when I talked to him, and Mary Susan was in my living room when she texted me. And Jane was keeping me busy talking while they all gathered at my house and hid their cars behind the house.

I had wondered why my husband, David, had cleaned up the backyard woodpile so close to wood-burning season, but I hadn't asked. He was perpetuating the lie too.

Jane and I pulled up in front of the house and Jane said she'd come in for a few minutes to visit. I didn't hear all the giggling that hushed as I turned the door knob.

I opened the door and there, lined up against the back wall, were my kids from all over the country!

"Surprise!" "Happy birthday!" they called out.

I was so happy.

They said they were afraid I'd have a heart attack, which is why lunch with Jane, an ER nurse, worked out well.

Two spouses-in-law didn't come and six grandchildren didn't come, the prices of plane tickets being what they are, but the weekend was wonderful.

A basic tenet of the faith my children and I believe in is that families can be together eternally. This weekend was just a taste of that.

It was a wonderful lie which continues to warm my heart with its memory. For a couple of days, being 60 didn't seem so bad. (The end.)

What a nice time we had! I realized that my children loved me and that I was important to them. I guess I sort of suspected that they did, but to spend all that money and go to all that trouble to actually make me feel important made me feel very loved.

Even now when I want to feel loved I think back all walking into the living room and seeing all of my children lined up in my living room and feel so wonderful.

If you kids are reading this in the years to come and I'm no longer with you, please know that the weekend that you surprised me meant so much to me and I really appreciated it. And thank you to Tim and Tarin for letting Mary Susan and Dennis come. I really wish you could have been here too, along with your children.

That surprise was one of the best days of my life. Maybe my best one, if you don't count having babies, which involve a lot of pain, so maybe it was the best.

Five years since I turned 55. In some ways those years have been hard spiritually. I remember waking up New Year's Day the year I was to turn 55 and realizing with a profound sense of my mortality that in 15 years I would turn 70. I was suddenly old.

That immediately sent my faith and my testimony spiraling down, not that I lost it, but I questioned whether I had a testimony or not strong enough for me to face death. I think I had always taken my testimony for granted and never questioned it. Then I began to question it.

It took me probably three years to climb out of that, and I think I am finally out of it, although I will always wonder about the difference between knowledge and faith. I'm thankful for Elder Holland's talk that all we are ever required to do in this life is live by faith.

There were some dark times, though, and a lot of prayer. I'm grateful that along

the way I was called to be the Gospel Doctrine teacher. That really helped, especially the year that I taught the Book of Mormon.

I'm still afraid of getting old and dying, but I really think everyone is. I used to think that old people were OK with that since, well, they were old, but I know now, they aren't. They just do the best they can.

The lucky ones go quickly doing something they enjoy. I wrote a story a while back about a well-loved volunteer at the hospital who was walking down the hallway in the middle of his volunteer work one afternoon when he dropped dead of a massive heart attack. I hope the Lord, knowing how afraid I am of dying, blesses me to die that way. And after Dawn has been gone for many, many years.

Enough on dying. These past five years have also been full of many weddings and many babies. We have been so blessed . . . I hope I get this right.

Let's see. We went through one divorce when Michael's wife left him, but that turned out to be a wonderful blessing because he met and married Evelyn. What a wonderful blessing she has been to him! I'm just not sure why he couldn't have met her first!

But before that, we had three marriages in one year. That was exciting and exhausting.

Mark and Jill got married in April 2007. They had a beautiful wedding out in Salt Lake City. David went out with me, so that was nice, and all my kids were together there,

at least for the reception. They both looked so happy.

The first time I met Jill I went out to Utah when Mark was on an internship in California, so he wasn't even there to introduce us. I think Brady took me to her apartment and I called from the parking lot. Apparently, she wouldn't have liked more notice before I came up to her apartment! But all's well that ends well, and we were blessed with another beautiful, sweet daughter-in-law.

Mark had dated so little in high school—except for Baden and Brandon, of course!—that I wondered how I would ever know when he was getting serious about anyone, but when his brothers started telling me that he had been dating someone for a while and especially that he was calling her by the nickname of “Jillio,” then I figured things were serious. I was right.

Just a few weeks later, Brady proposed to Karissa Flanagan, a pretty Utah girl. He was doing an internship in the Washington, D.C., area and she had flown out to visit. He proposed to her at the D.C. temple. I told him I thought it was a little fast, but he said, “Sometimes you just know it's right,” so I told him he had my blessing.

They were married on Sept. 22 on that same year in the Provo Temple. It was a Saturday and a day of a BYU football game, which didn't set too well with a couple or three of his brothers. Plus traffic was bad in Provo, so I remember being a little stressed out driving to the temple. It was a rainy day, and I remember being impressed how well Karissa handled that. I always knew I wanted someone sweet and nice to have Brady's heart since my baby boy had always been such a sweetie and he found someone.

Then that summer Mary Susan had been a counselor at EFY up at Southern Virginia University and she had met a certain young man who wound up stealing her heart. I was happy because his family lived in Virginia. A lot of good that has done me, though, because as I write this, he's going to be taking her away with a couple of my grandchildren and one on the way to their second trip to California to go back to school. That didn't quite work out the way I thought it would!

I remember the night Tim proposed to Mary Susan because I had oral surgery that day and was totally knocked out on pain killers. He called to tell me what he was going to do, but David had to take the call because I was totally asleep. I've sort of always felt bad about that, but I guess he's forgiven me.

They got married in May of 2008 in the Raleigh Temple and had a reception in downtown Danville in a reception hall that used to belong to Main Street Methodist Church. She remembers it as the most wonderful day of her life. I think it was very stressful, but I'll let her keep her memories!

And so we added another fine young handsome son-in-law to the family that day.

It's hard for me to remember when everyone graduated from college. I have it as my goal to make a timeline of graduations and weddings and babies, but I haven't done it yet. But it seems like the past five years have been filled with graduations and pregnancies and babies, and then everyone started going back to graduate school.

Age 60-65

Well, here it is the summer before I turn 65. The last five years have gone by fast. It seems just recently that my wonderful 60th birthday occurred. I know I can't hope that they are going to all come in again for my 65th birthday, so I am just looking forward to getting on Medicare and not having to pay \$1,000 a month for really bad insurance. And I'm going to try for a giant doughnut again—last year I missed out because Hall's Pastries is closed on Mondays when my birthday was.

FYI: If you are reading this and don't know it, I also have yearly journals in my Word documents. Go to Dropbox, then "A Documents" and then "Journal" to find my yearly journals and to "personal history" to find my history, patriarchal blessing, etc.

Right now I have served as Relief Society president for what will be three years in October. Such interesting work! Just this past week I have rescued a sister from her husband who put her out on the curb at 6 in the morning after he found out she "hooked up" with a man the night before via Tinder. Luckily, I have experience in swearing out emergency protective orders against mean husbands.

I have cleaned up cockroaches and filthy houses, prepared many lessons, visited in the homes of such sad sisters and situations, had many presidency meetings, stood in a puddle of someone's pee, set up and cleaned up countless RS activities, called and

checked on sisters, visited in the hospitals, counseled with members of the priesthood, prepared budgets, traveled down to the storehouse and delivered as many as seven orders in one day to people needing food, gotten electricity bills reduced with the city, and even seized a couple of dogs along the way!

Basically, I never know when I get up in the morning what I will need to do that day, but it is rewarding and exhausting work. I have felt the inspiration and strength of the Lord, though. Somehow I always know what to do.

Dawn has been through some rough times and continues to be my Garden of Gethsemane, even after almost 45 years of living. Last year she was in ICU twice because of kidney stones. What a tremendous trial that was. I'm not sure how she and I got through it, even though she was unconscious most of the time and on a ventilator with her body all swollen up.

She still has two kidney stones and has surgery coming up for those. Dawn's surgeries are the worst times of my life, especially since they happen in Richmond and I am so far away from home and usually alone.

I still can cry every day about Dawn and am tearing up now. My grief and sorrow about her is like a still pool at the bottom of my soul all the time, every minute of the day that rises up and overflows regularly. I don't know why she has lived so long and what I still need to learn for this trial to be over. I pray often that there will be some part of my life I can live without the pull of Dawn's disability on my life and heart. On the TV show "This Is Us" one of the triplet characters on the show—the black one who was adopted

into a white family—said that being adopted had informed every moment of his life. I thought, “Yes, that’s how it is with Dawn. Having Dawn has informed every minute of my life since she was born.”

I see her most every week. Mother doesn’t always go now since she has gotten older and finds it difficult to walk. Mostly, when she goes we take Mother’s wheelchair, which gives me two people to care for and we are basically stuck in Dawn’s room.

The worst part about Dawn’s situation, and I don’t even know when it began, is that she repeats the same few phrases over and over again.

“When’s Thanksgiving?” times 50. “We got a Michael” times 50 every time she hears the name “Michael” or “Mark” or anybody.

It’s almost impossible to get her to stop unless you threaten her with putting her out in the hallway or something. (What kind of mother does that to a disabled child?) Mother has even less patience than I have and talks terribly to her, but Dawn doesn’t seem to realize it and still adores Mother.

I tell people that this is my worst problem and most of them just laugh like it’s funny. So mostly I just hush. I wish I had a counselor to talk to, but it’s too much money.

I’ll stop talking about Dawn now because it’s making me cry.

One good thing that has happened during this five-year period is that I got to quit teaching at Danville Community College when my Uncle Alvin died in 2014 and left Paulette and me some money. David and I used it to pay off the mortgage, so I no longer had

to work and do that. I am grateful for that every single day. Every time I drive by DCC, I say, “I am so thankful I don’t have to teach there anymore.” It was so hard dealing with those bad-attitude students who didn’t care a bit about the three proper uses of a semi-colon.

I’m now only working very part-time for the Register & Bee and have told my editor Charles Wilborn that I will retire for good at the end of the year, but he doesn’t believe me. He says that I’ve said that before and haven’t, but I’ve really just been warning him for a year. I plan on continuing my 7XMOM column for as long as I have an idea a week.

My column is a testimony of the Holy Spirit to me because, even though I feel like I’m not inspired much in my everyday life, I always have one idea and only one idea a week for my column, two if I’m going out of town or Dawn is having surgery, which can only be from God.

One of the hardest thing to happen this past five years—it was the hardest until Mark and Jill’s baby was stillborn— was Dawn’s being in ICU and on a ventilator for five days last year in 2017. She had a blocked ureter from a kidney stone—the first time we knew she had kidney stones—and had surgery on the night of April 9. I remember that well because David, Paulette and I were at Mother’s house for her birthday when I got the call that she was being taken to the ER for seizures and a fever. I had no idea how bad off she was and waited about a half an hour before making the decision to head for

Richmond.

Luckily Jane was able to go to the ER and stay with her until we could get there. Dawn had the surgery, and it was successful so we left the recovery room late that night to go to the guest house at The Virginia Home. I woke up in the middle of the night about three or four and no one answered in the recovery room, so I went back to bed until calling at 6 a.m. and found out Dawn had gone septic and had been put on a ventilator. She was out of it for the next five days. Toward the end she got so bloated that her skin was tight and her hands were curled. It was awful.

But she gradually got better, and the people in ICU and the other floor were wonderful. I hope and pray I never have to be in the hospital with Dawn again. Those times are truly my Gethsemanes. I'm so far away from home and usually by myself.

The bad thing about Dawn is that she is either really sick and out of it, or she is recovering and talking non-stop or mad and uncooperative. It's just awful whatever the situation. I can't even read a book and escape because I just can't concentrate. I usually just sit and pray or cry.

I suppose I'm strong. I don't know. Most of the time I try to decide if I have faith because I trust that Heavenly Father is taking care of her in Richmond or if I'm just a terrible mother for putting her there. She is as happy as she can be, I suppose, but I'm sure she'd prefer to be home.

She went back to the hospital a couple of months later for another bout of kidney stones and sepsis for several days and back to ICU, but not quite as bad off. Still a terrible

time, though.

Her kidney stones have ruled our lives the past 16 months, but at the time of this writing—Sept. 2, 2018—I think the stones are gone. She had lithotripsy two weeks ago and the doctor thinks they got the last two in her kidneys. Her bowels were so clogged, though, that he couldn't get a clear picture and will repeat the x-rays in a month. But now getting her bladder to work correctly is a problem and her having to be straight cathed has caused me agony. I finally called last night and invoked my medical guardianship for them to stop cathing her unless she hadn't emptied her bladder. It's all complicated.

I'm still continuing to make almost weekly trips to visit Dawn. She had a bad year last year with kidney stones and wound up in ICU two different times. What a nightmare those days were! She will be 45 this year and is relatively happy at The Virginia Home. The trips have gotten harder the past few years because Mother had gotten older and feebler. She now can barely walk, so we take a wheelchair to get her into TVH and then are pretty limited to what we can do and where we can go.

I can't believe that I am 65 and still struggling daily in pain and sorrow about Dawn. I just hope and pray that I will have a little bit of my life without this burden. And maybe it's because I feel that way that it hasn't been lifted from me yet.

I hope the stones are gone though and we can go back on a cruise next year! I just can't go so far away I can't get home quickly. I was in the middle of the Tulsa Zoo in Oklahoma while visiting Mark and Jill in May this year (2018) when I got a call from

Dawn's doctor that they were sending her to the ER for a suspected kidney stone problem.

It was my worst nightmare come true. I was flying out the next day anyway, but I changed my ticket to fly into Richmond and David picked me up there and we went to St. Mary's hospital where Jane had been with her the day before and since that morning.

Dawn was lying there soaking wet and hadn't had anything to eat for almost 24 hours. The doctors had been focused on the seizures instead of the kidney stones and they hadn't fed her anything since they were afraid of her choking. It was basically the situation I have prayed for every day for years wouldn't happen. I'm not sure why that prayer wasn't answered. I am left to bow my head and say "yes."

The second worst thing than Dawn being on a ventilator in ICU, or perhaps the worst thing since there was no recovery from it, that has happened the past five years is Mark and Jill losing their baby boy, Nicholas Ethan Andrew, in a stillborn birth this summer. Just so sad. But I am so proud of them for the way they handled the situation so bravely and courageously and choosing faith and obedience in the face of unspeakable sorrow. So sad.

Jill had gone for a doctor's appointment on a Friday I believe and was showing signs of pre-eclampsia. They almost hospitalized her then, but told her to come back on Monday. But on Monday there was no heartbeat. So, so sad.

Within a 24 hour period on June 18, I found out that a grand-daughter had run away (she was found later in the middle of the night), that baby Nicholas had died, and that Mark E. accepted a plea deal and would be going off to prison. Mother and I were in Richmond for the final two things and I just had to leave early to head home. I was too sad to be there with Dawn.

I think the baby dying was the saddest thing to happen in the last five years, maybe in my whole life. Dawn is an ongoing sadness, but I know it will have an end eventually, or so I'm told. But Mark and Jill losing Nicholas was and is still so, so sad.

I still wonder why Dawn has to live so long and Mark and Jill's baby had to die. I suppose I will find out in the life after this one.

Five years ago Mary Susan was living in Texas and I was flying to visit her. I never really liked Texas much. I was afraid of tornadoes and it was beastly hot in the summer. Plus, lots of traffic. The house they lived in at first never seemed to cool off and the apartment they lived in next was far from any nature or park or anything. I was so glad when they moved from there, even though it meant they were going back to California for Tim to get another degree at Stanford.

I think I hated California worse than Texas, though. I've hated California since I lived there in the 1960s. When it came time for them to get a job, I so wanted them to come back East—why else did she marry someone from Virginia?!—but the choices came down to California or Utah and thankfully they moved to Utah where I enjoy visiting.

I actually spent my 65th birthday in Utah and Mary Susan had a party for me and baked me the most wonderful triple chocolate cake. Brady's family came over and then Brady stayed and Dennis and Tarin came over. We played some fun game on the TV with our phones and had a good time. Plus, I got lots of money to spend while I was out there and Amazon gift cards.

Before I went out to Utah, Jenny made me a luscious cake in Apex. That was a stressful week. Hurricane Florence was heading straight toward us just as Matt and Jenny needed to take Cameron out to BYU-Idaho. I had been supposed to go down to Apex and babysit with Ashlyne and Tyler but got a little scared and brought them back to Danville.

Luckily for us, not so much for North and South Carolina, Florence headed south then west and it basically skirted us. The plane going out to Utah was practically deserted on Sept. 27, however, since so many people had cancelled their flights because of Florence.

I stayed in Utah until Sept. 27. While I was gone, our cat, Frankie, got sick and had to be put to sleep. That was sad mostly for David. I didn't really like Frankie, mostly because I cleaned up his poop and vomit all the time and we weren't able to get new carpet without him destroying it. So I'm glad to be petless right now.

Five years ago Brady and Karissa were living in Chicago while he got an MBA at the University of Chicago, so I flew up there two or three times. Not a fan of big cities, but we got to do some cool things when visiting, like a boat tour down the Chicago River.

Then they moved to Arkansas where he went to work for Corporate Walmart in

2015, I think.

I liked them living just a couple of blocks from Mark and Jill. It was fun to be able to walk back and forth between the two families. But then the triplets were born in 2017 and they decided to move to Highland, Utah, to be close to Karissa's family for help. Brady got a job with Younique, a make-up company, in Lehi, so I see them when I got out to Utah.

Did I mention our family was blessed with triplets? Brady and Karissa have done a wonderful job on managing three babies. They spend about a month, I think, in the NICU, which was stressful, but everything is OK now. They are now 20 months old. Luke was a little late walking, but he's caught up now. They are absolutely adorable, as all my grandchildren are.

And Utah is also where Mary Susan and her family wound up. Tim works for Lucid, which invented some kind of cool spreadsheet and they live in Daybreak. They now have five children. Ali, their oldest, was baptized this year, and they have Parker, Charlotte, Emma, and the baby Bennett. It is a house of chaos but lots of fun when I am out there.

Dennis and Tarin moved during this time from Lehi to Eagle Mountain. Dennis is still with Novell, although it's been sold and I can never remember the new name, but they seem to be good to him.

The Clarks moved to Apex, NC, two years ago, which is a little closer than Fayetteville, but much harder to get to. I hate driving on highways. The Raleigh Temple

is closed right now for repair and renovations, but when it is open again next year, I got down there to the temple and then over to Jenny's about 15 minutes away. The road to the temple off of I-40 has 30-some stoplights, but it's familiar and slower, so I prefer to go that way.

Michael, Evelyn, and their son, McCoy, live in Durham where Michael now works for the Wildlife Resource Commission of North Carolina in downtown Raleigh and Evelyn is an immigration attorney in Durham. We see McCoy probably once a month because when he is a little sick or the daycare is closed, we meet them down in Hillsborough and babysit with him.

Mark and Jill still live in Arkansas where Mark works for Corporate Sam's Club and the twins are 5 years old. We love to go to Bentonville, Arkansas, to visit them. They built a huge house a couple of years ago, so there is plenty of room. They had hoped to fill it with children, but for some undiscernible reason by us mere mortals that wish and hope is being denied them.

More about our life

David and I have been on about four or five cruises, which are basically the highlights of our life together. So far we have traveled with the Clarks, who always seem to have money for cool vacations! And it was the day before we left on one of those down at Cape Kennedy that we were standing in line to get on a tour bus and David got a text from one of his friends at ABB saying that a bunch of the old-timers, including David, were being offered early retirement. The die was cast then, and it was a fast ride to

retirement about three months later.

David was thrilled to be retired. I guess that feeling was justified since he worked since graduating from college, totally 41 years with ABB-used-to-be-Westinghouse.

He had no desire to get a part-time job and didn't even worry about the money, even though we were going to live on at least \$30,000 less a year. I still worry about it. It has been very hard on me to get used to having someone home with me all the time, but I really think David has absolutely no idea that it has been. He's very good about giving me my space and entertaining himself, and of course, he is always content . . . unless his son is on the way to jail.

I'm still working very part time for the Register & Bee. I keep hoping to be able to retire too, but our money situation has been a little tenuous since Mark Elzey's life fell apart and cost us about \$40,000, and I like to have money to take to spend when I visit my grandchildren.

In an update in October, I have decided that the story I am doing about the 1968 George Washington High School state championship football team will be my last. I just finished some stories about veterans for the November SoVa Living and as soon as I get up the nerve to ruin Charles's day, I'm going to tell him that, except for my column, I'm going to quit writing for the paper.

End of the year: I got up enough nerve and told Charles I would continue to do my column for as long as I had an idea, but that's all I would do. He wasn't very happy. And so I went quietly into the sunset as a reporter. It was my dream and goal since I was

a little girl, so the Lord blessed me that I could get a journalism degree and then that I could work 15 years as a reporter. I have loved it and am eternally grateful for that chance. I have so many memories of stories here in the community: stories of heartache and happiness, murders and musicals, education and medicine. Most every place I go to in the city has a memory of being there for a story. As far as the murders, there used to be a joke around the newsroom that every night I was on the cops beat, there was a homicide or some other kind of crises—a fire or the front of a church falling down.

Here are some lists at the age of 65:

What I enjoy doing:

Reading good books

Serving in the Church, especially ministering one on one to sisters in need

Keeping my house neat and clean (my patriarchal blessing tells me that my greatest joys will come from being a homemaker)

Seeing my children and grandchildren

Cooking and baking (Now that I am catless I think I am going to start selling bread)

Painting pretty pictures (I've really just done one with Jenny and several people have given me lots of art supplies, but I just don't have the time to do it yet.)

Shopping

Writing my column (I plan on retiring from writing for the paper after I finish the four stories I am working on, but will do my column as long as the paper wants me to and I have an idea.)

Watching good TV shows

What I feel like I'm good at:

Taking care of people (Sometimes I feel like everyone is sucking the life out of me, but I think I'm good in that role.)

Cooking

Organization

Writing, except getting novels published and selling thousands of copies, but I'm an awesome reporter, so maybe I should be happy for that.

Teaching at church, but I don't really enjoy it.

Being a mother and grandmother. I'd be even better if any of my kids lived closer. I would love to be able to go to ball games and school assemblies like my mother always did.

Enduring. My trips to Richmond are endless.

I think I'm a pretty good Relief Society president. At least the couple of sisters who have gotten mad at me have gotten mad at other people also, so I'm not going to worry too much. It's been interesting . . .

My main challenges to overcome:

I'm afraid of everything and according to the scriptures and talks by the General Authorities, I'm not supposed to be. I don't know if it's a physical malady related to depression and anxiety, but I fight fear all the time. I'm especially afraid of dying or not dying for a while and getting old. I'm just ready for the Second Coming so I can skip all that.

Trusting my future and Dawn's to the Lord.

Feeling the Holy Spirit. Or maybe I'm good at this. I don't know. Mary McCann (Elder Holland's daughter) told me once that I needed to go into a bar and feel what it's like to be without the Holy Spirit, so I'll recognize I have Him with me all the time.

I've had a couple of blessings lately that have told me to be kind to my husband, so maybe I need to work on that. I thought I was kind to him. . .

Wondering if I made a mistake marrying someone who does not share my religion. If David joins the Church one day, I'll know it was OK. Pres. Mitch Scott said it was okay. But it is incredible hard and sad not to share the most wonderful part of your life with your spouse.

Worrying about Dawn. But I doubt I'll ever overcome that.

Facing more trips to Richmond. I estimate I've driven back and forth there 800 times in 20 years. That's a lot of biscuits and Diet Cokes/Dr. Peppers.

What I still want to do in life:

Live near some of my children and grandchildren so that I can go to ball games and concerts, etc., all those things my parents did for my children so routinely.

Probably too late for this, but I'd still like to make lots of money writing a wonderful book.

Travel to England and Hawaii without drowning from a plane crash over the ocean. I won't go so far away though unless I don't have Dawn to worry about.

Not have to worry about my weight. Fat chance of that happening. Pun intended.

Live close to some of my kids without an interstate highway being involved.

Live in a newer, nicer house. But I love my house and property, so I'm somewhat conflicted on this.

Have a whole wardrobe of pretty clothes.

Be happy and not sad all the time.

Learn to play the piano well enough to play a hymn at church. (I started piano lessons in October.)

Get a PhD free and without much work. Doubt that will happen until maybe the Millenium.

Becoming a painter, as in an artist, not a house painter.

Become a temple worker in a bigger temple that doesn't give me claustrophobia.

In conclusion for this five-year period, I looked back through my timeline on

Facebook for the last five years of my life and saw a lot of holding grandbabies and being with grandchildren, always my favorite thing to do. I saw that I went to the First Presidency Christmas Devotional in 2016 with Mary Susan. That was awesome! She got tickets for seats up close from her friend whose father is a Seventy. Then David and I went to the Tabernacle Choir Christmas Concert featuring Kristen Chenoweth on Dec. 14, 2018. We went with Dennis, Tarin, and their girls and Tim and Mary Susan. It was awesome!

We've had lots of babies the past five years—Mark and Jill's twins, Brady and Karissa's triplets, Mary Susan and Tim's three youngest, and Michael and Evelyn's McCoy. I think we're slowing down on babies or maybe even finished. I wish a miracle would bring a baby to Mark and Jill and Michael and Evelyn are still in the possible running, but for the first time in maybe 18 years, no one is pregnant right now. At least I don't know about it! Cameron is in college. I am old.

I just took Dawn back to the urologist for a checkup yesterday and she seems to be doing much better. Her wonderful, kind, gentle doctor, Dr. Deorah, keeps saying she is asymptomatic but agrees with me that she can go from asymptomatic to ICU very quickly.

He said he would see her back in a year, then seeing my face, said six months. Then he said they would do an x-ray and then when I asked for a c-scan, he said he would do whatever I wanted him to do. I opted for the clear c-scan. But hopefully the two stones he thought he saw last time will either pass without incident or remain where they are without problems.

Update on that: Dawn's weight dropped, her calcium level in her blood went up, and she wasn't feeling well, so the doctor at TVH took her off the anti-kidney-stones medication. Her weight has dropped to 78 pounds. She's eating a little better on this the last day of 2018, but now we can worry about the formation of kidney stones again.

On to 2019 and the five years leading to being 70. That whole idea is scary!

Here is my scripture, though, to get me through 2019 with a goal to trust the Lord more.

It's 2 Nephi 22:2-3: "Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust and not be afraid; for the Lord Jehovah is my strength and my song; he has also become my salvation.

Therefore, with joy shall ye draw water out of the wells of salvation."

I've got to close this update eventually, so I'm signing out on Jan. 1, 2019. It's also my 21st wedding anniversary.

Time Flies: Five Years Later and Being 70

I can't believe I'm turning 70 in a few weeks. It's so old. On New Year's Day the year I turned 55, which must have been 2008, I woke up to a dream that I was speeding around a corner, I guess in a car, and suddenly I crashed, and a blinding light surrounded me. I woke up, but was afraid to open my eyes because I didn't know if I was dead or alive. When I finally opened them to find out I was alive, I was terrified of really dying and of my 70th birthday being only 15 years away. I have thought about that every day since that dream. And then it came.

There followed a real crisis of faith where I questioned everything I believed. But

I kept on living the gospel the best I could and holding to the iron rod while I floundered, and eventually I got better. I can bear testimony now of the truthfulness of the restored gospel and all it involves.

These last five years have probably been five of the toughest years of my life. You think after your kids are grown, your house is paid for, and you have (mostly) retired that your life will be less stressful and more enjoyable. That didn't happen for me at least. The last five years have been a time of profound loss. I just hope I'm a better person for it.

The summer before I turned 65 was hard because Mark and Jill lost their baby Nicholas in a still-born birth, and Mark Elzey went to prison, but that was just the beginning.

Dawn continued to be troubled with kidney stones that resulted in several surgeries, procedures, and hospitalizations. I had to leave and come home early from a couple of trips because she had been taken to the hospital. These were difficult times, but through it all I felt like the Lord was helping me. The biggest reason and miracle was that Dawn did not feel a moment's pain from her kidney stones. She must have passed 25 of them and never complained a single time about pain. A little hangnail would totally put her over the edge until it was taken care of, but the kidney stones didn't. She would get sick, need surgery, and recover, but never complain about pain.

One time I took her to see Dr. Deorah—her urologist I loved—and he called me back to a room where two x-rays of Dawn's kidneys were hanging. He showed me the first one that showed several stones and then the next one that just showed a couple of

them.

“Where did they go?” he asked. “Where did they go?”

I just shrugged my shoulders and said, “I guess God took them away.”

So Dawn’s health continued to be a problem throughout 2019 to 2021 until her death in February 2021.

I also lost two good friends during this time. My good friend since 1989, Joan Bagley died on Aug. 10, 2019. I didn’t even know she was dying until the last few days of her life. I will always be bothered that her sons didn’t call me until the very end. I had visited with her in her townhome in Greensboro and couple of months before and had a nice visit. I took her some sourdough bread, and she had baked me some of her cinnamon bread I loved. We talked about life and the gospel and kids and marriages, as we usually did. She and Grant had moved to Greensboro a couple of years before to be close to her sons and have their help.

Grant continued to be in bad health, and Joan’s health wasn’t too good either. She had had a spinal fusion a couple of years before and continuing back problems. When we visited, Grant was in rehab after some health problems, so she was by herself. I remember asking her if she wanted to be married to Grant for eternity, and she said, “Not the way he is now.” We had a long and sweet visit, and I had no idea it would be the last time I saw her. I gave the obituary at her funeral here at church and got to say a lot of nice things about her.

In an unexpected turn of events, Grant passed away from a massive heart attack

while in the temple for one of his grand-daughter's weddings in December of 2020. In the temple!! What an amazing place to die. I must admit that my first thought upon hearing that from a text from one of his sons was "Oh my, poor Joan. Now she's got to deal with Grant again." (He didn't treat her very nicely on earth.)

The temple – what a wonderful place to leave this life!

I lost another friend through several strokes that caused severe dementia. She is still alive in a nursing home in Richmond, but doesn't know who I am anymore. It is Delmar Selden, the mother of one of The Virginia Home residents, Billy Shakespeare. She and I were such good friends and saw each other most every time I was in Richmond and then on Facebook. We knew the struggles of being mothers to disabled children, and she gave me strength. She also worked for many years as the TVH receptionist and kept an eye on Dawn when I wasn't there. We messaged a lot on Facebook, and her loving, supportive messages pop up regularly to bring her back to my mind. She is living her nightmare—her son Billy still alive but her unable to care for him. At least with the dementia she is not fully aware of her situation.

For 2018 and most of 2019 I remained Relief Society president. (I think I was called in 2015.) I loved that calling! I loved being able to minister to sisters and their families one on one. And I think I was pretty good at it. It seemed to call upon everything I have learned my whole life. There was always some different need to respond to, and I always seemed to know what to do about people's problems. It wasn't me, though, figuring it out. It was the Lord helping me love and help his sisters.

Fulfilling that calling seemed to be a culmination of everything I have ever learned and the qualities I have acquired. It required a massive amount of multitasking, ministering in love, caring for sisters, organizing, being creative, teaching, being smart, and every other good quality I may have.

But the end of November 2019 I was released, and I didn't want to be. The bishop told me the stake president had told him not to let me remain so long as president since it was a hard calling. But the stake president told Paulette he didn't remember saying that. I had little choice but to bow my head and obey. I've missed being Relief Society president every day since then. I went right on to be the activity days leader, a new calling at that time, and I'm not sure I did that great of a job.

I think I've had five callings since then. Right now I have a stake calling on the stake communication council, I'm still the ward historian, and I'm the building coordinator, which I enjoy. The crochety old women of the ward usually get that calling. Just saying'.

Right after that release, Covid hit and turned life around the world upside down. Dawn had a supra-pubic catheter inserted in January of 2020, I believe, which was quite upsetting to me. The alternative was to have her catheterized several times a day, which was also upsetting to me.

Then we went on a cruise in February. We were out on the water when the cruise ship with Covid patients was on its way over from China.

To me, the Covid pandemic will always mean my 11-month separation from

Dawn. I was with her at TVH the day in March 2020 the nursing homes were shut down to visitors and told to leave by some young, snippy CNA. I left tearfully and remained tearful for the next 11 months. Being separated from Dawn was excruciating. I cried all but five or six days of that time period. I would collapse in tears, pray and beg the Lord to help us, get up off my knees with enough strength for the next four or five hours, and then repeat the process. After a while, TVH set up video calling and I was able to facetime her five times a week, which was its own kind of hell, trying to think of things to say to her as she repeated herself over and over.

A few months in, she developed a horrible, deep bedsore on her tailbone and was then confined to her bed for months, an even worse torture for me, thinking of her alone in her room in her bed for who knows how long at a time. I think she handled it better than I did. To summarize, she eventually stopped eating and began to fall asleep when I would call her. One day in February 2021 when I was in Arkansas, the Spirit witnessed to me that she was dying. I called the doctor and told her, and she called back and said she believed I was right. I was allowed to stay with her the last five days of her life until she passed away early in the morning on Feb. 24, 2021.

I have detailed these months in a manuscript named “Being Dawn’s Mom complete” in my Manuscripts folder in Dropbox.

After Dawn’s death for which the Lord gave me strength to endure, Mother’s dementia got progressively worse until I was going over twice a day to check on her, Paulette called her throughout the day and visited, she had a Med-Alert (a constant

struggle to get her to wear the durn thing), she had a camera in her living room, and we paid several different people to check on her. The only reason we continued to let her live alone was that she was comfortable and could function in her own home where everything was familiar. We knew we were one incident away from a nursing home or coming to live with me, although with my bad back and arthritic hands, I didn't think I could care for her. This was a very frustrating time trying to deal her, and her not eating, and not changing her clothes, and not bathing, and her changing the input on her TV remote, the worst thing of all.

That incident happened in August 2022 when she developed a perforated ulcer from taking her arthritis medicine, Meloxicam, on an empty stomach every morning. (And I warned her about that every morning when I went over and she had taken her meds, but not eaten anything.) She had surgery in the middle of the night to repair it and stayed in the hospital for a week.

But she had forgotten how to walk and her dementia had gotten worse. She, in fact, pulled her NG tube and two IVs during one night. The doctor agreed to send her to rehab at Piney Forest Healthcare and Rehab where she had been content before when she broke her femur 10 years ago. But at Piney Forest she was extremely resistant to therapy, refusing it or not cooperating. Obviously, she never got better and before her 100 days of Medicare coverage were up, she was kicked off of Medicare.

Basically she was bedridden and perfectly happy. Some days she didn't even realize where she was—she thought she was doing the night shift at the shelter and kept

getting mad because she was alone. The staff loved her though! She would scream to make them think they were hurting her and then just laugh. But they thought she was so sweet and funny! She had an around-the-clock audience.

Nine months into her stay, though, she started vomiting blood. Although an x-ray didn't show anything, the doctor felt like she had another ulcer. Then she stopped eating for the fear of throwing up. We figured the end was near.

On May 4, Harper and Kathy came down to visit her, Jenny came up from NC, and I stayed most of the day. Her good friend, Joyce Underwood, also came and had a nice day. Mother and Harper had a wonderful visit, looking at old pictures and reminiscing. Paulette and Jenny went over that evening and as they left, the nurse was getting ready to give her a pain pill to help her sleep. Then a call came at 2:30 in the morning that she had passed away in her sleep. Apparently the last words she said were to a nurse and were, "I think it's time to go meet Jesus." That was weird for her to say.

I had taken her a bag of potato chips from my lunch out with Jenny, Harper, and Kathy, and she had eaten four of them that afternoon and said she couldn't eat anymore. But when Jenny, Paulette, and I went to the nursing home after the call in the middle of the night, there was the empty bag of chips on her table. She had had a wonderful last day on earth and eaten a last meal of her favorite foods. She went out on her terms. As Daddy used to call her—she was a fireball.

One of the most difficult things that happened during the last five years was the heartbreak of having two of my sons leave the Church. I always thought that having six

other children who went on missions (the boys), got married in the temple, and remained active and faithful was a compensatory blessing for all of Dawn's problems, but I guess I was wrong. It has broken my heart for both them and their children who will not know the blessings of the restored gospel. But I pray for them constantly and have fasted several times. There continues to be hope that they one day will remember their testimonies, and I cling to that.

One more hard thing during these years was Mary Susan and her family moved to Portugal. We got to babysit their beautiful golden retriever, Harley, and enjoyed that. The left August 1, 2022, and hopefully will return next summer, which was the original plan. We are going to visit next month for Thanksgiving. Somehow I will squelch my fear of flying over vast bodies of water.

Some good things happened during this time period too. Paulette and I were able to attend the rededication of the Raleigh Temple and actually be inside. Pres. Keith Hiatt had two tickets to give to two lucky souls, and he chose us! It was wonderful being inside and especially being able to meet Pres. Ballard and shake his hand as we walked out of the temple! Then there was some rude sister who called out from the line, "We love you, Pres. Ballard!" Yes, it was me, and I just couldn't help it. I've always loved him and all of his talks. That day was Sunday, Oct. 1, 2019. We drove to Matt and Jenny's afterward, and ate dinner with them and Michael and Evelyn and family.

I continued to write my weekly 7XMOM column, even though the end of 2022 I bowed out of writing any other stories for the paper. Then the summer of 2023, the

freelance budget was frozen, supposedly until October, my column disappeared too. At the time of this writing—Sept. 2023—I still have not heard whether the freelance budget will be back or if my column will be resurrected. I wouldn't be upset if it wasn't. I've written at least 800 of them, so that's been a good part of my life.

This last five years has also been full of many trips to visit children and grandchildren, many of which are recorded in my Facebook social books on the bottom shelf of the little black bookcase in my office / Dawn's room.

One of the most fun times ever was a cruise the summer of 2023. I had started asking the summer of 2021 if everyone would go on a family cruise to celebrate my upcoming 70th (gasp!) birthday. As it turned out, I had four of my children (Jenny, Michael, Mark, Brady) and their children with me on the cruise out of Charleston, along with stepson Josh and his family and former sister-in-law and BFF Jane Pugh and one of her daughters, Jennifer and her family. The cruise had a few hiccups, but I thought it was a lot of fun and was so sorry to see it end. It remains a wonderful memory to me. I know everyone spent a ton of money to go, and I appreciate it. The kids bought me a Bosch mixer for my birthday, and I love it. It makes bread making much easier.

For my actual birthday, David and I were in Arkansas. My birthday celebrating had started in May when everyone was together for Mother's funeral and sang me Happy Birthday. Then there was the cruise. Then in Arkansas on Saturday we went to a BYU football game against the University of Arkansas, and we won! On Sunday, I got to attend a session of the dedication of the Arkansas temple, which was awesome. We also got to

see Faith cheer in a junior high football game, and the next day we went to the Bentonville High School game. We ended with one of Dean's baseball games the evening before we left to drive back. All in all, if I had to turn 70, it was a fun way to do it!

On to the next five years: I hope at that time perhaps I live closer to some of my kids and grandkids somehow, I haven't gotten fat, and I have overcome my fear of dying. It would be nice to publish another book too.